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WHAT IF?

John Bischoff's journey from farm boy to fighter pilot

Carol Bischoff

Mother mentioned that she may not get any applesauce this year. My, if I only had such problems – instead of worring whether or not I'll be alive until tonight – or tomorrow night. But such is the perspective of war, I guess. When each day you hang on a fine line between life & death (and see some of your buddies go both ways), then all other problems seem small in comparison. And you don't have to tell me about loss rates or what the papers say. Because I sit in my airplane right next to them and watch theirs explode & mine fly home. Hell of a deal to experience.

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John Bischoff, letter to his sister, May 7, 1967

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Foreword

As I read through John's letters from nearly 50 years ago, so many memories come back. Not just of him as a young adult, which he was when he died at age 25, but those younger years, that we shared in growing up on the farm. My hope is that as I write about them, it will trigger even more memories and feelings of my very special big brother who was taken much too young from the great life he was living. Okay, that's a judgment where I'm telling God that she made a mistake in taking him so soon. I guess I think I'm allowed to make that judgment, even though on the other hand, I believe that God doesn't make mistakes; it just seems that way sometimes. Even when we don't understand nearly fifty years later what good came from his early death.

This book is a collage of sorts, compiling John's letters to my parents and to me sent between November 1962 and June 1967, interspersed with my own memories of John, family photographs, and primary source documents related to his experiences. All of John's letters are presented in chronological order, with the exception of two "Christmas letters" he sent in 1965 and 1966. Here is John in his own words, explaining the purpose of those letters:

This letter is a first. The year just closing has been full of many "firsts" for me. It has been a good year and I want to share so much of it with so many of you that I decided to compose

a standard letter, attempting to be meaningful to all – from grandparents to fraternity brothers and pilot training classmates to old girlfriends, so bear with me on the generalities.

Because the Christmas letters include details spanning the whole year, I've chosen to present them throughout John's other letters where they help to add context.

John never addressed our parents directly in the letters he sent; all the letters he sent to me begin "Dear Carol"; all the other letters included here were sent to my parents and often begin with "Hello".

Carol Bischoff
Fort Myers, FL
February 2024

Editor's note

When my mother Carol was diagnosed with stage-4 liver cancer in April 2023 at age 77, one of the essential things she wanted to do before she died was to finish this book about her brother John. She had been working on it for many years, typing his letters and award citations, writing her commentary, and scanning photos to include: a real labor of love.

At the beginning of 2024, I decided to take on the project of preparing the book for publication. I thought the book would really benefit from the use of different fonts and indenting to indicate different voices, and I had the skills to make it happen. To that end, in this book:

- Carol's exposition is in a serif font.
- John's letters are in a sans-serif font.
- *Excerpts from John's Christmas letters are formatted like his other letters but in italics.*
- `Official reports and citations from the Air Force are indented in a fixed-width font.`
- Quotations from other sources are indented in the serif font.

Additionally, in several places scans of John's letters appear in his handwriting.

Over the winter of 2024, I took all of my mother's text and pictures and created a draft of the book you are holding, and sent it to my mother along with many questions and clarifications. During the spring, my mother read through that draft, answered the questions and made edits.



My parents looking at John's award citations in summer 2024

In the summer, my parents and I were together in Maine, and with my mother's input I put the book into its final form. In August, I photographed my mother holding the large picture of John for the author photo on the back cover. She looks vibrantly

alive in that photo, but just two months later she would be dead.

In September my mother's health took a turn for the worse, and it was a sprint to the finish to polish the book, create a cover, and have the books printed and shipped to her. In the end, we managed to get a copy of this finished book into her hands just a few weeks before she died, when she was in the hospital in her own final chapter.

After my mother's death in October 2024, I received a sheaf of John's letters from 1967, which my mother kept inside her bedside table in Florida. I scanned some of them so that John's handwriting would appear in this book. I also received the contents of my parents' fireproof safe, which contained John's reel-to-reel tapes, the ones he had sent to his parents when he recorded his voice instead of writing letters. These were my mother's most treasured possessions.

In 2026, I had all of John's tapes and slides digitized, and I added about a dozen of John's own pictures from Thailand, Vietnam and elsewhere to the book.

In her last days, eyes closed in her hospital bed, my mother eagerly listened on headphones to John's final tape, piping the recording of his voice from 1967 into her ears. John was never far from her mind, and I am grateful that she knew that she had succeeded in preserving his memory for the next generation.

Diana Davis
Exeter, NH
September 2026

Introduction

John William Bischoff
January 6, 1942 – August 3, 1967

It has taken me several years to get started on writing some family history about my brother John. I have found myself somewhat overwhelmed to write about John; he was an amazing young man and my role model in so many ways. Since he was four years ahead of me in school and we had a distinctive last name, I was always known in schools as John's little sister. This was true not only when I went to Tecumseh High School with only 160 kids in the whole high school, but more surprisingly at the 10,000-student University of Nebraska in Lincoln as well. John had been a campus leader and was well known in many circles, both student and administrative. Fortunately he had been a very positive force on the campus and thus I inherited some positive attitudes even before people really knew me. I was fortunate to be his younger sister in many ways, and in many respects, it has taken me years to more fully appreciate him and the influence he had on me.

Highlights of John's year of 1966 as reflected in his (last) holiday letter:

I flew a couple more Embassy Flights. The round-the-world trips. The second week in January our airplane broke down at Madrid, Spain for three days. I enjoyed seeing much of that grand old city both by day and by night. The last week

of February saw us depart McGuire AFB, New Jersey on an Eastbound Embassy Flight. After ten stops (three to sleep) and 55 hours flying time, we arrived from the west 103 ½ hours elapsed time after departure. Anytime anybody tells you that they circled the globe in four days and stopped ten times—don't let them tell you it wasn't a rushed trip!

On July 26, A Day That Will Live In Infamy, I was notified that I had been ordered to fly an F-105 in Southeast Asia. So I packed up and went back to New Jersey the same day. I went on one last trip to do some shopping in the Orient- then to Fairchild AFB in Spokane, Washington for a three-week survival school.

Shortly after the first of February I will finish my school at McConnell, go to a week of Jungle Survival School in the Philippines, and then begin my year combat tour in Southeast Asia. Decisions made by diplomats, politicians and world leaders will rather directly affect my activities during the year '67. Even if the US ceases to bomb North Vietnam, I will still be busy somewhere else in the area. Probably only a complete cease-fire (unlikely in my opinion) would greatly alter the role of the F-105 in that part of the world. So I close this year involved with an airplane that is fun to fly, an assignment that I did not want or volunteer for, and a combat tour that I enter with mixed emotions.

And thus ended the last Christmas letter that John would write.

In the audio tape he made for us in March 1967, he seemed a bit more upbeat:

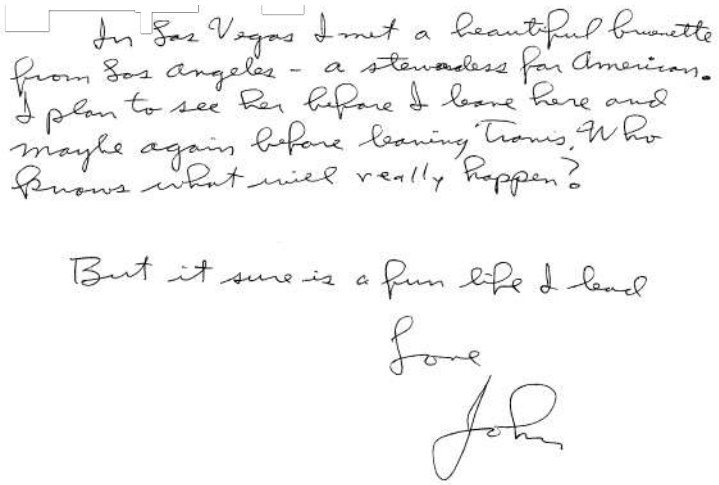
> And then came the 105, and the assignment and the training, and going off to combat and the war, and that's all as it should be. Someone has to do it and I was glad to do my part. I was very much interested in the airplane and all the things associated with it. I didn't go reluctantly, I did not go reluctantly, even though I didn't volunteer; after I got involved

> I really liked the airplane and I'm very happy with what I've been doing.

In January of 1967, the beginning of what would be his last year, he wrote:

In Las Vegas I met a beautiful brunette from Los Angeles – a stewardess for American. I plan to see her before I leave here and maybe again before leaving Travis. Who knows what will REALLY happen?

But it sure is a fun life I lead.



Early life

John was born January 6, 1942 at the Tecumseh, Nebraska hospital. This was just one month after the Pearl Harbor bombing and this affected his young upbringing in several ways. My mother always said that due to the rationing during World War II, she used very little sugar in canning and desserts, and thus John didn't have a sweet tooth like I do. I was born in 1945 just after the war ended and sugar was more available and I do enjoy my sweets. In fact, I jokingly refer to desserts as my main course. My parents had married June 16, 1940 and John was a welcome start to their farm family. Most of their neighbors were also relatively young farmers also starting their families. As the first born, and a boy, John was very special.

John was very thoughtful of those of us who would be left behind if he became a casualty. He made two tapes before he left Nebraska for the last time in early March 1967, one in case he was Missing in Action-MIA (who to talk to and who NOT to talk to and more), and one in case he was Killed in Action. This is an incredible tape in which we now still have his voice, even though technology has changed from the 3" reel to reel tapes on which he recorded them. We've kept this personal sharing only within our immediate family for more than fifty years and this seems an appropriate time to finally share it. It's hard for me to imagine him making these tapes in his upstairs bedroom on the farm. In the tape he made for us in March 1967, in case he was Killed In Action he reflected:

> Childhood: very good, a lot of love. I was

> taught the virtues of hard work, thrift and very good traditional solid values of life. Lots of healthy outdoor exercise and lots of love from very appreciative parents. There's always something special about the first-born and I would imagine I was so, and it was reflected in my care, upbringing and so on.

Our dad was a farmer of 220 acres six miles southwest of Tecumseh in southeast Nebraska and John was raised in a pretty typical way for that time and place. Our mother was a stay at home mother who raised a big garden, had a thousand Rhode Island Red chickens from which she weekly sold the eggs to the produce station in town on Saturday nights. They also milked Granny. That was the only milk cow's name I remember, and she might have been the same cow during both of our childhoods. Granny was a good Holstein cow and gave enough milk, three to five gallons at each of the morning and evening milkings. We brought the milk to the house and then poured it into the cream separator, and the thick cream was collected during the week, and also sold to the produce station in town.



John with a 4-H calf

With the cream and egg money, farm wives went to the grocery store to get their weekly groceries and anything else they might need. If Mother wanted to make a new shirt or dress, the money also needed to cover the yard goods, pattern and thread. Of course she had been taught to sew as nearly all young women were in that day. It was a necessity. As an aside, my mother noted when she went to high school she had one dress that she wore every day to school, just like her classmates. This was 1928–1932, and the depression years meant they all coped with the bare basics. They were grateful to just be able to go to high school.

So John was raised in a typical farm home of the time, and learned all the details necessary to make the farm work. And work we did. My Uncle Eldon (Miller), my mother's brother, once said my dad was the hardest working farmer he knew, and he knew lots of them. Daddy worked so hard to make a living for his family. As the first born son, John was indoctrinated to the farm routines early on, and never forgot what it had taken for our parents to raise us and send us to college.

Unless you've grown up on a small farm, it's hard to imagine what a demanding life it is. Someone else who has been there and written about it said it this way:

> A farm is a manipulative creature. There is no such thing as finished. Work comes in a stream and has no end. There are only the things that must be done now and things that can be done later. The threat the farm has got on you, the one that keeps you running from can until can't, is this: do it now, or some living thing will suffer or die. It's blackmail, really.[1]

From John's audio tape:

> Grade School, very different from many grade schools in the country but a lot paid off, got good

[1] Kristen Kimball, *The Dirty Life: Memoir of Farming, Food and Love.*



John on his confirmation day

values, virtues that will show up later in life. And a lot of the basics that are very important, for which all the rest of the things are based upon; it was a very good experience in many, many respects.

District #49

John went to District #49, the one-room school house just a quarter mile east and then a mile north of our farm. District #49 school was all kids from the neighborhood and we all went to the same one-room schoolhouse that our father and

grandfather had gone to. For at least twenty years the rural school kids were in the same 4-H club together. Our parents all farmed land that was adjacent to one another and within a couple miles of one another so they often saw one another on their tractors or trucks. Everyone pretty much knew who was doing what farming and which fields they were working on. It was a true community with a real neighborly feel to it. And it was truly a community of friends when someone had a need. We were all part of the District #49 school and were a typical rural Nebraska community. It was a good place to grow up with solid mid-west values modeled by our friends and neighbors. When we competed at the Johnson County Fair and other events, we were the Maple Grove 49'ers and proud of it.



John with his 4-H ribbons, with Grand Champion and Reserve Champion steers at the Johnson County Fair

John and I had the same teacher, Mrs. Eva Hunt; she was John's teacher for his eight years at the school. He was alone in his grade all eight years (as was I). Fortunately she was a very good teacher of not only the basics, but was also a gifted artist and musician. This meant we would always start the day with the Pledge of Allegiance, and then sometimes she would play the piano and we would sing a variety of songs,



District 49 country school

or establish a "band." On these favorite days, we would get our choice of a musical instrument, drum, metal triangle, or for most of us, wooden sticks to keep time to the music while we marched around the perimeter of the inside of the school house in time to the music. We loved it. Can't you just see it all on a cold winter day when we'd all arrived with our four buckle overshoes and metal lunch pails, both of which stayed in the cold entrance hallway? All these overall-clad boys and girls with hand-me-down-jeans and Mother-made long-sleeve shirts, prancing around the schoolroom? It got us warmed up and taught us that exercise and moving was important, even if it was zero outside. The last hour on Friday afternoons was for art and Mrs. Hunt was truly gifted and creative, even if all her students (including John and I!) weren't. It was always our favorite period of the week. Mrs. Hunt's daughters were all equally gifted and one had a career with Hallmark cards.

My mother had a favorite memory of John's train set. He probably received it for Christmas in the late 1940's when he was 6 or 7 years old and I was about three. He was very happy with his new train set and track and he and our dad had set it up on the dining room floor so he could play with it regularly, in comfortable temperatures, close to the oil burner stove in that room and the wood cook stove in the nearby

kitchen. Upstairs in our bedrooms it would have been quite cool, sometimes downright cold, and certainly out of the way. This was a more fun place, even though it was sort of in the midst of lots of foot traffic. But it was a cool set and carefully laid out. Mother said I had been clearly told that I was never to walk ON the thin, metal tracks, but over them. I doubt that my weight at the time would have been harmful, but why tempt fate. She remembers that I was so cute when I always, very slowly and carefully, stepped OVER the tracks and never damaged them. I could be obedient and was.

The only boy living close in the neighborhood while John was growing up was Delmar Badertscher, who lived across the road and was three years older. Delmar went to Lewiston High School (about ten miles southwest of us) so their paths connected primarily in grade school, and later only in the neighborhood.

When I told Delmar Badertscher that I was putting together a book about John's life, Delmar reflected on their time together:

> Yes I grew up with your family and remember some things. Starting going with the same country school we walked many a mile to school and usually took a short cut walking through our field to the north to the half mile line. I do remember John was a smart student and one thing was when we we were sleigh riding east of the school and into the ditch and I believe it was John's wrist that was broken going down the creek bank.
>
> In those younger years we were in 4-H together, gave a presentation at the Johnson County Fair one year but I don't remember what it was about. There were a few times that we camped out in our front yard in the summertime.
>
> I guess we used to trap for opossum mostly, I believe and may have caught some skunks also. We got

much money for the pelts and maybe we sold the whole animal to Chet Hoke in Elk Creek for maybe a dollar.

We rode our bicycles a lot and went fishing some also. We used to walk a mile northeast over to Porter Dysart's pond and went fishing with our cane poles. The Dysarts had a pond that had bass in it and that was a big deal to catch the bass on a cane pole.

Hunting we did both for rabbits and for rats. I don't know how old I was at the time but I was too young to have a driver's license,[2] but we would take my Dad's '42 Ford in the wintertime and go around hunting for the rabbits that were in their hedge rows along the road at the time, using a spotlight to find them. Lots of fun that would maybe result in getting twenty rabbits. Then we cleaned them in the cellar at home. Seems that John didn't take many, or any rabbits home. After I got out of grade school and went to high school, I didn't see much of John through those years, although I did help your folks put up hay at different times.

After I got out of high school and went to Lewiston and not Tecumseh High School,[3] we got together when he was going with a very good looking girl from Crab Orchard who he met by probably going to the free movies they presented on Saturday night. I saw him a lot when he was dating Sara Boyden.

[2]When Delmar says he was too young to drive: he was born in 1940, so he was 12 when he drove them for hunting.

[3]The Lewiston managers came to the Badertscher home and recruited Delmar to go to Lewiston, about ten miles southwest of our farms. Delmar's older siblings had gone to Tecumseh, and apparently Lewiston needed more students. So the Lewiston school bus came to the top of our hill and picked up Delmar and went southwest, and the Tecumseh bus came to the same location and took John to Tecumseh to the northeast. John was the first student on the first bus route Tecumseh had. Jim Montz was the bus driver for many years.



John in high school years: left: our farm house south porch door to right; center: high school graduation picture; right: John and me on the east side of our farm house on my confirmation day.

I don't know the years but we would drink beer together and spent some time at dances, way too young to buy the booze. I had a few drag races in the 60's when he had his parents' 6-cylinder '57 Chevy 3-speed column shift. We used to race from the railroad tracks to the river bridge or from the Farris corner to the Golf Club. That old 6 cylinder was as fast for 200 feet or so and then slowed up.

As for your parents I can remember them as always on a very fast pace and very busy. Oh yes, we did shoot a lot of rats out of the chicken house at night and used to shoot starlings in the barns. I remember Lawrence Bischoff (John's grandfather) coming from town every day to help your dad. I knew Mary but not much about her and the same for the Miler

> grandparents.
>
> Seems as I knew the Gewekes better because I used to go squirrel hunting on their place.
>
> Oh yes, it must have been in the 50s when John wanted to play a game of poker. Seems we played for pennies and he won all the time. When we got done he showed me the marked card deck he had gotten. The design of cards were different markings and then you could identify the card numbers.
>
> As for Don and Ruth Buethe, I knew them but nothing what they were older than me so I never ran around with them.
>
> Probably a lot more that John and I did that I can't remember. Hopefully you'll receive much more information from the sources and the family history book will be very nice.
>
> Delmar[4]

During winter weekends I remember that they went hunting, hoping to get rabbits, coons, badgers or more likely, squirrels. They skinned some of their bounty (maybe coon, badger, or even a mink), and sold it to Chet Hoke in Steinauer. I'm sure they didn't make much money, but it was all part of the experience. And occasionally my mother fixed their rewards, fried squirrel. Yes, it tasted like chicken. One of my favorite photos from our childhood is a picture of John and me skinning a rabbit just west of our chicken house. He clearly is in charge but I'm sure my holding the animal so he could skin it felt like a very important role.

On cold winter nights John and Delmar would often go out to the chicken house and with gloved hands, surprise sparrows that were roosting under the outside eaves. While this sounds like a terrible brutal and thoughtless killing, I recall they often

[4]Delmar Badertscher died in Tecumseh in October 2016 at age 76.



John and me skinning a rabbit

weren't successful, but catching the birds was the major part of the sport. Poor cold birds just trying to stay warm!

But my most vivid memories were of their shooting rats under the chicken house. Yes, rats! For this you need to imagine a sub floor of the chicken house above irregular ground in the west part of the chicken house. There was a second chicken house, two steps down that housed another smaller group of chickens but they had the run of both sections. The chickens had all gone to sleep hours before, and John and Delmar would take their .22 rifles and go to the east section that had an opening under the flooring of the west section. This was maybe 12-18" high and under the chicken house, in that quiet peaceful place where hundreds of chickens were sleeping, there was lots of activity. There was an irregular stone foundation around the

exterior of the building; the rocks had been brought in from the farmland for the stable base of the wooden chicken house.

The boys would take their flashlights in this totally dark space and zillions of beady eyes would stare back. They were RATS!! The lights got the rats attention. The first time I saw this I could hardly believe that there were that many. Occasionally when we opened the ground feed door just inside the west door to the chicken house, I would see a big rat scamper out the back and over the top of the piled up feed. I guess I had imagined that a pair of rats, and maybe a couple babies were around somewhere, but hundreds? With the rats being startled by the bright flashlights, they ran in all directions, and John and Delmar shot at them. Thankfully the rats didn't run toward the small opening from which they had their flashlights, and their guns.

I guess my parents thought the risk was low, but me, being a more naturally anxious person, I was always afraid the bullets would ricochet off the rocks and return and hit one of them in the eye. I thought it was terribly dangerous, though exciting. When they shot at the rats, the noise was truly explosive in that relatively contained place. If I thought it was scary, what must it have been like for the rats? They scurried in every direction as fast as their little feet would take them. I don't remember John and Delmar ever actually killing any of the rats. It was sport for them. Amazingly, the chickens seemed to make little fuss about their middle of the night intrusion.

District #49 Students

When I was in country school, John was four years ahead of me, so he was already a big kid, and I saw him as one of the leaders. When I started school, he wasn't the oldest, of course, and looking back at school photos (all taken outside on the south side of the school house in bright sunshine, since we had no flash equipment back then), I see that there were several boys older than him. I recall Pat Mahoney and Wayne Badertscher as being the big boys. They were four or five years older than John.

Delmar Badertscher, who grew up across the road from us, and was Wayne's younger brother, was also in the school photo and was probably three years older than John. Their sister Ruth, who was my only playmate growing up, was a year younger than John and was three years older than me. The Badertschers had eight children, and these were the three youngest of the family.



Some of the students at District #49. John is front left, and the teacher, Mrs. Eva Hunt, is behind him.

My Big Brother

John was four years ahead of me throughout our school years so he was out of high school just as I entered. Those four years were perfect timing when we were growing up, at least most of the time. The fact that he had a good reputation both in our high school and at the much larger University of Nebraska, made it a very positive thing for me who also carried our pretty unique last name. So it was good following in his footsteps.

Much earlier memories, of when we were little kids on the farm, were a bit different. Since I was a much littler kid, and a girl, I was probably dominated by this much older brother.



The tractor we played with in the sandbox

I don't recall minding that he decided what to plant in our sand box fields, or how the imaginary crops would be cultivated and then harvested, just like our dad. But he did mind when I stepped on some field or carefully manicured rows he had created with our small size implements. I now treasure the sandbox-sized heavy steel green John Deere tractor with rubber tires that did all that farming!

Though my memories are foggy of our interactions, when I was less than five years old, I do recall several instances where he got mad at me and I had to run crying to the house for my mother to save me. Of course I was in no mortal danger, just dealing with an older brother who had ideas about the way things should be done. I remember my mother comforting me and distracting me with something in the house and then all was well. He really was a good, and very normal big brother.

Riding Bikes

John and I rode our bikes lots. I remember getting a new blue Schwinn bike for my birthday, and getting it early so I could ride it to school for the first day of school in early September, probably when I was 7 or 8. The road to school was hilly, but it was not quite uphill both ways!



A formal picture of John and me

We rode the quarter mile down hill to the east corner and turned north, left, to the dirt/mud road. This road was always wonderfully smooth since no one drove on it when it was muddy. Everyone knew better! It has a few small hills that are mostly down, then a longer hill up to the half-mile line. From there north to the school house corner, a whole half mile, it is downhill! What fun! We would pick up speed, put our heads down to the handle bars to decrease our wind resistance, and just fly to school. When we got to the corner we had to turn left, west, about a block up hill to the school house entrance, and more uphill to get to the trees where we parked our bikes. Of course no one would have thought about locking their bike. We didn't even know such things existed.



John and me on our bicycle and tricycle

We all put our bikes to the side of the school exercise equipment which we enjoyed at morning and afternoon recess and at lunch hour. All the pieces of playground equipment we had were made by our fathers. In addition to the swings by the boys' outhouse (fifty feet south of the girls' outhouse) I especially remember the hang-down-off-the-rings on another big elm tree just to the east side of the school driveway. This was probably created by attaching an old wheel rim to a big branch, and then attaching chains and bars so you could lift your feet and go around and around. These would all be items found on any farm and cost just the labor of our fathers. Our dad had one of the few welding machines in the neighborhood and often was able to create useful items from cast-offs. We

school kids spent hours on these rings since the chains were at different levels to make it easy for the little as well as big kids to grab on, pull their legs up to their chest, and swing in a circle. These rings and swings were under trees so it was sometimes cool when the sun was hot.

We also had a teeter totter made from a 4" × 12" × 16' plank that had been there for years and was weathered gray and had some splinters. But it was out in the sun, closer to the schoolhouse and the coal house. By the time we went to school there was no longer a coal stove, but a gas stove. But the coal house had all kinds of storage that didn't get used much. It was just a junky old open storage building. But we could hide in it for games.

Chapter 1

1962–1963

Letter to our parents from John, during the summer before he graduated from college, while he was in the summer ROTC program:

Tuesday AM
31 July 62

Hello–

Am in the hospital for physicals. Am on the end of a big line of other cadets. Almost the first chance to rest since arriving here. Sunday night I slept from 2:15 to 3:30. Up again to clean up room etc.

Three times a day we march 3/4 or 1 mile, one way to chow (meal). Sure do have sore feet. Is very hot here, but not too humid.

We are scheduled to get up at 4:55 Pacific daylight time. Also scheduled to go to bed at lights out (9 PM), but nobody does because we have so much to do. Took 1/2 or 3/4 hour to make the bed right so I sleep on top of it under the second blanket and just tighten it up in the morning.

Our Flight (24 men) Tactical officer, is very nice – firm, strict, follows the book and regulations – but very fair and is a good Air Force Officer.

We got a travel pay check for $67.30. Spent $14 for my share of gas. Not a bad deal at all.

Am looking forward to second weekend. We get to go into town from 1 pm. Saturday to 2 p.m. Sunday.

Must go in eye clinic now. Hope I pass everything

3:30 PM eyes are clear again after dilation.

The above scribble occurred when an officer walked in the room and we all snapped to attention. An every-other-minute occurrence.

We eat breakfast at 6:15, dinner at 12:01 and supper at 6:05. I was Flight Commander the first day and we were 5 minutes early to breakfast! yes, early! So this means 2 1/2 hours of marching Sat or Sunday afternoon. Lots of fun!

8 PM Wed eve.

Next free time, sorry this has turned out like a schedule. Got up at 2:30 this morning to clean the room. I dusted everything and took all the light fixtures apart to clean them.

We all sleep on top of our beds.

Our Officer in charge assigned speeches to everyone tonight. Since I did a good job as Flight Commander, the first 2 days, I am first and have to give a 50 minute speech this Friday morning at 10 on “WEAR OF THE UNIFORM.”

Got your letter today. Sure am glad to hear the home news. No papers, magazines, or radios here, so word from the outside world sure is welcome.

Sounds like a lot of people want to own a farm in SE Nebr. It might be all right but not at those prices.

About the typewriter!!! She doesn’t know how to use it. There is a small lever sticking out to the right under the right roller knob. It is not pulled all the way toward you when you unlocked it from being centered. Just pull it more towards you. Don’t feel bad. It happens to everyone who uses it.

Fell asleep in class today, but didn’t get caught!

Must close and polish shoes!

Love
John

6 Nov 1962

Well, it's been a great week, and especially a great weekend. You can look at the newspaper clippings from the Journal and see for yourself. I was Susie's escort at the rally where she was crowned Homecoming Queen. That night (Friday) we were both on the news reel at 10 PM, hugging each other in joy. I have many other things to tell you also. First in Homecoming Display, 3500 people at Homecoming Dance, a fun migration, etc. etc. Much, much to tell you. Will be coming home Saturday afternoon and taking Sara to dinner in Auburn on Saturday night. I have many wonderful things to tell you, but will save them 'til this weekend.

Love, John

P.S. It isn't every day I get a big picture on the front page of The Lincoln Journal.

John and Sara Boyden dated during high school, some of college, and remained friends. This homecoming was fall of his senior year of college at the University of Nebraska in Lincoln. John had joined the Presbyterian church during high school when our country church where he had been baptized and confirmed was destroyed by a tornado. Sara belonged to the Presbyterian church and they and other high school friends were mentored by the young and very dynamic minister, Rev. Don McCall. By 1967, when we asked him to be the minister for John's funeral, he had moved to another church and was unable to accept.

John's College Leadership

- President of Theta Xi social fraternity his junior year, a major honor and responsibility. He said in his final tape that he learned lots of leadership skills in this position, and it remained one of the highlights of his short life.

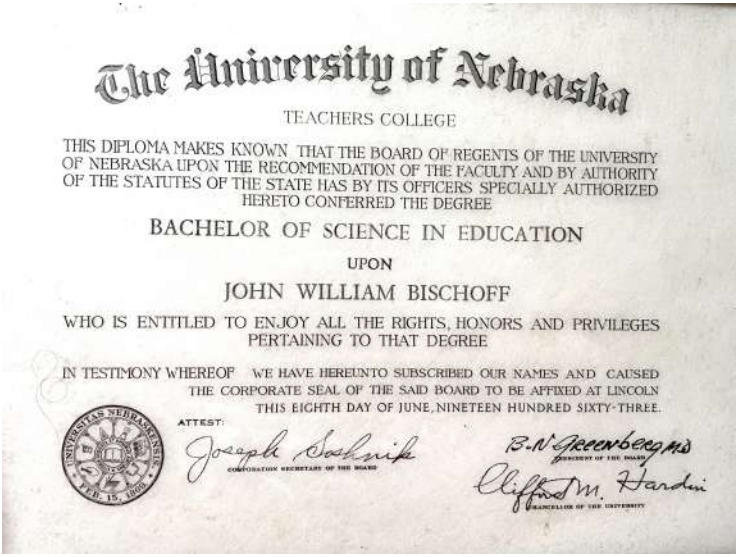
- Treasurer of Corn Cobs, the men's pep organization



The Theta Xi house at the University of Nebraska–Lincoln

- Section Editor of the Nebraska Cornhusker, the UNL yearbook
- President of Arnold Air Society

  The Arnold Air Society is a professional honorary service organization. AAS is open to officer candidates in Air Force Reserve Officer Training Corps and at the United States Air Force Academy, and is formally affiliated with the Air Force Association.
- Air Force Cadet Staff
- Regents Scholarship winner
- Graduated with distinction and received the Convair Award, both from the University's ROTC program
- Outstanding senior of his fraternity



The University of Nebraska

TEACHERS COLLEGE

THIS DIPLOMA MAKES KNOWN THAT THE BOARD OF REGENTS OF THE UNIVERSITY OF NEBRASKA UPON THE RECOMMENDATION OF THE FACULTY AND BY AUTHORITY OF THE STATUTES OF THE STATE HAS BY ITS OFFICERS SPECIALLY AUTHORIZED HERETO CONFERRED THE DEGREE

BACHELOR OF SCIENCE IN EDUCATION

UPON

JOHN WILLIAM BISCHOFF

WHO IS ENTITLED TO ENJOY ALL THE RIGHTS, HONORS AND PRIVILEGES PERTAINING TO THAT DEGREE

IN TESTIMONY WHEREOF WE HAVE HEREUNTO SUBSCRIBED OUR NAMES AND CAUSED THE CORPORATE SEAL OF THE SAID BOARD TO BE AFFIXED AT LINCOLN THIS EIGHTH DAY OF JUNE, NINETEEN HUNDRED SIXTY-THREE.

ATTEST:

Joseph Soshnik

CORPORATION SECRETARY OF THE BOARD

B. N. Greenberg MD

PRESIDENT OF THE BOARD

Clifford M. Hardin

CHANCELLOR OF THE UNIVERSITY

John's college diploma

After John's death, our parents created the CAPTAIN JOHN W. BISCHOFF MEMORIAL SCHOLARSHIP FUND at the University of Nebraska Foundation. Funds are annually awarded to members of Theta Xi fraternity and to graduates of Tecumseh High School who are starting their education at the University of Nebraska–Lincoln.

June 1963: Dad's first heart attack

When my dad had a heart attack and was hospitalized in June of 1963, all the neighborhood men came to help finish planting the crops, put up the alfalfa hay (cut, bale and store it in the barns), harvest the crops, and more. John and I were there to help since we were 17 and 22 years old, but the men in the neighborhood took the lead with the crops. We managed the cattle and hog operations.

To give you an idea of what running the farm operation

involved, and what John helped do for those busy weeks in June, the following is more of what really happened.

It was Sunday, June 16th, 1963 (coincidentally my parents' 23rd wedding anniversary) when my dad had his first heart attack, except he didn't know he'd had a heart attack. He and my mother were loading the big grinder mixer with large scoopfuls of ear corn, When the grinder was filled and thoroughly mixed, my dad would drive the grinder/mixer along the cement bottom feed bunks with 3" metal pipes to hold the cattle back, that my dad designed and I helped build. Then our 200 feeder cattle would come to the bunks for their morning meal. While scooping the corn that morning my Dad had told Mother he didn't feel so good, but of course they finished the job and he fed the cattle.

That Sunday 6/16/63 was also the Sunday afternoon that John flew a single engine plane from Lincoln to Tecumseh. He graduated from the University that June and had taken Air Force ROTC and learned to fly, had his license, and loved it. He flew the plane down so all four of us could go for a plane ride and see our farm from the air, a first for all of us. None of us had ever flown before. After the morning incident scooping corn, Daddy didn't feel quite right so he didn't go up in the airplane, but Mother and I did and we loved it. It was very special having John fly us, and I'm sure he was proud to show off a bit of his new skills, and something he really loved doing.

Because Daddy still wasn't feeling so good, he decided not to go, but my Mother and I went up and marveled at the views of the farm. It looked so different from a couple thousand feet up. We enjoyed the ride, and we were especially proud of John for being able to fly us around. Our only regret was that our dad, who had been born on the farm fifty years before, wasn't able to see it from above.

The next morning Daddy still wasn't feeling good, and went to the doctor and I went to town with him. I did errands while he was at the doctor's office. When I picked him up he said I needed to take him to the local hospital. Oh dear, this wasn't good. Of course I was shocked but calmly took him there and

just left him to check in by himself as he requested. Then I drove the six miles home to our farm, alone. When I drove into the yard, my mother came running out of the house to the car wondering where my dad was. She of course was worried about him and this was just about a worst-case scenario. My dad had said we didn't need to come see him right away since he would just be resting in the hospital. John was home then too and all three of us went to see Daddy that night. He then told us that he had had a heart attack and the doctor wanted to keep him in the hospital for three weeks to keep an eye on him and see how much damage had been done to his heart.

This was the beginning of his three weeks of being hospitalized, and the three of us suddenly running a busy farm in June. My parents were operating a 220-acre farm with those 200 beef cattle, and also a couple hundred hogs that we were raising to salable size. Of course there were many row crops like corn and milo as well as wheat and alfalfa hay to be taken care of. John was going off to Air Force flight school at Reese AFB near Lubbock, Texas the next week. I had just graduated from high school and had been hired to be the receptionist-secretary at the Wherry Mortuary.[1] I had already started the job in early June. and worked 9 to 5 five days a week. Who was going to do all the farm work?

My dad, being a typical farmer, was clearly the main spoke and knew everything about everything about how the farm worked, the precise mixture of all the components for the grinder mixer, and everything about the crops and all the equipment to cultivate, fertilize, and harvest the grains and crops. But with him lying in a hospital bed six miles away, it was my mother, John and me having to carry on, somehow.

While John was still there, the well on "the back forty" broke and went dry and suddenly in the middle of hot summer days, we had no water for the 200 cattle. Each animal can drink up to fifty gallons of water a day so it is a major problem to keep

[1] That's another story of how to get a job without applying, or without saying a word during the interview (I'd just had my tonsils out).

the animals hydrated when you have no water in the well, or can't get it up to the two ten-foot-diameter tanks. We had all learned how much gas to put in empty vegetable cans with bent spouts to fill the Briggs and Stratton engine in order for it to just fill the two tanks, with one running into the other, but not too much gas so it would overfill, and go on the ground making a huge mess for the cattle and us. But if there is no water, then what?

We thought carefully about what we should do and we all agreed that we shouldn't worry Daddy at all with this problem. His job was to get well and any unnecessary troubles dropped on him wouldn't help his healing. So we found a well driller/repairman in Beatrice, about 35 miles away, and he came and fixed the well. In the meantime, of course, the cattle needed thousands of gallons of water daily, so our alternative was to bring them home, about a mile away, and have them get water there, and graze on lesser pastures – but it would have to do. Weeks later, of course, our dad got the bill, but by then he was out of the hospital and we could ease the news to him.

John had just graduated from the University of Nebraska in Lincoln earlier that month. He had been commissioned a Second Lieutenant in the Air Force, having been a top leader in the Air Force ROTC unit at UNL. He had been president of the Arnold Air Society. Those were challenging weeks on the farm for all of us to cope with all the new challenges of running the farm as well as the cattle and hog operations with our dad in the hospital. Duty called, and John then reported for flight training at Reese Air Force Base in Lubbock, Texas.

After several weeks, Daddy helped arrange to have the cattle moved to a feed yard near Omaha; from there, they would ultimately go to the Omaha stockyards. However, it was very expensive to put them in the feedlot and pay someone else to feed and manage them. Years later Daddy told me that year we lost tens of thousands of dollars (many more in today's dollars!), and I was going off to college that fall. Oh my.

Chapter 2

Reese Air Force Base, Lubbock, Texas: 1963–1964

16 July 1963
Tuesday morning

Hello

As per about 1 year ago on 31 July, I am waiting behind 11 guys to get into the dental clinic for x-rays (only one machine). So will write some of the things I didn't have time for last night. Am also short on paper I brought with me.

When Carol goes out to Dickinsons, be sure Jack is there, as no one else knows where the watches are. Call first – 489-5478. Address is 1601 Skyline Drive. Go East on A street, past 48th to 58th street. Turn right (South) and take the first left (You are now on Skyline Drive). Follow on around SE (curved street) over hill until you come to 1601 on west side of street, brick house, name and address on mailbox in front of house by driveway. They are looking forward to seeing you, so be sure and go.

I have probably the oldest car on base. But it doesn't really bother me since I expected that to be the case. Most things

here are not much of a surprise – with one exception: 70% of the student pilots are MARRIED ! ! Yes, seventy per cent! Rather hard to get used to the idea that bachelors are in the minority especially after college and fraternity associations.

I had no car trouble, with the exception of the flat tire which is still holding air. The car ran beautifully all of the way.

Our rooms are nice. But for $85 each per month, we should have better facilities. We pay $10 per month each (required) for maid fee. She makes the beds, dusts, empty wastebaskets and changes the bedding once or twice a week. Not too bad of a deal, I guess.



John's service photo

My roommate is an Academy graduate. He has an iron and we put a towel on our coffee table and he taught me last night

how to press a uniform. Much cheaper than sending it out, even if we can afford to do it. We bought 2 glasses, milk, doughnuts, 2 spoons, one knife and a can opener. We have a refrigerator and are keeping some bread and lunchmeat in it. Cooking in the rooms is forbidden. Since we are buying meals out of pocket, we potentially can save a lot of money. Have to see how it works out yet. We start exercises Thursday, so may need much more nutrition then. Don't know yet.

Air is very dry here. Am drinking a lot of liquid until I get used to it. I am almost used to it by now.

We have 50 in our class, 19 bachelors, about 20 AF Academy grads, 2 Navy Academy grads, 1 West Point grad, 1 OCS grad, 3 Air National Guard and the rest ROTC like myself. About equally distributed across the nation as to home. A very wide variety of accents. Very interesting. If I don't go into town much (8 miles) I might pick an eastern accent as easy as a southern one.

Is going to be a very busy year—again! Don't know yet how much homework or night work there will be but probably 2 or 3 hours per night. But most Saturdays and Sundays are free – I hope. It is going to be a very demanding curriculum. We have a 250-mile radius limit to travel on weekends. We get two weeks at Christmas if we aren't behind on flying time.

We already have assignments and haven't even been to class yet. About 262 hours of flying, 400 hours of classes, 143 hours of physical training, and much more of everything compressed into 55 weeks.

Must close now.
Love
John

15 Oct 1963

Just a quick note to tell you that I'm still here – flying, dating and studying. I don't have a date tonight – first time in 6 consecutive nights. We have a night flight tomorrow night and a Navigation Final Thursday morning.

Am enclosing a most interesting cover story from TIME. I would like both of you to read it in full. I am no longer a foolish youthful dreamer when I set out in life to aspire to similar heights. There is no reason in the world why I can't do the same and more. Read the article and then think about it. Not at all ridiculous or impossible when seriously considered. Read, evaluate and consider. Will tell you about girl friends (plural) some other time. Am still very much single. Intend to stay that way.

Love, John

12 Nov 1963

. . . Talked to both aunts, Dale and Kathleen Friday night on way through Colorado Springs. Had a very nice chat. One of them asked about Karen Gunlicks, who I haven't seen or written to for 4 months. How did they find out about her? And what did you tell them? You should have learned by now that I'm quite unpredictable about girls and you shouldn't give people the wrong ideas until I've been engaged to be married for at least six months. Nothing is stable or assured until then. Karen was a good example of this.



Karen Gunlicks (left) and other women John dated. These wallet-sized pictures were in his personal effects.

Right now I'm rather interested in a senior at Texas Tech. I am proceeding rather guardedly because of my sworn convictions to remain a bachelor for quite some time. I could

be very happy with this girl if I allowed myself to be. Really, she's great! My question is—what do YOU think of the relative pros and cons of early and late marriage? Sit down and discuss your courting and early marriage years and try to determine how different they would have been had you both been 21 rather than 24 and 27. How important was age? How many of your reasons were unique to the depression and/or Dad's financial status? How long did you know each other prior to marriage? How much did you gain by waiting? How much of all this does or does not apply to me today because of changes in society and/or the economy? I ask these questions – and hope you will sit down and discuss them together at length before answering – only because I greatly value your advice and realm of experiences in this area. These are not questions to be answered in one evening. Think about and discuss them for a week. Then please send your opinions and words of wisdom gleaned from 23 years of marriage. This may take a lot of time, but it will mean a lot to me.

Thank you.
Love John

Relationship Advice

We didn't have serious discussions like this very much at home so this was an important outreach by John. His dating life was much different than my parents. He had far more choices in a very different culture than our parents grew up in. He was very outgoing, and later in his career he had girlfriends in various parts of the country, and world, when he was traveling.

My parents met a couple of years before they married on June 16, 1940. As opposed to John's extensive travels, neither of our parents had traveled beyond Lincoln, Nebraska fifty miles away, if that far. (The only exception was my mother and her cousin and high school classmate, Frances Miller, going to the World's Fair in Chicago in 1932.) They met because a high school classmate and best friend of Mother's, Laura Baum (Graebner), was a first cousin of my Dad. Her father and my dad's mother, Mary Baum Bischoff, were siblings, having both

immigrated from southwest Germany in the 1890s. My parents and other young people at the time often saw one another at church picnics, a dance, or other informal gathering. Neither of our parents ever mentioned any serious previous dating relationships.

However, I learned my father was a charming man and popular with women in the area. A picture of him standing proudly beside a car of the time indicates he was a good looking guy who, despite his modest roots and humble ways, also liked his dapper presence in this photo.

My dad was the oldest of two children and my mother was the oldest of four children. Both were serious in their approach to the world and were frugal as were most of the young people of that day. They and their parents had lived through the depression so they were supportive of "reduce, reuse, and recycle" long before it was a familiar phrase. They both had a good sense of humor, liked to dance, and my dad was an especially graceful dancer.[1]

Our mother was 24 and our dad was 27 when they married in 1940. Mother had been teaching in a one-room school house for six years. She was living with her parents when not teaching, and during the school year she boarded with an aunt and uncle who lived close to the school, since she didn't have a car. Our dad was farming with his father on the family farm. They were probably at an average age for getting married. Three of their four closest neighbors married about the same time and also started families. Thus, their neighbors' children were in the same country school as John and me.

Neither of our parents had saved much money. My mother made about thirty dollars a month teaching, and I recall that she paid her aunt and uncle five dollars a week for board and room, so that didn't leave much for saving or other expenses. Years earlier, during the depression, she mentioned she often wore the same dress daily and had a special, nicer dress for

[1] He taught me to dance at the local community building in the 1950's when there were wedding or anniversary dances. And I met my second husband at a singles dance many years later, in 1983!

Sunday. Her peers were in a similar situation, so it was no cause for embarrassment. Our dad was farming with his dad and money was tight, especially since my Grandpa Bischoff had bought another farm for his daughter (Alma, my dad's younger sister) and her husband, when they married in the mid 1930s. He paid too much for it and all three families helped pay for that farm until many years later.

When my parents married, they shared the pickup truck that my grandparents and my dad had been sharing. This means they had to coordinate who needed it since it was six miles from the farm to the town where my grandparents lived. My grandparents went to the country church where my parents also attended, so it's possible that on Sundays the grandparents drove the car out to the farm, picked up my parents, and they all went to church together. This arrangement continued throughout the war years since there was rationing and no one bought cars or many other items until the war was over. After the war, each of them had some type of vehicle. Grandpa Bischoff bought a 1950 black Ford sedan that he drove to the farm for years and he probably bought it new back then. No doubt my parents got the (very) used pickup for farm use.

Thus the decisions of getting married, where you might live, how you would earn money, and create a life together were very different for my parents than for John. Our parents' choices were far more limited since they knew they would continue to live in Johnson County, Nebraska. The law back then was that when a woman married, she lost her teaching job, so it was no longer a choice for Mother to earn some income outside the home. She became a "typical farm wife" and raised a big garden, canned and preserved (and much later froze, when they got a freezer) produce, raised hundreds of egg-laying chickens, raised "broilers" to butcher for meat, milked a cow, and was a helper-on-demand to my father. They were a team, as you needed to be to make it in the faming industry. A very different set of circumstances from where John was, but selecting the right personality for this endeavor was critically important in both situations.

[In John's handwriting:]
Headache treatment in 24 Feb -16 March 1964

7 March 1964

Received at Reese AFB Hospital and Sheppard AFB Hospital
Dr. Johnson
Dr. Green
Dr. Tegtmeyer

History
This 22 year old 2Lt was admitted to SAFB Hospital on 7 March 1964 with a chief complaint of headaches since 12 Feb 64. The patient is a Student Pilot at Reese AFB, Texas and was well until 12 February when denoted generalized constant, steady headache. He noted no relation to posture and no relationship to flying. Approximately one week later, the patient developed a cold which he describes as being generalized and steady and not aggravated by coughing, sneezing or head movements. Occasionally it is somewhat worse occipitally or bitemporally; at which time massaging the occipital or nuchal area may relieve it temporarily. He was admitted to Reese AFB on 27 Feb 64, at which time studies revealed 20% atypical lymphocytes in a peripheral smear, a BUN of 23.5, and a CSF protein of 49 mg%. The spinal fluid pressure was normal. He was treated with meprobamate with brief temporary relief of his headache. The patient feels that his headache has not interfered with his work in any way. There is no significant family history of headache. Past history reveals the patient's father to have had a heart attack and the patient's mother a carcinoma of the breast. There is no family history of diabetes, epilepsy, mental disease, or renal disease. Patient had mononucleosis approximately two years ago at which time he was quite seriously ill and apparently had some hepatic involvement. Subsequent to this, there was some disturbance in his clotting mechanism which was corrected with vitamin K. He fractured his left arm as a child. Review of systems was non-contributory.

Physical Examination
Blood pressure 120/88, pulse 72. Patient was alert and oriented. Examination of the head revealed

prominent frontal sinuses but no Bruit's were heard over the skull. Examination of the nose revealed slightly injected nasal mucosal. The remainder of the general physical was within normal limits as was a complete neurological examination.

Laboratory Data
Urinalysis -- negative. WBC 8,200 with normal differential. Hematocrit 46%. Cerebral spinal fluid cells 3, protein 68 mg%; repeat 58mg%. Prothrombin time 16 seconds with a control of 14 seconds for 73%. SGOT 8 units. SGPT 16 units. Heterophil agglutinations -- negative. Serology non-reactive. X-rays of the sinuses revealed them to be well aerated without evidence of mucous membrane thickening. The nasal airway was felt to be partially occluded by swollen inferior turbinates. The possibility of an allergic rhinitis was raised. Examination of the skull was normal. Chest x-ray was negative. An EEG was obtained and was felt to be within normal limits.

Course in the Hospital:

A lumbar puncture was done on 10 March 1964 with an opening pressure of 175 and a closing pressure of 80. 20 cc of clear, colorless, cerebral spinal fluid were removed. Following the spinal tap, the patient had a typical post-lumbar puncture headache, lasting several days. The patient continued to complain of his usual headache. It was felt that no definite evidence of any neurological disease to account for the patient's headache was found. It is possibility that his headache was related to an allergic rhinitis or perhaps related to a rhinitis secondary to rhinitis by dust. Since the headache does not interfere in any way with the patient's performance as a Student Pilot he can safely return to full duty. If the problem should persist, perhaps he should be investigated for sinus disease though this did not appear of a significant nature at the present time. I would also be glad to see the patient again if his problem should persist. The elevated spinal fluid protein remains unexplained but in the view of the absence of any other positive findings, I do not feel that further evaluation is warranted at this time. It was also felt that there was not sufficient evidence pointing to a tension type headache to make psychiatric evaluation

worthwhile at this time.

Gamber F. Tegtmeyer, Capt USAF
13 Mar 1964
USAF Hospital Sheppard, Sheppard AFB, Texas

16 March 1964
Monday noon

Arrived here by bus about midnight Friday. Went to see doctor this morning and told him I wanted to fly. He cleared me and I will start flying tomorrow. At least I will get caught up and get my $100 a month for February and March.

My headaches are about the same, so if they don't get better in a week or two I'll have to go somewhere else for more tests, etc. Probably would go to Brooks AFB, San Antonio where the Air Force's Aerospace medicine Headquarters and Space Laboratories are located. Depends on whether or not they get better. Will only have to wait and see. Meanwhile will fly enough to get some flight pay. If I went to Brooks AFB it would take 2 or 3 weeks for all of the tests. As it stands now, I can stay in "A" class and get caught up in a week or two. Don't know anything else. If health isn't good, nothing else matters.

Love John

Aeromedical Evaluation (excerpt):

Lt Bischoff is a 23-year old white male who was referred to the School of Aerospace Medicine for severe generalized headaches. These headaches started in February 1964 during pilot training. They were generalized and steady; were not aggravated by sneezing, coughing, or head movements; were not associated with nausea or vomiting; were not preceded by an aura and had no sequelae. They were not related to position and were non-throbbing. They have never interfered with his flying duties. Lt Bischoff was evaluated in March 1964 at the USAF Hospital, Sheppard AFB, Texas by Captain Gamber F. Tegtmeyer. This evaluation was made because of the headaches. Laboratory examinations at Sheppard were reported to be essentially normal with the exception

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of a slightly elevated CSF protein.  This was not
considered significant and he was returned to flight
training.  Diagnosis at that time was ‘‘Observation,
neurological, for headache, no disease found.’’
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My parents and I knew he had headaches that year of flight training in Texas, that he was having them checked out, and that he was off of flying status for several weeks while at Reese. In his final tape (the one he made for us in case he was Killed In Action) he mentions the headaches and says they weren't an issue after that:

> I had the headaches and I appreciated your help and support during all those things. All the problems and trials and tribulations I had as a result of that. But as things got straightened out, solved the headaches, I felt a lot better – it was all the result of ambition, I guess, tension, but I've been all right since.

He never wanted us to worry about him, and the records indicate he did see additional medical personnel at several points in his flying career.

It's a stressful career, and made more so by knowing you might get shot down and be taken prisoner, be tortured, and worse. The Air Force prepares you for what might come, and the records reflect the extreme stress he experienced and its effects on him. It wasn't diagnosed as stress-related, but seemingly didn't have a physiological basis.

With fifty-plus years of hindsight, I now see them as stress-related, an undiagnosed possible fear of being killed. He wanted to live a full life and saw the inherent dangers in those fighter planes. Even that early in the war, he was aware of the statistics of the fatalities of fighter pilots, and the survival rates only got worse as the war went on.

Chapter 3

Reese Air Force Base: May–June 1964

1 May 1964

Carol wrote to me about Tassels.[1] I am so happy and proud it is a bit hard to express in words. After being there for four years, I think I can appreciate the significance of this and AWS[2] Board, also Builders[3] to a certain extent, even more than you can. This is really an accomplishment! And all in her freshman year! Remember how little I did my freshman year? If she has done all this by now, who knows – there is practically no limit to what she can do before she graduates! There is no doubt about it – she is a very exceptional, outstanding, popular girl with a wonderful personality.

I am still dating Bobbie. She wants to get married [penned in later: "Naturally I'll resist."] Am also dating Beth (the schoolteacher). Both are very good girls. I guess I should say women (both are 24 years old and would like a husband). Beth lives in an apartment, cooks for me sometimes, doesn't have "hours" at night and has a swimming pool. This is very

[1] UNL women's pep organization
[2] Associated Women Students
[3] a service organization

important in the spring and summer. Have been spending some time over there swimming and sunning. Until my candle burns out at one end or the other, will continue to date both and resist conversation concerning anything perm-anent.

Car is running beautifully. I just love it. Top goes down 4 or so times a week. Now have 3900 miles. . . I fly a supersonic airplane, date 2 women with pool whenever I want to, have money to spend, a new red convertible and beautiful weather. I feel great, have no obligations or responsibility (wife, children, etc.) and can hardly think of any way that life could be better! Besides, it's spring!

Love, John

From farm boy. . .

John and I spent many hours daily playing outdoors in our sandbox just south of our farm house. It was under the big elm tree, so it was shady on hot summer afternoons. We were only twenty feet or so from the big farmhouse kitchen, so Mother could keep an eye and ear on what was happening, but mostly we were just quietly and compatibly farming the many fields in our sandbox. There was a swing on a branch further south and west, but it never interfered with the sandbox. The upper level of the sandbox was the end of a pathway that led to the gate through which you entered to turn left and go on the cement walkway to the "south door," the only door we, and guests, ever used.

John and I were quite ingenious in using whatever we had to do our farm construction. Just like other farm kids, I'm sure we used items that our parents had tossed out. Emptied tin cans (and we did call them that, not being made of aluminum I imagine) could become the bases for bridges with plenty of space for water escaping through them. Our sandbox was on a bit of an angle, so John periodically got a bucket of water to see what the rain would do to the creation of the day. My dad talked of erosion in the fields after a big rain, so this happening in our small plot was understandable. Of course, the financial impact of our sandbox erosion was hugely different from a newly

planted field of corn or wheat being washed out and having to be replanted. This would have been a major expense for our dad, for the tractor and more planting time, new seeds, more fertilizer, as well as the fuel for the tractor, and the potential of a delayed crop that wouldn't produce as planned. But our version of farming and rain storms was a healthful and fun way to use our imagination and just have a good time together.

. . . to fighter pilot

One of John's doctors summarized that as the only son of a farmer in Nebraska, and the first to get a college degree, John felt pressure to succeed. He didn't want the headaches to remove him from a flying career that he loved. He did love to fly, and he liked it from when he first started flying while a senior at the University of Nebraska. And he was good at it. You don't get to be a jet fighter pilot by being a slider. He was among the best.

He liked the Air Force, the potential for seeing more of the world, and for doing his part in the military. He was clearly smart enough to master the intricacies of flying not only the cargo plane – the C-135, which is similar to a Boeing 707 that he flew for two years to and from Southeast Asia – but he also mastered the skills of flying and using the F-105 Thunderchief as a serious weapon of advanced warfare.

As I re-read all the medical reports, I see my brother as a young man who internalized the stress of flying and the pressure to succeed in all that he did. The psychiatrist indicated that the headaches may have been a defensive mechanism for dealing with the many stresses. John was determined to do his best, and to make sure it was good enough to be a great pilot. He always scored well on his many qualification tests in each of the airplanes he flew, from the trainers at Reese AFB, to the C-135, to the F-105.

29 May 1964

. . . Yesterday I flew my first formation flight up and back through the clouds. Very different, challenging

Ratings were computed, since assignments are made on individual preferences in order of class standing. Rank order in the class does not go on our final report only now for airplane assignment. The list is for all the pilots in 7 or 8 bases. Not very many fighters but a lot of transports and bombers. Some people were happy with this, others were not. At the end of the first half of the program I was 13th of 37 in our class. As of this week, final standings placed me 6th of 37. and of course interesting. . . I suppose that this week past differed most from others in that our list of assignments came down from headquarters and as a result, final class standing. I moved up more than most people. I surprised many, especially those who moved down. Am quite satisfied with my standing. Lt Smith (of Iowa) was the #1 man. There was only one other ROTC graduate besides me and Lt Smith in the top 11 people (rest were Academy graduates).

We figured out which airplanes we wanted to fly and ranked them in order, 1 through 19, we were given 19 different kinds of airplanes to choose from – a rather wide selection. These preferences, along with class standings are fed into a computer and then we are assigned to training schools and survival school, travel orders are issued, and in 6 or 7 weeks we will find out where we are going, when, and what kind of airplane we will be flying. So now we are all looking to Tuesday, August 4 for graduation. . . Am going to Ruidoso, NM for horse races and mountain sight-seeing this weekend.

Love, John

28 June 1964

Another beautiful Texas Day. Lots and lots of sunshine, a slight breeze, just enough white puffy clouds to make the sky pretty, and warm. Up to 95 or 100 degrees every day. Down to 80 at night. Perfect weather. Car top hasn't been up for 3 or 4

days now. No dust storms any more. No cloudy, dreary days. All are bright, warm and beautiful. Went to pool almost every afternoon this week. Off of work at 12:30 every day. Really a great life. Sometimes play golf in the early evening, then have a date in my red convertible. Really the great life!

Got my airplane assignment but not base yet. For the next 4 years I will be flying a C-135 for the military Air Transport Service. It is the same airplane as the jet airliners – a Boeing 707. Just the military version of the commercial airliner. Very similar to the KC-135 tankers that the Strategic Air Command uses to refuel its bombers. . . A very big but very pretty airplane. When fully fueled it weighs about 250,000 lbs. The T-37[4] weighted 6600 lbs and the T-38[5] weighs 11,620 lbs fully fueled. The C-135 has 4 engines (all jet) and is the safest plane in the Air Force. It was my third choice, after F-105[6] and F-100[7], both single engine fighters. I won't be able to do loops or rolls any more, but it will be a lot safer with 4 engines. The C-135 cruises at about the same altitude (30,000 to 40,000 ft.) and about the same speed (500 to 650 mph) as the T-38. But of course it won't climb nearly as fast as the T-38. And it won't do any acrobatics either. And I probably won't ever fly any formations again. But I will be flying passengers and high priority cargo to all parts of the world. This is the Air Force's only jet transport (all others are propeller planes and go half as fast) and is used whenever things (people or cargo) need to get somewhere in a hurry. A lot of the flights will be unscheduled errands to far corners of the world.

There are only 2 squadrons of C-135's in the Air Force (except the ones at Andrews AFB at Washington, DC which carry the President and other government VIPs). (The President's Air Force One personal plane that Kennedy flew to Dallas is the same as the one I'll be flying except the interior has been modified for an office and bedrooms, besides

[4] his first trainer jet

[5] his second trainer jet

[6] which he ultimately got when he got orders for Vietnam

[7] which would also have sent him to Vietnam earlier



The C-135

seats.) One squadron is at McGuire AFB, near (northeast of) Philadelphia. The other squadron is at Travis AFB, between San Francisco and Sacramento. Both places are near a coast and in beautiful country. Either place I get assigned to is generally regarded as a very plush assignment. I just can't lose either way. McGuire is 72 miles from New York City and 55 from Philadelphia. That would be just tremendous. But so would California's weather! Both places will have a lot of overseas flights which is what I really want. I came into the Air Force to travel, and I got the best job to do that. Might not be as much fun as shooting guns and dropping bombs from a fighter, but a lot more travel and a lot, lot safer!

I was 6th in a class of 37. The five people above me got fighters except #3 who wanted to be an instructor. Most of the people below me got propeller planes or bombers – both not

as desirable as this. I am the only one in our class to get this airplane. There are a good number of people below me who listed this airplane first in preferences and really wanted it bad, They are quite envious of my position. And the more I think about it, the happier I am.

And if I want to get out in 4 years, I should be in a very good position to step into one of the airline jobs that you've been reading about. I am enclosing another article from this week's TIME. Please return it and the last one about airline pilots from "The Air Force Times" when you are finished reading both.

You might show this letter or explain its contents to the grandparents or other people if you like.

The airplane has a crew of 9 or 10 so I'll never go solo again. But this one really is safer than driving a car. And you can't really say that about a single engine fighter. The C-135 pilot has to practice 2 engine landings all of the time. And they extremely rarely lose even one (out of 4).

You know how much I enjoyed my flight to Boston last summer – now I will be flying the same airplane as a co-pilot and probably aircraft commander in 18 months or 2 years. I will probably fly 80-90 hours a month. I hope I am gone most of the time. Nothing would make me happier than being in a different city every night for the next four years.

. . . and then about flight school graduation.

You should plan to arrive here sometime on Sunday, August 2. Spend Monday looking around and Tuesday at graduation exercises. Then leave Wednesday morning if you like. Don't know yet whether I'll go to Colorado with you. . . I'll make reservations for the guest house for 3 people for Sunday, Monday and Tuesday night.

Have been flying a lot. Mostly solo in 3 and 4 ship formation flights. This week will fly solo at night and do some solo night navigation missions. Sit around the pool all afternoon every afternoon and talk to girls in 2 piece and bikini bathing suits. Really the great life. Am living and loving every minute of it.

Love, John

Flight Training

John was 6th in his class of 37 and thus didn't get his first or second choice of planes for his assignment out of flight school. We are belatedly grateful! The fact that they took the top students in the class and sent them more directly to war is interesting. The plane he was assigned, the C-135, was directly involved in supporting the war effort, though in a much safer way.

Throughout his time flying the C-135 he primarily took over troops and brought back the injured, including burn victims, as well as casualties. He said one time the plane home was totally filled with caskets. Yikes! That must have been a real psychological jolt to know that that many guys your age were losing their lives over there and coming home in a box. What is the emotional toll of that, even when you are not being shot at while flying the cargo plane? You can believe in the national mission and that we were in the war to keep the south from becoming overrun by the communists and then continuing to take over other countries in the region (the "domino theory"). Seeing the huge and dramatic human cost was something he didn't discuss very much, but it had to be on his mind, heart and soul. We'll never know the full impact.

It's interesting that he wanted the fighter planes, and that they were most desired by his classmates as well. He loved to fly, and I understand why a pilot would want to command a fighter jet and put it through its maximum maneuvers. Those men, and it was all men, would have enjoyed the thrill of the speed and intensity of the experience. In addition to being good at flying under adverse combat conditions, to also be good at firing and hitting targets while doing loops and aversive action would indeed be a feeling of mastery of the machine. And to be contributing to the greater good at winning the war, as defined by those who sat in Washington who had no clue what it was like to be in a fighter plane and be shot at on every mission.

Chapter 4

Reese Air Force Base: July 1964

12 July 1964

. . . I am broke and have been for two months. After car insurance and 3 months payment on Mutual Benefit Life and $100 car payments plus food, I am regularly broke. Cannot pay any other bills. Will have all I can do to leave here even. . . Saturday night we bachelors gave a return party to some of the married couples who have had us over for meals this past year. We bought a 16-gallon keg of beer and 15 lbs. of barbecued beef, plus other food. Cost us $4 each and all had a good time. . . not much else of note to tell. Hope to borrow a movie camera and take some formation pictures before I leave here.

16 July 1964

Look at ad on pages 70 and 71 of July 17 Life Magazine. That is what the airplane I am going to fly looks like. I am just overjoyed with my assignment! Very, very excited about living in New Jersey. Have been reading, asking and inquiring about this

65-A CLASS HISTORY

It was the 14th of July in 1963, a typical hot, sunshiny West Texas day when 50 "volunteers" reported to begin the 55 week Undergraduate Pilot Training Program. With one exception, who SIE'd the the next day, all of us were brown bars (not at all gold as we had been told at The Academies and as ROTC Grads). We were all new, but were all just as eager as we were green.

The affable Capt Garrett greeted us "gents" on Monday and proceeded to tell us about the program. Thence a parade of base brass, all who said "Welcome to Reese." At the completion of the three week pre-flight phase, we apprehensively marched down to Flight 7 to meet our glorious instructors and get on with this business of learning to fly jets.

Capt "Andy" and his boys introduced us to the T-37 "Tweetie Bird", and after proper introductions all around, it screamed back at us. But one by one we got ahead of it, withstood a pitch-out without getting sick and most of us eventually soloed.

When the Baptist Ministry called Capt Garrett away from the Air Force, Capt Howell took over as the OTI for 65-A. Primary Training rolled *on as some of us went to B class and others to* navigator training.

Solo radio calls became the humor injected into each day's flying experiences. Who of us will ever forget Cantwell's stuck mike button ". . beautiful, beautiful turn, . . . Aw,——! Throttle Jock 27 on the go!"? or Culberson's being told to go around and unconsciously asking Deadwood "What FOR, you ———?"!

The great machine called UPT rolled on until the first part of December arrived. We were sure training would come to a halt when we first heard rumors about that thing called Operation Split. But one day Major Leong appeared and each of us democratically drew out of the brown envelope. Half of us went to the "Oh-Worst" and the other half remained "Spooks" to go to Flight 6. And even after we had our decision made for us, none really knew who had gotten the better deal. It was up to Flight 9 to decide that for us.

Yes, about the first of February the fabled white rocket came from a starry blur into focus as a reality with procedures to learn about. We were about to fly the T-38 Talon! And Capt Zoerlein was right when he told us the "38" was self-motivating. We eagerly fondled our NEW, non-dog-eared Dash-Ones and read about afterburners and IFF Squawk.

But with the good (T-38) also came the bad (Spring on the South Plains), more commonly referred to as "another ——dust storm." Each February morning we heard "Wx today: winds 260/20, vrbl 240-280, gusting 35, ocnl. gusts to 45, 7 miles vsby, inter ¼ mi. BD; outlook, little change 'til May or June." Everyone dismissed at 1000 hours because weatherman predicts building to blow away at noon." The dust came and went, the building stood, and we eventually soloed, after of course, getting cross-wind qualified.

Slowly but surely training rolled on (even if we were 17 hours behind in the 01st)

65-A became famous for its response during fund drives and in our 00th section class spirit. We had a good boner party. The bachelors got married and most of the marrieds had babies. The bachelors who remained single bought new cars instead. ("36-2 and the Goul, too")

The end came into view and we began to look back. Many things would stick out in our minds, for it was in the truest sense of the phrase "A year to remember". There were the radio calls ("NITECAP, altimeter. . . .Go ahead, altimeter"), *the military courtesies ("STANDBY. . .one. . . two. . .three. . .alltogethernow . . .* ROOM . . . ATTEN-HUT"), and Sgt Zamora looking at your mask and saying "No——sweat Sir, I feex eet for you".

And we began to tell ourselves and each other "Everybody graduates August 4, and there never was a class that graduated late." We computed class standings, submitted our career to ATC and IBM, flew 4 ships and waited on orders.

We had enjoyed our stay at Reese, we were closer to shedding our brown bars, and we were all anxious to get to an operational unit.

There may have been better classes (we doubted it), classes with more stick and rudder skill (Throttle Jock, go around), more unified classes (the 00th section wouldn't hear of it), more co-operative classes ("But Sir, I don't believe in charity") and classes that were less frustrating to their OTI.

But in spite of everything (us included) they had made pilots (using the term loosely) out of us, and yes, we even graduated on time, that glorious calendar day many times circled, AUGUST 4th! We had learned a lot. It had been a good year.

One person's recollection, from the previous summer's class in 1963, of the type of experience that John had in summer 1964.

area since I got my assignment. . . the base is 20 minutes from the ocean and 20 minutes (the other direction, west) from the mountains. Now what could be better than that? Maybe only being in Europe once a week. . . Capt. McKinney, our Flight Commander and a fine man you must meet, says I have a very good job—and then he added—"just don't fall in love and get married." Means it's a tremendous job for a bachelor. He got married young and now has 5 kids.

Went solo to Waco yesterday afternoon by way of Wichita Falls and Dallas. Landed, got fuel, ate a hamburger and took off about 8:30 PM, solo, flew to San Angelo and then back to Reese. Very interesting. A lot of fun and very good experience, if only to build your own confidence. Had final Instrument check Monday and Final Formation check yesterday. Got Excellent on both. Very happy. Flew night formation Tuesday night. Very pretty to see engines and lights close up at night. Now have 117 hours. Am finishing up. See you August 2nd.

John

19 July 1964

Had a hectic week—in the first four days I flew 3 final checks and three night missions. Had final navigation check Thursday – went from here to Tucumcari, New Mexico, Garden City, Kansas and then landed at Altus, Oklahoma. Took off at 9 PM, flew to Wichita Fall, Dallas, Abilene and home. Haven't got grade yet but I think I did fairly well.

Will try to answer questions about clothes. Monday night is Dinner Dance. Formal attire for us. Ladies come in cocktail dress (formals for our wives if they prefer) graduates in Mess Dress and male guests in business suit (Winter is fine).[1] It will be in air conditioned Officers Club. Bring long-sleeved white shirt. Both of you ladies wear whatever qualifies as a cocktail dress (no hats allowed). Tuesday morning is parade – outside and 100 to 1 odds say it will be hot. Ladies wear summer dress – with heels and you Dad can get by with a white shirt, even

[1] That's all my Dad had, so they asked.



John in his dress uniform

without a tie. Doesn't make a lot of difference though. We go to Base Theatre after parade for graduation ceremonies. It, too, is air conditioned. Don't plan to buy a suit here. Winter suit will be fine for evening wear. Dinner Dance is not couples only. It is for us graduates and our guests. Bobbie will be there with us. . . I plan to take Civilian Commercial Pilot License Test on afternoon of August 4th. . . Stead Survival School lasts from August 19 to 9 September and I have to be at McGuire on or before September 21. So will have some vacation time again in September.

But a lot of travel from Reno, Nevada to Trenton, New

Jersey. At 6 cents a mile I should be able to come out ahead. I only have about 4 flights left in the program.

Love, John

Graduation

John's girlfriend, Bobbi joined us for many of the festivities. I have positive recollections of her. I also remember my parents weren't enthralled with her. I don't know if it's because John had been sleeping with her, or what, but I recall they were warm to her, but not welcoming like they would be to a possible daughter-in-law. Of course they knew John didn't plan to get married for a while so she was just a significant girlfriend at this point. We didn't meet his other girlfriend that he had dated at the same time as Bobbi. She was history by the time graduation occurred.

My mother proudly pinned on John's wings after his graduation. We attended all the formal events John had outlined above and we seemed to fit in with all the other graduates' families. It was a big occasion for all of us since my parents and I had driven down from Nebraska to Lubbock, Texas. We were all very proud of John for graduating from this 13-month school. Since he had graduated 6th in his class we were also proud of the fact that even though he hadn't gone to the US Air Force Academy, as had many of the other graduates, he had graduated higher than many of them. Very proud of this farm boy from southeast Nebraska!

I do recall that we stayed at a very modest hotel and John would have been happier at a more upscale place. I have no idea how my parents made the reservation since this was long before anything other than long distance calls were in use. They may have sent a written letter, which was often their way of communicating. It was cheaper than long-distance calls, so often much preferred. The motel had all the basics, but it was more basic than John had gotten used to. The fact that I remember that more than fifty years later makes it significant!

I have no correspondence from the time John was at Stead Survival School from August 19 to September 9. This is when, in one of the tests/traumas, he was placed in a "black box" which apparently is excruciatingly confined, and he did not handle it well. He lost feeling in his legs and hyperventilated. He had some type of mental breakdown and was hospitalized overnight:

> Aeromedical evaluation (excerpt 2):
>
> After completing pilot training Lt Bischoff was sent to Stead ASFB for the Advanced Survival Training School. While in the compound phase of the training and while in the ‘‘black box", he developed a severe headache and severe pain in his knees. He had an episode of hyperventilation and became hysterical. He was hospitalized overnight. He was then returned to the survival school where he completed the course. Captain Paul W. Knoop, Chief of Flight Medicine, 3635th USAF Dispensary, Stead AFB, Nevada evaluated Lt Bischoff at that time. He suggested that Lt Bischoff have a complete psychiatric evaluation some time in the future.

The psychiatrist who examined him said after he finished the other parts of the survival school he was to return for further evaluation. That never happened since there was a bureaucratic blunder and John was passed on to the next step and graduated out of the Survival School without further evaluation. This is the big WHAT IF?

WHAT IF...

What if it was too much stress and he would not have, for example, handled being a Prisoner of War experience as expected? What if he had not been passed on and had taken a different path, avoiding active combat?

What if John had decided that the headaches and stresses were too much, and he wanted to bow out of the jet fighter path? What if a psychiatrist hadn't passed him on to the next step of training? What if John had had the follow-up appointment that the psychiatrist recommended? What if

there hadn't been apparent pressure on the Survival School staff and medical personnel to pass as many pilots as possible since they were needed in Vietnam? They were being killed off in increasing numbers and would be for the next several years, so they had to keep the new pilots coming into fighter pilot assignments.

Would he have continued as a cargo pilot (C-135) that he would become proficient at, and didn't involve the ultimate stress of being shot at and possibly being a Prisoner of War? Would he have transitioned to being a commercial airlines pilot? Would he have felt challenged and happy with continuing to travel the world and meeting interesting people in many cultures? Would he have become a flight instructor and lived the good life at some southern air force base here in the USA? I think he would have been happy in any of these roles: less stress, no headaches, and still flying a big interesting airplane. But that isn't the trajectory that developed for him.

Chapter 5

McGuire Air Force Base: 1964–1965

31 Oct 1964
Saturday

Hello-
Got up early today and went to Washington DC! Yes, after years of anticipation and dreaming, I got there. This is an especially pretty time of the year to go (spring and cherry blossom time is the other). It was a beautiful sunshiny day, temps in the 60's (just right) and just enough breeze to rustle a few falling leaves. The perfect setting.

Washington is probably the most beautiful big city I've ever seen anywhere. It was all that I expected it to be. I drove all over and enjoyed it immensely. Went down through Baltimore. Saw Johns Hopkins University, Hospital and Medical Center-School. Also the University of Maryland. Took some slides of the roads and beautiful countryside.

Am enclosing a couple of maps to look at, follow and maybe even use at school or to show to grandparents. Came in from northeast and drove past north side of White House. Then south to Lincoln Memorial. Then across Arlington Mem. Bridge, Potomac R. and to Arlington Nat'l Cemetery. Walked

to President Kennedy's Grave. Can't really describe how I felt, but I'll never forget the experience. I deeply admired him long before the assassination.



John's picture (from a different trip) of the Washington Monument

Then drove past lake north of Jefferson Memorial and Washington Monument. Didn't take any pictures here. Will wait until cherry blossoms are in bloom. Drove down Independence Ave past Smithsonian Institute and many other gov't bldgs. (huge Department of Agriculture) to the Capitol. It is covered with scaffold steps and junk in preparation for the Inauguration ceremony. Lots of it is already built, so didn't take any pictures here. Look at Library of Congress and Supreme Court. Also 2 Senate office and 3 House Office Buildings.

Then west on Constitution Ave to Pennsylvania, past buildings belonging to cabinet, past buildings belonging to cabinet post departments (Labor, Justice, Commerce, Post office, Health Educ and Welfare and Treasury Bldg just east of White House). Since Johnson is campaigning much of the



John's picture (from a different trip) of the U.S. Capitol Building

time, the White House is covered with scaffold getting a new coat of paint for the inauguration. I guess. Anyway I didn't take any pictures here either. Some other time. A beautiful place though.

The whole thing was very impressive and quite worthwhile. Something I have long wanted to do. I have hoped to live there for quite some time. Seeing the city reinforced that feeling.

Left to the northeast (after spending about 3 hrs in Washington) and went across Maryland to Annapolis and the Chesapeake Bay Bridge (almost 5 miles over water without approaches) across Maryland and into Delaware. Then north and back to Wilmington, across Delaware Bay and Bridge, through Camden and back to here. About 320 or 330 miles total. About 3 hours direct to Washington. Really great.

Will go back and do a walking tour of Library of Congress, Smith. Institute, National Archives, White House public tour, and Congress when they're in session (all home now for the

campaign). This will all come later.

Am also checking out times, distances, and facilities at various ski resorts. Is looking good. And an infinite amount more remains! What a great place to be. I like it more and more.

Got a nice long letter from Carol. She's not just doing well – it's fantastic! Grades, activities, popularity. Rush chairman of any house is very prestigious. She's very busy – and that's good. She'll get the most out of college that way. She is really a tremendous girl. Must close.

Love John

P.S. Heard Nebr beat Missouri today. Yea!

16 Jan 1965
Sunday night

Dear Carol,

I'm sure I'm overdue on a letter, but the holiday season was hectic. Lots of parties and I was here for them. Really great. Bobbie came and spent 3 days over New Year's Weekend. Had a very good time. Not surprisingly, she still very much wants to get married. Having met this crisis before I was able to weather it and come through very single. But she's a very fine gal and I'm sure would make a good wife. It's just that I don't need one now. Maybe in a few years. . . ?

Congrats on house office. If that's what you wanted – fine. You are the best judge.

Be a Dorm Counselor if you like. I think it would be a good experience, challenging, and most of all—very personally rewarding.

No – there's no hurry on china.

Hold your ring under a light and there should be a six pointed star visible. Don't have it scratched for a hardness test.[1]

[1]He had given both my mother and me black star sapphire rings for Christmas but I didn't know much about them.

You read my mind by sending Jade East. I changed brands about 3 months ago. Wore your sweater over a yellow-brown turtleneck sweater and put on your "smell good" for a recent party AND – every girl there was snowed and wanted to come home and sleep with me! Not really – not quite every girl, but I am happy with your gifts.

Just got back from spending 4 days in Madrid. Great city. Lots of dark eyed, black haired, hot blooded, full bodied, big breasted women there. Good times were had by all. Saw a lot of the city too. Also from air by daylight for first time. Cairo, Suez Canal, Nile River Valley, Red Sea, Pyramids, the Sphinx, Mediterranean Sea, Crete, Sicily, Corsica, Sardinia, Southern part of Italy and Greece plus much more of Spain. A good trip.

Went to see the Woods in Montclair, NJ today for Sunday dinner. Very nice people.

Haven't been called to fly yet, so don't know when I'll leave.

Good luck on finals.

Love, John

Late last winter I moved into an unfurnished apartment. I had been living on base and was unhappy with the BOQ there. Another bachelor, also a recent pilot training graduate (whom I met over a tall beer in the Officer's Club Stag Bar) and myself began the arduous (for us bachelors with no courses in interior decorating) task of buying furniture, accessories, silverware, pots and pans and all the rest—things a woman traditionally handles. The place actually looks like two amateur bachelors did the color combinations and floor plan, but it does have a few necessities of life, i.e. big bar, a TV and lots of records, so we survive.[2]

21 Jan 1965

Spent first day in laboratory today. These are really top-notch professional people. Very competent and all are on the brink

[2]Recall that italics means that this comes from John's Christmas letter.

of the extent of human knowledge in the field of Aerospace Medicine. This is a more thorough physical exam than could be obtained at any price at any clinic in the world, Mayo or any other. The facilities, equipment, knowledge, personnel and experience at the disposal of the people here is second to none, anywhere. Some of the data on us is being used in basic research that goes on every day here. The exotic equipment and facilities would be the dream of any doctor or research laboratory. This place is new, started with the US entry in the space race and dedicated by President Kennedy the day before he was shot... and we are handled on a very personal basis, not in a production line manner as many big clinics are guilty of doing. All of the medical aspects of the space program and all of our astronauts are handled here... If they'd let me I'd stay here until it gets warm in New Jersey. But I'll probably leave in a week.

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Aeromedical Evaluation Dates:  21-26 January 1965
Referral Diagnosis:  Headache

USAF SAM Aeromedical Evaluation Summary 26 Jan 65

Lt Bischoff was evaluated at the USAF School of
Aerospace Medicine at the request of Captain Jay R.
Moore, Flight Medical Officer, 1611 USAF Dispensary,
McGuire AFB, New Jersey.  Captain Robert L. Sadoff,
US Army Medical Corps, Walson Army Hospital, Ft.
Dix, New Jersey, completed the accompanying psychiatric
evaluation.  Lt Bischoff is an unqualified pilot
in the C-135.  He completed pilot training in
August 1964 and has a total of 272 hours flying
time.  He has logged 12 hours in the C-135.  Lt
Bischoff is a 23-year old white male who was referred
to the School of Aerospace Medicine for severe
generalized headaches.  These headaches started
in February 1964 during pilot training.  They
were generalized and steady; were not aggravated
by sneezing, coughing, or head movements; were
not associated with nausea or vomiting; were not
preceded by an aura and had no sequelae.  They were
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not related to position and were non-throbbing. They have never interfered with his flying duties. Lt Bischoff was evaluated in March 1964 at the USAF Hospital, Sheppard AFB, Texas by Captain Gamber F. Tegtmeyer. This evaluation was made because of the headaches. Laboratory examinations at Sheppard were reported to be essentially normal with the exception of a slightly elevated CSF protein. This was not considered significant and he was returned to flight training. Diagnoses at that time was "Observation, neurological, for headache, no disease found."

After completing pilot training Lt Bischoff was sent to Stead ASFB for the Advanced Survival Training School. While in the compound phase of the training and while in the "black box", he developed a severe headache and severe pain in his knees. He had an episode of hyperventilation and became hysterical. He was hospitalized overnight. He was then returned to the survival school where he completed the course. Captain Paul W. Knoop, Chief of Flight Medicine, 3635th USAF Dispensary, Stead AFB, Nevada evaluated Lt Bischoff at that time. He suggested that Lt Bischoff have a complete psychiatric evaluation some time in the future. Lt Bischoff was then sent to McGuire AFB for upgrading in the C-135. While at McGuire he was referred to the Walson Army Hospital for psychiatric evaluation. There he was seen by Dr. Sadoff. Dr. Sadoff suggested that Lt Bischoff's headaches were an "unconscious play toward removal from flying status." He recommended that he be removed from flying duties. Past history is negative with the exception of a single previous episode of hyperventilation. This occurred following fraternity hazing in college. At that time he was forced to perform a deep knee bend for a long period of time. His knees became quite painful and he hyperventilated. There is no family history of nervous or mental disease.

Examination reveals a well-developed healthy young white male whose blood pressure is 120/88, pulse 78, height 70.75 inches and weight 174 pounds. His weight at age 20 was 165 pounds. A marked protuberance of the frontal sinuses is present but this is not abnormal. Initial examination reveals a slight tendency to weakness of the upper arms and

shoulder muscles. On more thorough examination they appeared normal.

Laboratory procedures included blood count, white cell count, platelets, bleeding time, clotting time, prothrombin time, red blood cell count, morphology, hemoglobin, hematocrit, sedimentation rate, all of which were within normal limits. Urinalysis was entirely normal. Serological test was non-reactive. Chemistries including acid phosphatase, alkaline phosphatase, BUN, sodium, potassium, bicarbonate, choloride and calcium all were within normal limits. Uric acid was in the upper limits of normal for this laboratory. Other chemistries including bilirubin, thymol turbidity, SCOT, SGPT, total protein, albumin, globulin, protein electrophoresis, creatinine, cholesterol, total limid, phospholipid and triglycerides are all within normal limits. A glucose tolerance test on 21 Jan showed:

Fasting	30 minutes	1 hour	1 1/2 hours	2 hours
116	150	140	116	160

Electrocardiogram including precordial map were within normal limits. An EEG performed on 25 Jan 65 was within the range of normal variations. Scant alpha was seen. The patient became drowsy towards the end of the recording, but it remained normal. X-rays of the chest, skull, cervical spine, and a KUB film were all within normal limits.

Lt Bischoff was seen by Captain Alan R. Montgenstern, Flight Medical Officer, Psychiatric Branch, and Captain Carlos J. G. Perry, Chief, Psychiatric Branch. It was their opinion that Lt Bischoff has no psychiatric illness and qualifies for any kind of flying assignment in the Air Force. Captain Perry mentions the possibility that Lt Bischoff, if assigned to a combat crew and if taken prisoner, would probably be subject to ‘‘harassment, brain washing, or whatever.’’ He suggests that Lt Bischoff not be assigned to a combat crew for at least one year.

Lt Bischoff was seen in the Neurology Branch by Major Donald R. Bennett, Flight Medical Officer, and Edward A. Liske, Chief of the Neurology Branch. It was

their opinion that "These headaches are extracranial in nature and are most likely muscle contraction headaches of a mild degree. Since they are not incapacitating to the patient and since they have been decreasing in frequency recently and since they are not associated with any neurological signs, it is felt that this patient can be returned to a trial of duty as a pilot. It should be emphasized to the patient that if headaches increase in frequency or intensity and are associated with new physical signs that he should report to his flight surgeon for further evaluation." Dr. Like interpreted the EEG to be within the range of normal.

Lt Bischoff was evaluated in the Ophthalmology Branch by Dr. Philip Lempert, Flight Medical Officer. This evaluate disclosed no finding which would contraindicate unrestricted flying duties. Dr. Lempert did discover an old healed coreoretinitis which did not affect the vision of Lt Bischoff's left eye.

Lt Bischoff was seen in the Clinical Dentistry Branch by Dr. Gaylord L. Hall. Dr. Hall reported gingival recession around tooth #5 caused by improper toothbrushing technique and an incipient carious lesion on tooth #30. The SAM Periodental Index was recorded with a periodontal score of 1.17, irritant score 1.0.

No pathology has been uncovered by this thorough aeromedical evaluation. In view of the fact that his history of hyperventilation was only associated with severe pain, and in view of the decreasing frequency of the headaches, it is the recommendation of the School of Aerospace Medicine that Lt Bischoff should be returned to unrestricted flying duties. In addition it is felt that Lt Bischoff should not be assigned to combat crew status at the present time. With further maturation and familiarization with the Air Force mission it is felt that Lt Bischoff could perform any type of flying duties required of him by the Air Force.

Diagnoses: 7910 Headaches
7930 Observation for history of anxiety reaction, no disease found.
3760 Chorioretinitis, old healed, not affection vision, O.S.

```
5535 Absence of teeth, congenital, #'s 17 and 32[3]
James A. Lewis James H. Oliver, Jr.  Captain, USAF,
MC FMO Captain, USAF, MC, FS Flight Medicine Branch
Flight Medicine Branch

Approved by
(all signed in person)
Robert L. Johnson, Lt Col, USAF, MC, FS, Chief,
Internal Medicine Branch
Carlos J. G. Perry, Capt, USAF, MC, FMO, Chief,
Psychiatry Branch
Edward A. Liske, M D., Chief, Neurology Branch
James F. Culver, Lt Col, USAF, MC, FS, Chief,
Ophthalmology Branch
Alfred Hamilton, Lt Col, USAF, MC, SFS, Chief, ENT
Branch
Arthur J Stumpf, Jr., Lt.  Col, USAF, DC, Chief,
Clinical Dentistry Branch
John M Connolly, Major, USAF, MC, FS, Chief, Surgery
Branch
Charles L. Randolph, Jr., Lt Col, USAF, MC, FS,
Chief, Radiology Branch
David G. Simons, Lt Col, USAF, MC, SFS, Chief, Flight
Medicine Branch
Lawrence E. Lamb, M.D. Chief, Aerospace Medical
Sciences Division
Harold V. Ellingson, Colonel, USAF, MC, Commander
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25 March 1965
Thursday

Hello – Received your letter today. Decided to write now while I have on my mind some things to say.

Am enclosing a sketch map that I just remembered you asked for some time ago. Road maps don't show size of McGuire AFB. Fort Dix is as huge as it appears on road maps. All of base buildings are north of the NE-SW runway and most are east of N-S runway outlined.

[3]Fun to note here that John's niece Diana also has congenital absence of wisdom teeth 17 and 32

Towns of Bordentown[4] and Wrightstown have about 5000 people each. End of town and beginning of rural area are not nearly as defined as is so in Nebraska or Texas.

Received a nice card from Carol in Salt Lake City today. Sure am glad she got to make the trip. And she spent Denver to SL City talking to Cindy Hardin. I am sure it is a very valuable experience for Carol.[5]

I bought what is called a "Queen" sized bed, 60" $\times$ 80" as compared to a 54 $\times$ 72 for regular double bed. With book case headboard. Was told by many people not to skimp on a mattress. So bought a Beauty Rest.[6] Am very happy with it. Guaranteed 15 years. But was expensive. With car payments, 2 months rent plus 1 month deposit on apartment and the furniture; no flight pay until end of March—all of your money is gone. Can and will borrow $400 from Mutual Benefit Life when you need money back. Rest must come from Beatrice Production Credit. Sure can use the $100 month raise due June 9 (day 2 years from commissioning).

Am glad and a bit surprised to hear the new school passed. That's good.

Mr. Timm told me a lot about his landlord. One of their many farms was just south or just west of Boys Town (can't remember which). Had 300 or 400 acres and sold for something like $1000 or $1500 per acre while I was seeing Earlene. The brother and sister inherited one or two farms about the turn of the century. They lived like hermits, never went anywhere drove a very old car and just never spent any money. They worked very hard (farming) and put every spare penny into land. This was the story of their life. (Both are probably 70 or 80 now. Of course with Omaha's growth into their farms, they're worth several million dollars now.

[4]this is where he lived

[5]Cindy's father was Chancellor Clifford Hardin who was the University of Nebraska's Chancellor when I was a student there.

[6]It was the most comfortable mattress, and years later, when my mother had it in her new home in Tecumseh, Nebraska, guests and I always raved about how comfortable it was.

Sounds like Harold is better off hiring his dozing done than buying a D 8 for $30,000 or $35,000. Sure am glad he's got a good job going. The prediction to Grandpa Miller may turn out true sooner than you thought.[7]

Have 20 pictures of rural Southern US. Haven't taken any since I got back. Will send them and others you saw if you want them now. Postage won't be too much. Just say so.

Weather has been rather cold. Snowed Saturday and last night. Very nasty and unpleasant.

This school is not very difficult.

Mailed two packages today. Hope they arrive in good condition. Sorry about the atlas being flattened.

Just noticed Carol mailed her card Monday. Has color picture of University of Utah campus which I drove through early last fall. It is as pretty as the city itself, which is beautiful. She's a tremendous girl doing great things.

Just hope she relaxes often enough and doesn't work too hard. And I'll tell her that too!

Love

John

(Date unknown)

In May I finished the check-out school for the C-135 and started "flying the line." As a co-pilot, I sit in the right seat of this 275,000 lb. airplane and have very little, if any, authority, but that's part of being "new."

My first trip out of the United States, as were the first 4 or 5, was to Rhein Main AFB at Frankfurt, Germany. I got my first glimpse of Western Europe and the British Isles, even if it was from 35,000 ft.

[7] Grandpa Miller predicted that Harold, our mother's youngest brother, would someday be worth more than his three siblings' families put together. Harold certainly did make a lot of money, as a construction project developer (roads, sewer and water systems). Unfortunately, he was the first of the four siblings to die, of colorectal cancer at age 50, leaving a wife and three sons.

One of the most interesting trips I've had so far occurred the first week of September. It is referred to as the "Embassy Run" and literally goes around the world, one westward and one east-bound each week. We went to Charleston, South Carolina, and then to Madrid, Spain. From Torrejon AB near Madrid we flew over Barcelona, across the island of Corsica, down the west side of Italy, across the Mediterranean Sea, over Cairo, Egypt, the Suez Canal, the Red Sea, Saudi Arabia and landed at Dhahran on the Persian Gulf. From there we flew across Iran and landed at Karachi, Pakistan.

This turned out to be a major problem because India had bombed the city of Lahore in Northern Pakistan the morning of the day we arrived. Since we were bound for New Delhi, India, the Pakistanis didn't want us to leave. All commercial airline flights between the two countries had been cancelled by noon. By 2 p.m. local time when we wanted to leave they considered us their enemy and suspected us of attempting to carry vital war supplies to India. After much diplomacy we were grudgingly allowed to leave.

As we landed at New Delhi, an air raid was in process. We stayed overnight there and were told of a practice blackout at 6 p.m. The entire city was blacked-out ala Battle of Britain and remained so for the entire night. Only the next morning did we discover it had been a real blackout and air raid. During the night the Pakistan Air Force had dropped paratroopers in an attempt to take New Delhi.

The next morning India didn't want us to leave because they had cancelled all international flights. Again much discussion, delays, seeing increasingly more important officials, more diplomacy, and we were finally given permission to leave.

We flew southeast from New Delhi, over Lucknow, plainly saw the entire chain of Himalaya Mountains, including Mount Everest, across Calcutta, over Rangoon, Burma and landed at Bangkok, Thailand. From there a 1 1/2 hour flight to Tan Son Nhut Airport at Saigon, South Vietnam. Another 2 hrs. and we were at Clark AB in the Philippines, northwest of Manila. The next day we arrived for an air-evacuation load of war casualties

out of Clark, stopped at Kadena AB on Okinawa to pick up more patients, and flew on to Hawaii.

After an overnight stay we left Hawaii with more war casualties for Travis AFB, California. Most of the patients were taken off there but we took the badly burned ones on to San Antonio, Texas to be treated at the Army Medical Center there which specializes in burn cases. We arrived at McGuire AFB, NJ from the west, having circled the globe in six days elapsed time, 59 hours flying time. A very long and hard trip, but it was a wonderful excursion.

Since that time our Embassy Run goes east to Karachi and returns here and the other trip goes west to New Delhi and returns back across the Pacific. I have since flown the latter twice, spending overnight in Bangkok, Thailand each time. I could write pages about Bangkok, its Buddhist Temples, prices of black star sapphires, Thai silk, and above all, "its women." I could write more pages about the women of Thailand, probably the best in the world, but I'd bore my women readers and make the men envious, so it will suffice to say I had a very good time.[8]

The rest of my trips have been quite similar to each other. All are in the Pacific carrying troops (Marines, Army, Special Forces, Air Force Fighter Pilots, etc) to and from Vietnam. Sometimes our return flight carries patients and war casualties. The Marines we take to De Nang AB and most of the rest go through Saigon.

We usually pick up our load at Travis AFB, California and go to Wake Island, Hawaii, or Guam on the way to Clark AB, Philippines and then into Vietnam, from there to Japan to refuel for the 10 hr. flight direct to Travis AFB. Because of crew changes, time on the ground, etc., this trip takes us 1 1/2 to 2 wks (the airplane goes around and back in 40-50 hrs). After that I get 3 days off at McGuire.

[8]It is not clear who the recipient of this letter was. This sentence suggests that the audience was neither John's parents nor his sister, so perhaps it had a wider audience, like his Christmas letters.

Monday
23 August 65?

Hello –

Home from another trip. Another circle around and back to Travis. Hauling troops, cargo, and patients.

Remember Phil Tate? The red-headed Texan, pilot training classmate who took you out to runway in January. He graduated 2nd and I was 6th so he got the F-105 I wanted so bad. Well—we took him over "there" for a 3 or 4 month tour of duty flying missions "up North." They average one mission per man per day. He is stationed at McConnell AFB at Wichita, Kansas. His wife plans to teach school there this fall. Had a chance to talk to him for a while. He's certainly getting a taste of combat at a ripe young age. I'm not sure, but I don't think I'd trade places with him.

Sounds like JW Leuenbergers had a very nice trip.

Read all of the clippings.

The pay raise the President signed recently means just over $23 per month raise beginning September 1st.

Before I left on last trip, saw my roommate coming home from a trip. Saw him for 3 hrs, the first time in 9 weeks. He was home when I got home this last time, so we cleaned the apartment. First time we'd done anything since we'd moved in. Needless to say it needed cleaning. Venetian blinds were especially dusty. Sure is good to be a bachelor and only have to dust every 6 months.

Will write again when I have some news.

Love

John

P.S. Please don't work so hard or do so much. You sound much too busy.

Tuesday

By now you can conclude that I'm gone from New Jersey 2/3 to 3/4 of the time. I only get 3 days at a time here. (In August I had 5 days off and spent it in Tecumseh, Neb). My job work schedule including time away from home is not likely to change much until the world situation changes. The future is very difficult to predict. Changing airline requirements and demands on our time make the future quite unstable, but one adjusts and learns to live with most anything.

My personal and social life are a bit cramped, being crammed into 3 days of which 1 1/2 are spent catching up on sleep. I like living in the East, in general. The traffic and densely populated areas take adjustment. (1/3 of the population of the US lives within 250 miles.) The people here are very nice, but a bit more reserved initially than Southerners or people of the Midwest.

I enjoy going to New York City for the day or a Broadway play (it's 60 miles), and living within 30 miles of the Jersey shore has its summer advantages. There are also a number of good ski slopes within driving distance and I plan to patronize them this winter.

19 October 1965
Tuesday

Hello-

Got home yesterday from modified Embassy Run. Went west thru Travis, Hickam, Clark, Saigon, Bangkok to New Delhi and back the same way. Had evacuation patients after leaving Clark. Stopped at Anderson on Guam. There are a lot of battle casualties to be brought home. But sad as Air Evac missions are, they are still better than the trip before this—our load from Yakota, Japan to Travis was coffins.

Trip I just finished was a good one. Pleasant crew rests in Hawaii (24 hrs east bound) Clark and of course, Bangkok. We got there about 5:30 p.m. local time so didn't get any pictures of palace, temples or anything else in that beautiful city.

I am beginning to really like southeast Asia. And it is cold here when I get back. Very pretty with all of the trees turning every color. Rural countryside really is quite pretty.

Have 2 1/2 days crew rest and then probably west again. No one in our airplane goes to Europe any more (except Embassy Run). We have a lot of trips from El Toro, Calif to Kadena AFB, Okinawa to Da Nang AB, S. Vietnam to rotate Marines to and from the combat zone. When I leave, I'll spend most of my time between Travis and Clark.

All except Travis are very nice and warm, so I look forward to every Pacific trip.

It's noon and I'm going back to bed to try to catch up on some lost sleep.

Don't work too hard.

Love
John

3 Nov 1965

Dear Carol,

Nice to have a letter waiting here for me when I got home Monday. You sound busy, of course. As long as you stay ahead of everything, it's all good. It really sounds like an interesting life. And of course it brings back many pleasant memories of my "Activity Jock" days.

O.K. About Christmas gifts (by the way, I called Mother last night to wish her a Happy Birthday. Told her about gifts for Grandmothers from Japan. Plan to buy Philippine cigars for Grandpa.) Am anxious to hear what Mother has to say about washer. And I hope Daddy will get a chair. I will look for a salt and pepper set (wooden). Am sure I can find one for less.

You and the folks want to know what I want. Most anything I want or need I already have, or else none of us can afford the other things. And the smaller things I can use I can get cheaper overseas. So I am very difficult to shop for. And don't send money. I have more than enough of that too. You mention the apartment. Could use a maid, but have been looking for six

months and can't find one. Could also use some drapes, but size would be complicated. I may get a chance to go skiing this winter, so will need new ski pants (36 waist) and could use a couple of sweaters (ski or otherwise) size Large. Don't really need anything. I know that's no help, but at least I'll understand when I get nothing.

I have an idea! Pack up one of your good looking sorority sisters, send her out here to cook and clean by day and sleep in to entertain us at night. What I need more than anything for Christmas is a good mistress. Put a note on the bulletin board to ask for volunteers.

Enough of that.

I'll probably leave tomorrow on a trip. We're short of pilots, as always, so don't get much time here. But it's a good life. It's nice and warm in the Pacific.

Hope the Great Pumpkin was good to you.

Love,
John

I'm sure some of you are wondering about my marital status. Well, I'm still very much single – and will probably remain so for some time. Enough said.

I'm sorry I won't be home for Christmas this year. Christmas Day itself will probably be spent somewhere between here and Saigon. Thanksgiving Day was observed in the Philippines. I strongly believe we belong in Vietnam and want to do my part to help the overall situation. As I look back on the year I realize again that it has been a very good year. Destiny and the Air Force have been good to me. I hope that the holiday season is as full of pleasant memories for you as it will be for me.

I send each of you best wishes for a very Merry Christmas, a jovial holiday season and a prosperous, healthy and Happy New Year.

Mulberry Jam

One of our childhood treats that John could have requested and that he would have enjoyed would have been jars of Mulberry Jam. While he was flying around the world and could shop for exotic products, there was nothing like Mother's Mulberry Jam. It's hard to find even in specialty stores and even online these days.

One of my favorite memories is of my parents coming to visit me in Oshkosh, Wisconsin in the fall of 1969 when I had started my first professional job at what was then Wisconsin State University at Oshkosh. I was Assistant Dean of Students (former Dean of Women position) and it was a 600-mile drive for them, so I was thrilled they came to see me. They brought with them wonderful birthday gifts for my September birthday... mulberry jam. It was the perfect gift from thoughtful and always hard-working parents. There was just nothing like Mother's mulberry jam. It took lots of effort, and was messy, but oh so worth it. Our whole family loved that jam.

In case you've never experienced this delicious treat, here is what it takes: To harvest the ripe mulberries, which are a deep purple, I would help take the clean but stained bed sheets that had been used the year before for the same purpose. (We stored those special sheets in the northwest storeroom of our big two-story house. See, the directions are everywhere in our lives!) We would lay them on the ground under the trees and then forcefully shake the tree and all the ripe clustered berries would fall on the sheets. Plump ripe mulberries are about the size of a thumbnail and are deep purple. They stained everything they touched, including our hands and clothes as well as those sheets. Then we would transfer them to a pail and take them to the house for washing and sorting. Mother would make the jam, and John and I would always be available for sampling, especially me, the queen of sugar, even back then. Mother would preserve the jam in jars for the winter.

Chapter 6

Early 1966

17 February 1966
Thursday

Dear Carol,

I guess I'm long enough overdue on a letter that I shouldn't even mention it. So I won't.

Been home two weeks now. Got a vacation for strep throat. Have to take penicillin pills for 10 days and started last Wednesday (9 Feb). Don't have a sore throat now, but have to take pills so I don't get a relapse. So I'm enjoying my vacation.

Been doing my share of partying and dating. Went to NYC and saw Skyscraper, playbill enclosed. A good musical that opened a few months ago. Really enjoyed it. There was an article and some good pictures in LIFE magazine a few weeks or a month or so ago. Might look them up. You can mention all this to folks whenever you go home next; take Playbill along then.

The article (ad) from United Air Lines indicates how bad they need pilots for all the new airplanes they're buying. Read it and send it on to the folks now.

Last trip we visited the wineries of Napa Valley near St. Helena in Northern California. Interesting, and of course there was the usual tasting session afterward. On the way home

through Travis we spent a night on the town in San Francisco. That was great! A real city, sophisticated, lively, and a lot of fun.

Will probably be leaving on a trip this weekend. Be good, have fun, and don't work too hard.

Love
John

A C-135 co-pilot moving along the airways of the world, supporting the Air Force interests at many spots over the globe. MATS, the Air Force Command I worked for, had its name changed to Military Airlift Command. Congressman Mendel Rivers said MAC was more dignified. Maybe.

I flew a couple more Embassy Flights. The round-the-world trips. The second week in January our airplane broke down at Madrid, Spain for three days. I enjoyed seeing much of that grand old city both by day and by night. The last week of February saw us depart McGuire AFB, New Jersey on an Eastbound Embassy Flight. After ten stops (three to sleep) and 55 hours flying time, we arrived from the west 103 ½ hours elapsed time after departure. Anytime anybody tells you that they circled the globe in four days and stopped ten times—don't let them tell you it wasn't a rushed trip!

3 March 1966
Thursday

Hello-

At 2 PM last Saturday the Squadron called me to go on the eastbound Embassy Run at 3 PM. I hurriedly repacked and went. We took off at 5:25 PM Saturday, went east, the first to go all the way around the world since the one I was on in September and landed back at McGuire at 1 AM this morning. A total elapsed time of 103 hours, 35 minutes!

Flying time was 45 hrs. 5 minutes and we made ten stops enroute, sleeping at Torregon, Spain; New Delhi, India; and Clark AB, Philippines. 45 hrs. flying time in 4 days, 7 hrs. The

fastest, most hectic trip I've ever made. I am very tired and hungry didn't eat the last 24 hrs (Clark to Hawaii to Travis to McGuire – a long day).

I just got up (noon), am going to get something to eat and go back to bed.

As I look back, I can hardly believe the whole thing was real. Around the world, literally, in 104 hours!

And I'm very tired. Will close now and try to write again before I leave.

Love

John

P.S. We left 40 hrs behind schedule because of snow and broken airplane. We made up that 40 hrs and landed here about 30 minutes ahead of schedule.

22 March 1966
Tuesday

Dear Carol,

I guess I'm sufficiently overdue a letter to feel guilty enough to write. And I'm not nearly as busy as you.

Read with great interest your letters. Congrats on your high grades and recent honors, elections and appointments. Wish I would have done as well as you are.

Maybe folks told you I flew Embassy Run around world in 103 1/2 hours. Trip I just got off of was regular Pacific trip. Was on Okinawa while Astronauts Scott and Armstrong were there. One of our Squadron's crews and airplanes brought them home to Cape Kennedy.

Weather here is beautiful. May celebrate official arrival of Spring by putting the top down and going driving.

Got a card from Rich Halbert[1] saying only —"What ever happened to John Bischoff?" so I sent him a letter and asked about the house and some of the guys I used to know there. Am wondering if old Theta Xi is slowly sliding. What's your

[1] fraternity brother

opinion? I don't hear much of course. Nothing else to say, I guess.

Still leading the same life and loving it.

Love, John

The remainder of the spring was spent hauling troops to and from Vietnam across the Pacific.

Thursday

Hello-

Arrived home yesterday afternoon from Pacific. Route was El Toro[2]-Wake-Kadina (Okinawa)-El Toro-here. Leg from Kadena to El Toro is 5880 nautical miles, 11+30 hours flying time. A long day considering we'd been awake about 16 hours before we took off.

On Wed the 11th we went over the Pawnee City VOR radio station[3] about 12 noon CST at 35,000 ft. I listened to KFAB news and weather just like on the ground. (I saw and flew around a big thunderstorm in N Central Kansas and hope you got some rain.)

Received very nice letter from Sara Boyden.[4] She thanked me warmly for the [wedding] gift and mentioned she'd seen you and Grandma but you hadn't mentioned my being in Nebraska. She invited me to visit her and Chuck in Lincoln. A very nice letter indeed. Is cool, rainy and foggy here.

Love

John

Send enclosed Time article to Carol when thru, then send to me.

[2]San Diego

[3]20 miles from our farm in Tecumseh, Nebraska

[4]long-time high school girlfriend

23 May 1966
Monday

Hello-

Got slides today. Pencil numbers are mine. You can rearrange if you like. Also take out #16 and 22 also. They're duplicates, so not really necessary. Hope I did okay on photo endeavors.

A beautiful weekend here. First real sunshiny period we've had—cool, cloudy and damp all Spring. But is now summer. And the countryside is just beautiful! So many flowers, green green grass, dogwood trees, lilacs—all in multicolored bloom. So much flower odor in the air you can smell it while driving. Top on car up and down a few times a day.

[The remaining pages of this letter are missing.]

A week in May was spent in Nebraska climaxed by witnessing my sister Carol tapped as a member of Mortar Board, the Senior Women's honorary at the University of Nebraska.

Mortar Board Ceremony: The Best Day of My Life

Saturday May 7, 1966 was the best day of my life. Ivy Day at the University of Nebraska was one of those old traditions that had stood the test of time. It was a day when there was a May Queen and her court, all of whom were a small group of highly selected freshman pages, and sophomore and junior women attendants who excelled in scholarship, leadership and service to the university. But the biggest, and for many of us, the most suspenseful part of the day was the "tapping" of the new Mortar Boards and Innocents. That latter was the men's senior honor society with only and always thirteen members.

The Mortar Board criteria were also superior scholarship, leadership and service. They could select from ten to twenty women, and you never knew how many would be selected. For me, the real suspense was that, even though I knew as a junior I could possibly be selected, if I didn't make it into Mortar Board,

I was going to be really disappointed. If you had come close and hadn't made it, you might have been selected for the May Day Court. If you hadn't made that, and I hadn't, you either made Mortar Board, or you got nothing. I feared the last.

Unknown to anyone else, since before I entered the University of Nebraska, one of my primary goals was to be a Mortar Board. To me, it was the culmination of all the things I valued most highly: the best grades I could achieve, involvement and leadership in a variety of organizations, and ultimately, broad-based service to the flagship university of my home state.

The biggest factor that led me to this goal was my brother, John, who was four years older than me and had graduated from the University as I graduated from high school. He was a campus leader, a BMOC[5], and a great role model for me. He was president of his fraternity his junior year – a real honor – was a major section editor of the huge Cornhusker yearbook, and was a leader in other organizations, while placing a priority on doing his best as an Air Force ROTC student and serving as President of Arnold Air Society. The latter was in preparation for a career in the Air Force. He loved to fly, and got his private pilot license his senior year of college.

The "tapping" consisted of the current senior Mortar Board members walking mysteriously around in their black caps and gowns, with crossed arms, and black masks covering their faces. Since the Nebraska chapter was Black Mask chapter of the national organization, they selected or "tapped" their new surprised members by coming up behind the woman sitting on the grass in the midst of her friends, and quickly placing the mask over the newly selected member. Numerous new Mortar Boards had been tapped, but would there by more? Was it over? Had I been left out? There was tension in the thousands gathered on the lawn.

And then, one of the flowing black gowns was upon me and she had put a black mask over my head. I was tapped!

[5]Big Man On Campus

I was elated. I had made it! Three years of hard work and I had achieved my highest goal. This was more important than graduating Summa cum laude to me since it indicated a balanced list of accomplishments. I was thrilled. But wait, there was more. As they added the chair for me to sit, someone from behind handed me a dozen red roses. It was John! I knew my brother was halfway around the world flying for the Air Force and wouldn't have been able to come on this special day. But he was there, on the most important day of my life. I was totally overwhelmed. It turns out that they notify parents, and tell them to keep the news secret, and they shared it with John, who was able to arrange to be there.

Since he'd been a well-known campus leader just four years before, he knew what a tremendous honor this was, and what it meant to me. He was so proud of me and what I'd accomplished, and he'd made every effort to be there. He had been such a shining star in so many ways and now I, in my own way, had achieved the top honor. He had been my role model and I'd taken it to the next level.

In going through their belongings after my parents had both died, in 2007, I found two special letters from John that my mother had saved. One was written 22 March 1966 and the other was 4 April 1966, the months just prior to the May Mortar Board tapping. In the March letter he mentioned that he had requested time off in May to come to Nebraska. He noted that he'd have to plan his trip and sign out before my parents got the notice if I was going to be selected. Because he was flying burn victims back from the Vietnam War, his schedule was somewhat inflexible.

He noted "If I'm stuck in the Pacific and can't get home it won't make any difference [if I were selected or not]." Then he said: "P.S. Don't tell Carol I'm coming." He wanted it to be a surprise and boy was it. He knew the suspense of the day and knew he could make it the best day of my life and he did.

During June and July I was able to fulfill a long harbored desire to live in Washington, DC. I worked for the Special Mission Squadron at Andrews AFB. These are the people who fly Air Force One, The President, and other government dignitaries. They were getting some of our airplanes and we helped them fly until all of their people were checked out. It was a very interesting experience. We were on call most of the time and I flew one trip; took Secretary of the Navy Nitze to Danang, S. Vietnam for an inspection trip. He was met by Marine General Walt and escorted around the country for five days while we, the crew, waited for him in Bangkok, Thailand. It made a very nice shopping trip. We picked up the Secretary in Saigon where General Westmoreland saw him off. Twenty-seven hours later we landed at Andrews after a refueling stop in Honolulu. The remainder of my stay in Washington was spent partying, availing myself of the many secretaries that make up the very favorable, fabled, female/male radio, and also sight-seeing. I learned something of the Washington Press Corps, a special breed of people. Congress and the Supreme Court were in session and it was an interesting time to be in Washington. I took the time to view most of the Smithsonian Institution, a sizable endeavor.

Chapter 7

End of 1966

4 July 1966
Monday

Dear Carol

Received folks letter on Friday telling of your trip to Colorado Springs. Hope you had a good time. Water skiing, swimming and all that. Would like to hear about it if you have time. I know I don't write much.

I'm leaving on the 9th for an 8-day trip to take some congressmen to Vietnam. That's the schedule, at least.

This has turned out to be a real vacation. Lots of sightseeing, swimming, dating, movies, parties and drinking. Have been working on the Smithsonian Institution. A solid week project. Need about another day to see the rest. By then will have done about all the sightseeing I want to do. I have a nice sun tan, in case that makes you jealous.

I saw "Who's Afraid of Virginia Wolff?" with Richard Burton and Elizabeth Taylor written by Edward Albee. A very powerful movie. One of the best I've ever seen. A tremendous plot (I'd seen the play) with fantastic acting. Burton is phenomenal. Make sure you see it.

Am enclosing check for folks' gift. Thanks for getting it.

Don't work too hard.

Do you want to come East in August? Think about it.
John

On July 26, A Day That Will Live In Infamy, *I was notified that I had been ordered to fly an F-105 in Southeast Asia. So I packed up and went back to New Jersey the same day. I went on one last trip to do some shopping in the Orient- then to Fairchild AFB in Spokane, Washington for a three-week survival school.*

10 August 1966
Wed night

Hello –

Got back from regular Pacific trip. Hadn't been on one since mid-May. Didn't change too much though. Bought Jeanie a set of china. Boy is that a lot of work to carry home. Hope she likes it. Spent 3 days at Clark. Lots of stewardesses there flying the military contract flights. Very nice – beautiful young, single women, well kept, dressed, tanned and all wearing bikinis. All worldly, interesting, friendly and transient. A pleasant group. Not much else to tell about on trip.

Very hot and muggy here. Planning a big party Friday night.
Love
John

China Patterns

John called me one Saturday morning when I was working as a receptionist at our local mortuary (another story). He told me it would be his last trip for shopping, and asked what pattern of china I wanted. I had been poring over the brochures he had sent for weeks, and fortunately knew the simple elegance gold-rimmed dishes I wanted: Goldwyn pattern by Noritaki. And those 12-place settings are now my treasured items that he hand-carried back to Nebraska that I now have on the coast of

Maine. Lucky me.

On a previous trip, he brought back a comparable 12-place setting of Noritaka china for our Aunt Jeannie Miller. Hers has a platinum edge. Uncle Harold (my mother's brother, and Aunt Jeannie's husband) had seen our big teak mother and baby elephant, and John brought back a trio of elephants for them.

11 August 1966
Thursday

Hello-

Received your letter today. Guess I'll inform you that I'm leaving for survival school (it's been moved to Fairchild AFB, Spokane, Wash) on Saturday and be back here about the 2nd or 3rd of Sept. Will fly both ways. Will be around here for about a week to get things straightened up for the movers to come. I have to be at McConnell AFB, Wichita, Kansas by September 21st. Will drive and plan to spend some time in Nebraska.

I'm sending some address changes and having some things sent to Nebr. so don't be surprised. Got the pictures of the Bangkok floating market. Turned out good so I'll bring them with me.

Mike and I are planning a party tomorrow night. Karen and Sharpe Rideout plan to come, among other people. Hope it turns out all right.

I have an instrument check ride tomorrow morning. So I guess I'll get some sleep.

Will write next time from Fairchild.

Love
John

P.S. Larry Wusk is at Phang Rang (50-100 mi south of Cam Rahn Bay) along with Bob Vinegar who writes occasionally, and Gary Thrasher. Thanks for the clipping.

After a 1 1/2 week delay in Nebraska (during which I observed close up, the fabled Nebraska Football Team) I settled at McConnell AFB, Wichita, Kansas. My job during the 4 ½ month school is to learn to fly the F-105 Thunderchief, use the airplane as a weapon, and understand the myriad new rules and procedures of Tactical Air Command.

This new assignment is very different from the transport business. The airplane is a single engine, single seat, supersonic (1500 mph) jet fighter. The school is quite good. The instructors all have combat experience in Southeast Asia, many with 100 missions over North Vietnam. The flying mission is very different from the transport where a prime consideration was a smooth ride. It is a new and different experience to hurl your pink body at the ground at a 45 degree angle at 500 or 600 mph while trying to hit a target with a dive bomb. Or shoot the gun at a target at that speed while trying to be sparing with bullets that are expended at 100 per second. All while traveling over the ground at 1000' per second at altitudes measured in a few hundred feet or less. A typical (if there is such a thing) mission in Southeast Asia would probably carry two external 450-gal. fuel tanks and six or eight 750 lb. bombs. This along with internal fuel and the internal Gatling Gunn 20 mm cannon would be the load—approximately 52,000 pounds take-off gross weight. It is a big fighter.

The F-105

It had been conceived to carry the new tactical nuclear weapons designed by the national laboratories during the early 1950s. Its target would be the Soviet Union during the height of the cold war, operating from well-equipped bases in Germany and Japan. Instead, it found itself in the jungles of Thailand, surrounded by heat and humidity, trying to fight a war as dictated by politicians 7,000 miles away. Too many missions

were flown with only a few bombs per aircraft, simply so Washington could count sorties. Too many crews never came back.

The F-105 holds the distinction of being the only American combat aircraft withdrawn from service simply because there were not enough of them remaining to be tactically useful. The Thunderchiefs flew 159,795 combat missions in Southeast Asia, resulting in the loss of 334 aircraft, most of them to North Vietnamese anti-aircraft fire. This was almost half the combat-capable F-105s built. One hundred fifty-six crew members were listed as killed in action or missing in action.[1]



John in his F-105 Thunderchief

[1] Dennis Jenkins, *Thunderchief: The Complete History of the Republic F-105.*

Chapter 8

McConnell Air Force Base, Wichita, Kansas: 1966–1967

Fall 1966
John was in F-105 jet fighter training at McConnell AFB in Wichita, Kansas. Therefore he was within driving distance to attend a special event in my life. He made the four-hour trip north for the final evening of the Nebraska Centennial Queen pageant at the Pershing Auditorium in downtown Lincoln. I was very honored that he made the effort to come see the pageantry. It was an amazing week in the middle of a busy fall semester of my senior year of college. I missed all of my classes and failed the mid-term of my art history class the next week. I feared that would keep me out of grad school. Fortunately, my other grades allowed me to graduate, and to get into my chosen graduate school, Indiana University in Bloomington.

The *Tecumseh Chieftain*, the local weekly paper, noted the event:

> There are 71 County Centennial Queens who will compete in the five-day Miss Nebraska Centennial Queen Contest and Pageant in Lincoln. Johnson

County's entry is the lovely and talented Miss Carol Bischoff of Tecumseh.



Arnold, Leona, John and Carol in 1966

Saturday
19 Nov 66

Dear Carol,

There is an outside chance I may have next Friday off. I won't know until Wednesday afternoon, though. But I'd like for you to bring home your typewriter so I can do my Christmas letter on Ditto Masters if I have the whole weekend off.

I flew a ground attack mission every day this week. That is lots of fun. I'm getting so that I can hit the targets – sometimes. But it sure is fun.

Hope things are going well for you – academically, socially and politically.

My plans for Christmas are gong to be modified somewhat. All accommodations at Aspen and Vail were filled (reserved) by last summer. So will have to see.

Will close

John

10 December 1966
Saturday afternoon

Hello-

I've just spent a few hours looking at tape recorders.[1] There are many to choose from I found. Since I plan to buy one for myself later, I think you should purchase one with you in mind. And unless you will buy tapes and listen to music (which I doubt) – then anything sufficient to send letters on is good enough. In this category all are portable, some are battery and AC powered, some battery only, all are mono (as opposed to stereo), usually play no larger than a 3 inch reel and at 2 speeds (1 7/8 ips and 3 3/4 ips). Most are solid state (transistor) and cost less than $50. Something in this category I'd recommend – unless you plan to use it for music listening.

[1] My parents and John were planning to communicate while he was in Thailand by sending 3" reel to reel tapes back and forth. We did this throughout his time at Takhli, and I still have the tapes, in a fireproof box.

I arrived at a nice speed and convenient time Wed morning. A pleasant trip back.

Antifreeze is good to -15° so maybe we should put in some more before going to Colorado.

After being rejected by most I found a sheet metal man who was willing to do a project as small as my movie camera clamp. It will be a week till he is through (very busy, old, and a one-man shop). He gets $6/hr plus materials. Most of the rest get $8.[2]

On Thursday's refueling missions my second, and first with the basket at the end of the 9 ft. hose, I broke the basket off of the tanker and brought it home stuck on the probe of my airplane. We were in the first of 3 flights to refuel off of that tanker. The flight behind us had already taken off and had to cancel their refueling, fly around to burn out of gas to get light enough to land. The third flight was called and cancelled just as they were starting engines.

I didn't break any pieces off of the hose so no pieces were ingested by the engine. So I landed with this big basket (24" diameter, 75 lbs.) hanging on the side of the nose of my airplane. Very embarrassing. So I had to buy an hours worth of beer for about 20 people.

Agneta[3] is coming Friday afternoon and leaving Sunday at 1 p.m. so we won't drive to Nebraska. There is a class party Friday night and a friend's (bachelor) party Saturday night so I hope she enjoys her stay here.

We lost Monday and Friday of this week for bad weather. We're still 3 or so days ahead of schedule so hope I can come home on 21st. Will not know until the 16th.

Will close and mail this today.
Love
John

[2] John had a custom bracket made for a small movie camera so he that could start recording just before he was making a bombing run. This way, we could see what it was really like.

[3] girlfriend of a few months or more; she later sent a Swedish horse for good luck

Living in the Midwest again is a lot different from the East. Things I miss: The New York Times; Broadway plays; so much recreation and entertainment so close; and intelligent, sophisticated and interesting women. Things I don't miss: The Traffic; high prices; unfriendly sales people; slums; and the tendency for the streams and air to be something less than clear and fresh.

28 Dec 1966

[On Copper Kettle brochure/card, Aspen, CO]

It is now -9° in Glenwood Springs so we will be starting a bit late. Arrived in Aspen at noon yesterday. It is all I expected it to be. Saw Kent Hildreth[4] in Boulder on Monday night. No car or road trouble at all.

Ate dinner at Copper Kettle last night. Probably the best meal I have ever eaten. This country is beautiful and the slopes are in good shape. It was -5° on slope at 3 PM yesterday. Will be much colder there now, so will go late. It snows some but is very cold. Having a great time.

John

8 Jan 1967
Sunday

Dear Carol,

Thanks for the nice card and very interesting letter. I sure am glad you had such a good time. You staying out until 5 AM!! And drinking too!! You're a real swinger and get my OK stamp of approval. I finally have a swinging sister. That's cool.[5]

I'm sorry you have any guilt concerning writing to me. Anyone who would take time out of swinging in New Orleans to do something silly like write to a brother who can be written to later – that anyone is a fool (and that sentence matches yours). I'm glad you got to all those places at night and still managed

[4] fraternity brother

[5] Note: I had gone to New Orleans with college sorority sisters for the Sugar Bowl football game, in which Nebraska played. It was the only time I went to an away game, and was a big, great trip for me.

to do some daytime sightseeing. It really is a grand old city. Am also glad you got a Hurricane Glass. Did you drink all of it yourself?

After a few days partying like that you might understand why I liked New York so much. And don't like Kansas. **And will never be a farmer.**



John was not, as it turned out, a future farmer

I had a great time skiing. The first day, the first morning on the way to the chair lift, I was proposed to by two girls and propositioned by three more sweet young things—all because of that neat cool ski sweater I was wearing. Naturally I declined all advances/offers in order to expose me and my sweater to more girls on the slopes rather than a few in the lodge. I was the best dressed man at Aspen, including Secretary McNamara and Senator-elect Percy. Just by putting my sweater on I was instantly unfair to all competition.

Aspen was all I expected it to be and more. The night life is great. And so was the skiing But it was very cold. On the first day it was -5° at 3 PM at the base of slope – the high for



The famous ski sweater

the day. On Thursday at 10 AM at base of slope at Vail it was still -11° F. So didn't ski Vail. Very nice place though. Drove back to Denver and spent 2 days partying there. New Year's Eve with the Schmeckles[6]. A good time was had by all. Got up at 3 PM New Year's Day and left Denver at 5 PM for a 9 hour drive to Wichita so I could be here to watch the game on color TV. I should have stayed in Denver or something.[7] Have been flying and going to class since. Got to George AFB, Calif Friday morning.

[6] his fraternity brother
[7] Nebraska lost

All of the new Majors threw a big promotions party Friday night. Four hours of free drinks – yeah. Otherwise an extremely uneventful birthday. Which was fine. I didn't even cry because I'm 25 now. I don't feel any older now. 'Til I meet someone who's 21 or so. Then I feel old. Almost.

Will close and write to the folks. I called them when I got back here (evening of Jan 2) and said I had absolutely no car or road trouble on my trip. A nice vacation. Thanks again for the perfect ski sweater.

Love, John



John's F-105 Pilot license, issued 10 February 1967

25 Jan 67

Dear Carol,

Received your letter and enjoyed it. Good luck with finals.

Am glad to hear your social life is going so well. Am looking forward to discussing Dr. Zhivago with you. I saw it the second time in Denver and enjoyed it much more than the first.

I fired my first air-to-air missile today. It is heat seeking and is used to shoot down MIGs. Made a nice big orange explosion. We use a 5" rocket for a target.

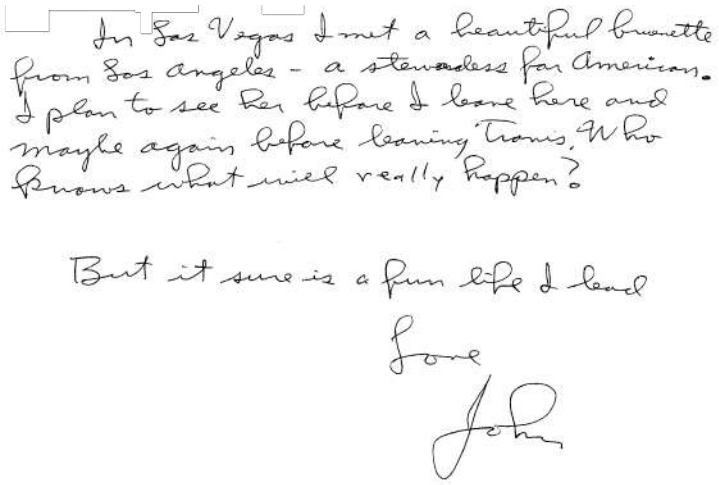
I guess the folks haven't told you they asked us if we wanted 30 days leave prior to Port Call. After hesitation and some phone calls, I said YES. So I should be leaving Travis sometime during the first week of March. On Febr 18th I'm leaving New York for a week in the Caribbean, Bermuda or somewhere and I hope the folks take a week's vacation somewhere in there. They said they would, which was a factor in helping me decide to take 30 days leave.

The folks asked about moving the date for the family dinner. But I said to simplify things, we'd better leave it on February 5th. So I'll see you then.

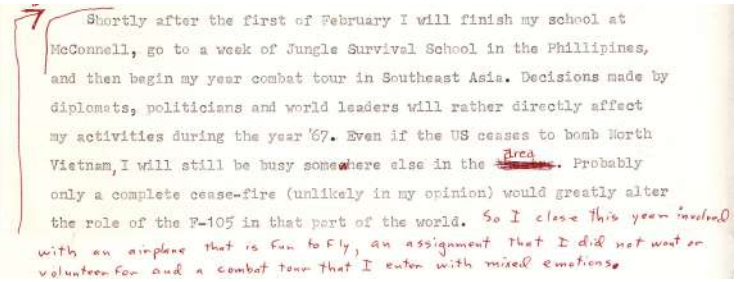
In Las Vegas I met a beautiful brunette from Los Angeles – a stewardess for American. I plan to see her before I leave here and maybe again before leaving Travis. Who knows what will REALLY happen?

But it sure is a fun life I lead.

Love, John



Shortly after the first of February I will finish my school at McConnell, go to a week of Jungle Survival School in the Philippines, and then begin my year combat tour in Southeast Asia. Decisions made by diplomats, politicians and world leaders will rather directly affect my activities during the year '67. Even if the US ceases to bomb North Vietnam, I will still be busy somewhere else in the area. Probably only a complete cease-fire (unlikely in my opinion) would greatly alter the role of the F-105 in that part of the world. ***So I close this year involved with an airplane that is fun to fly, an assignment that I did not want or volunteer for and a combat tour that I enter with mixed emotions.***


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Chapter 9

Takhli Royal Thai Air Force Base: Spring 1967

From Wikipedia:

> On 19 April 1967, Major Leo K. Thorsness won the Medal of Honor on another F-105 mission from Takhli. The Major destroyed one SAM site with a missile, bombed another, shot down a MiG, damaged another, and repeatedly chased or lured other MiGs away from an ongoing rescue mission for his wingman, who had been shot down by AAA fire. Thorsness' back-seater, Captain Harold E. Johnson, was awarded the Air Force Cross for the mission. Less than two weeks after this mission, the two were shot down and became prisoners of war.

This is a snapshot of the war that John was entering. He flew numerous similar missions where he assisted in shooting down MIGs, and encountered severe ground fire as well as Vietnam fighters chasing him while firing thousands of rounds at the attacking planes, all while releasing his bombs on the intended targets.

Not knowing that I was going to write a book about his life, and since I had no place to properly display them, I donated

John's many framed awards to the Johnson County Veterans' Association. For years they were displayed in the large Veteran's Memorial display at the drug store on the west side of the square in Tecumseh, Nebraska. Therefore, the more complete listing of his numerous awards will need to be researched.



John's patches

22 Mar 67

Dear Carol

Hello from Thailand. I'm here at last. Settled and happy. Live in air conditioned quarters, close to Officers Club and swimming pool.

Really enjoyed jungle survival school. A very good course. Informative, pertinent, and fun too. The only snakes I saw were in cages. The jungle is a very pretty place when you take the time to study it close up.

Arrived here this morning and spent the day running errands and turning in records, etc. Tomorrow I start 3 days of briefings. And then I FLY. Yeah! One member of our class at McConnell has 5 missions already. I'm anxious to get started.

I haven't got much else to say. I guess I told you that the day I left Omaha I called Kathy. At my suggestion, she may call you next time she's in Lincoln. I think she's a very fine gal.[1]

Had a great weekend in San Francisco. Went to winery, U of C Berkeley campus (50,000 students on one campus!) and saw lots of San Francisco. A great city. Pretty and fun. And

[1]Kathy was one of John's love interests and frequent correspondents. She was married at the time, to a man named Roger.

Agneta was very glad to see me too. So it was a very fine weekend. Will close now and catch up on sleep.

Love

John



John with his F-105, labeled CAPT BISCHOFF

28 March 67

Dear Carol,

Flew my first mission yesterday. So I've been to North Vietnam now. Flew a training mission the day before. Refuel on both and didn't fall off of the tanker. Mission yesterday was rather standard. Dropped six 750 lb. bombs. A good feeling to do it for real finally.



John's picture, which he took from the cockpit of the F-105 while he was flying, of refueling from the tanker

I've got to forecast preferences within 10 days of arrival. Think I'll ask for Europe. Probably Germany, England and Spain in that order. If I don't get that, I'll be asking for TAC and F-4 plane in Florida, ATC and R-38 in Arizona and ADC and F-106 in California, also in that order. All of which may not make any difference if I'm not needed any of these places. So who knows? **I'll like what I get anyway. I always seem to make the best of things and be happy.**

It is hot here. Not so humid yet. The rains start in a month

or so. Now it's just hot. Around 100° F each afternoon. But squadron and living quarters are air conditioned. So get a good night's sleep at least. Not really so bad at all here. Except no round eyed women.

Love
John

Friday
31 March 67

Dear Carol,

I AM proud of you if you drank green beer on St. Patrick's Day. It can be done with good sense and moderation and a good time be had by all. That's what I've been saying for years, and trying to do. The moderation, I mean.

Flew #2 yesterday. Only 98 to go. Turned out to be a four hour mission. BOY was I tired! Refueled 3 times! Took on 9000, 3000, and 11,000 lbs of fuel. So I'm getting pretty good at refueling. The weather is so bad – hazy and smoky. We flew all over trying to find some thing to hit. We couldn't see any of our planned targets. We found a small bridge and destroyed it. So the mission wasn't wasted.

Don't write to Kathy. She'll call when she gets to Lincoln. She's quite intelligent and interesting. I think you'll enjoy meeting her.

It is so hot here. Over 100° every day. Was 104° or 105° today. But the air conditioners cool the place off at night, so sleep is no problem.

Hope you have a nice time at the wedding.

Do use and enjoy my car. The only word of caution I might add is – don't put the top down while it is still wet. Otherwise use it as much as you like. You can't wear the top motors out, so use them. It's VERY quick and easy to put it up and down. Don't even have to get out of the front seat. Just remember not to put top UP when the windows are up. The red cover to put over lowered top is in NE storeroom in a black plastic container. Use it if you like (plan to leave top down a while,

etc). It just snaps into place. And the entire car could use a good Simonize wax job. Hasn't been done since last July. Don't park the car under any trees if you can help it – regularly, at least, and wash it fairly often – like once a week or so. It's much better for the finish.

But above all – use it and enjoy it. Put the top down and up as often as you like. If it is sluggish coming "up" at first, just push UP on the arms on the side while holding button in "up" position. It often needs help the first 6 or 8 inches starting to come up. But be sure to use it. You can't wear it out. So enjoy it.

Love,
John

Saturday
1 April 67

Dear Carol,

Received today your Tuesday letter. Pretty good service. Be sure and put box # on all mail. I put 8 cents on letters because we're not officially in a combat zone. Only admitted we're here and bomb the North since about March 1st. So don't get free mail, etc. like the troops in S. Vietnam. Pilots get combat pay and tax exemption only if we get into N. Vietnam each month (all F-105 pilots do) but ground troops don't get either. All in S. Vietnam do. It's a funny war.

The rainy season starts in a month or so. Is quite dry now. Over 100° every day.

Do mail commercial pilot's license. What do you mean – ride with me on a mission that's exciting! ALL missions are exciting!!

I read with great interest your comments concerning Tom. I understand how you feel and your dilemma. And I enjoyed hearing about it. Often talking (verbally on paper) about something like that helps to sort out a person's thoughts. I think, without a doubt, you're doing the right thing. And I think it's very commendable you're so concerned about how best

to break the news. You're so kind—and the coolest gal in the whole world.

Don't forget – I needed to talk with someone about Kathy too. And the night in Lincoln with you was one of the most memorable I've ever had. I appreciated your company and perceptive understanding. I can't believe Arnold and Lorene Jacobsen. And remember how the folks used to (high school age) contrast their Uncle Fred's approach to privileges to the ones we got? How about that? Raising children well is probably the ultimate and supreme challenge in life. And I think our parents did quite well.

Am sorry Daddy isn't going to the wedding. But I understand and realize he's probably happiest that way. He won't worry about things if he's there (staying in Nebr.). So inform me about the cousins, Eldon, Ruby, etc.

Am flying # 3 mission with Col. Hill at 6:40 AM so will close and sleep.

Be nice to Tom (I know you will) but be firm, too. Besides, on a light note, you know how I feel about drinking!!

Love
John

Friday eve
7 April 67

Dear Carol,

Received your letter of Tuesday, April 4th. Very good service.

I got two letters from Kathy today. That made me very happy. Roger's relief pharmacist was transferred so he works a lot more than before. Kathy is even more alone than before. She wishes I were in Omaha. So do I. But since I'm not, I wish you could go to Omaha some weekend (he works every Saturday and every other Sunday) and have a long talk with Kathy. She needs to be cheered up a bit. Or a lot. She's lonesome and needs someone to talk to. You'd be absolutely perfect. And she wants to know a lot more about me, also.

And I trust you to tell her whatever she want to know about me. You have her phone numbers and the hospital. Call person-to-person. Or write to her at her new address, just acquired for my benefit:

Kathleen... PO Box... Omaha, Nebraska

Whatever you prefer. I've told her you know all about us and that I want the two of you to get acquainted. I think she's a very intelligent woman. I request two simultaneous approaches: (1) evaluate her as a mature young woman and tell me honestly what you think of her, (2) treat her as a woman I'm in love with, and converse with her openly and honestly as an old friend. Listen to her and have a good woman-to-woman talk. I think you'd both find it very rewarding. Try to work it out some weekend if you can. Let me know if you're interested.

I'm glad you enjoyed your trip to Colo. even if you were tired from driving. Too bad it was a dry wedding.[2] I'll bet Grandpa Miller didn't like it either. If you marry anyone besides Tom, yours shouldn't be dry either! And you know mine will be VERY wet!

Gas mileage for my car was normal.

I've got 5 missions now. Only 95 to go. And already I want to come home to see Kathy. Hell of a deal. Please take good care of her for me. You'd do such a good job of all of the delicate fine points. I trust you completely with something so important in my life as my relationship with Kathy.

Be nice to, but firm, with Tom.

And thanks for listening to me.

Love,

John

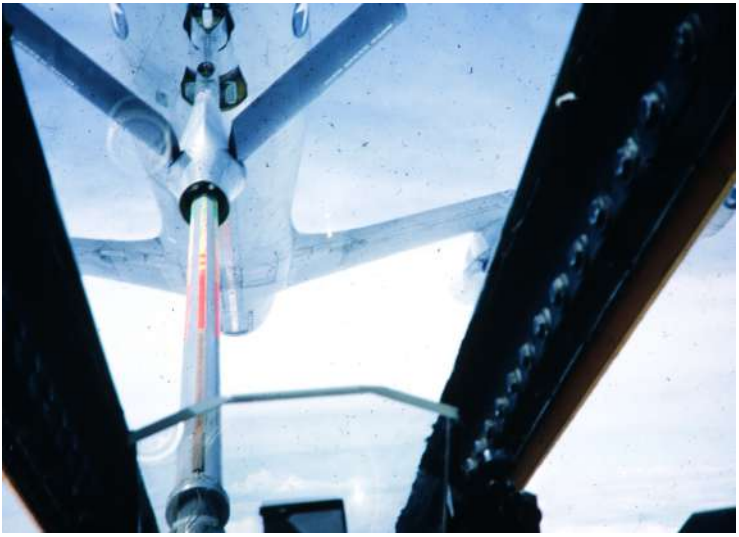
[2]Wilma Stark, John's cousin, let us know that this was her wedding.

Tuesday Evening
April 11, 1967

Dear Carol,

I received today your very nice letter typed last weekend. I'm sorry to hear you're ill and hope this letter finds you well. I know how strong cold pills can be.

Today I flew #9



John's picture, which he took from the cockpit of the F-105 while he was flying, of "hanging on the boom refueling"

Yesterday I flew a 4 hour and 45 minute mission. It's a long story I may tell when I get home. But my rear end sure was sore. And still is today. But what I want to tell is this. While I was hanging on the boom refueling (during one of several) the tanker went into a turn. Usually it is all I can do not to fall off. But yesterday they asked me if I could call someone (not the tanker, who you are usually talking to) while on the boom. I said yes, not at all knowing whether I could or not. And I changed radio frequencies, called people, changed frequencies back

and rolled out of the turn, all the time taking fuel at 4000 lb per minute. I might add that I needed the fuel. A lot. I won't tell the whole story now, but I got hooked up on the tanker with considerably less fuel than it takes to get home. One of the things you get used to here. But I'm getting pretty good at refueling.

And my bombing is improving considerably. Which is good. We blew hell out of some new roads northeast of Dien Bien Phu today. A good feeling to see your bombs blow dirt 300 ft in the air and start a landslide on the side of a mountain. That's what I'm here for, you know. So I might as well do good work.

I got up at 4:20 AM, so will close. Have to write to Kathy too. Can you ever get to Omaha to see her?

Love John



John with his F-105, loaded with bombs

Sunday night
April 16 67

Dear Carol

Received today your letter of Tuesday, the 11th.

Yes, Kathy and I are writing rather regularly. I hope you've written and received an answer by now. She's a bit apprehensive about meeting you and getting your approval (or acceptance) of her. So be nice and understanding. I'm very interested in her and hope to see her when I get home. Just be your usual wonderful self.

I do hope your cold is better.

Hope you can work out your problem with Tom. Just be firm. And consistent. He'd probably have lots of patience and hope you will change your mind.

Few mission #12 today. Last week the Thai people had a national holiday to celebrate the coming rainy season. They call it their "Water Festival." We called it a rain dance. But no matter what the name, they must know something or somebody we don't. It hasn't rained a drop here for months—and beginning with the day of the "Water Festival" it's rained every day since!! Some things I never understand.

I'm going to close now and read some of the magazines the folks sent me. Haven't received any here as a result of address change. So have missed them a bit. Hope to catch up now. The folks mailed a package to me air mail. Cost $5 ! But I appreciate it very much. Is worth it to me.

Love John

Friday night
April 21, 1967

Dear Carol,

I enjoyed your nice letter the other day. Hope your cold is better by now. I'm sure the Spring is too nice to sit at home and feel ill. So put my top down, drive around town, laugh and live. Because you should. Life is too short to not live and have some fun. So do it.

Kathy tells me that she heard from you. I hope you've made some arrangements by now. Be kind and considerate of her. Her circumstances are a bit delicate, so above all, be discrete and considerate. But she's so cool. But I want your evaluation, too. An honest one. And don't tell me she's flat-chested. I already know that and she's self-conscious about it too. But if you only weighed 87 lbs. how much do you think you should be in the breasts?

The enclosed clipping is about Paul Craw. He was an instructor at McConnell who volunteered for his second tour. I was in the flight of four airplanes he was leading when he was shot down. He was rescued and is in the states by now. A badly broken leg and ankle. But at least he was rescued. One of the more interesting flights, to say the least. But they are all interesting for that matter.

You don't have to tell the folks that I've had people shot down out of the flight I'm in. Or seen it happen. But I have. So they don't need to worry any more than they already do I WILL RETURN!

And Agneta tells me she prays for me every night. And she sent me her good luck Swedish horse. So I say again – I shall return.

Only 85 to go.

Love

John

Sunday night
April 23, 1967

Dear Carol,

It's 9:30 PM and I have to get up at 2:45 AM. I don't have much to say, but want to send the enclosed picture and poem. Both are too perfect. I think both are worth framing, in themself. But together, and with the guy climbing into an F-105, and the rising sun, it's just too much. Really, do save it. And frame it if you like. Sorry I had to fold it at all. But do save it.

Can't say much else about what I did today. But I was in the thick of the big raid today. You can read about it. I think we did good work and blew hell out of their steel mill. But I sure did get shot at a lot. Such is war.

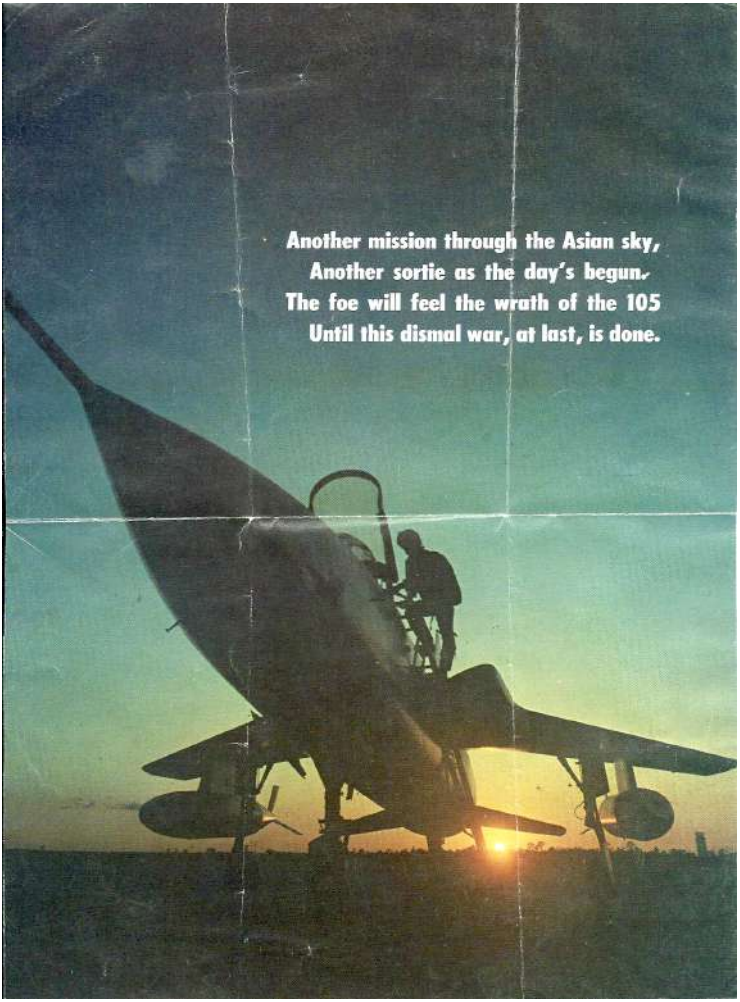
Hope all is well there.
Don't tell the folks anything that would worry them.

Love, John



Citation With Distinguished Flying Cross

Capt. John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by extraordinary achievement while participating in aerial flight as an F-105 pilot near Thai Nguyen, North Vietnam on 23 April, 1967. On that date, Capt. Bischoff's flight was assigned the role of flak suppression for the force of F-105's operation against the large and important Thai Nguyen Iron and



The clipping that John folded and enclosed, saying that it was perfect. He encouraged me to frame it, and I did.

Steel Mill. Flying through a very heavily defended area, he was personally able to silence two flak sites at the vital target. His success is attested to the fact that not a single aircraft in the force behind his received any battle damage.

His flying ability and outstanding performance are in keeping with the highest tradition of airmanship. The professional competence, aerial skill and devotion to duty displayed by Capt. Bischoff reflect great credit upon himself and the United States Air Force.

Citation with Distinguished Flying Cross
(First Oak Leaf Cluster)

Capt. John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by heroism while participating in aerial flight as an F-105 pilot over North Vietnam on 25 April, 1967. On that date, Capt. Bischoff successfully out-maneuvered surface-to-air missiles on two separate occasions and delivered his ordinance despite MIG attacks and intense flak barrages. By courageously maintaining precise fighting wing formation while twice being attacked by MIG-17 fighter aircraft, Capt. Bischoff was directly responsible for the safe return of all aircraft in his flight. The outstanding heroism and selfless devotion to duty displayed by Capt. Bischoff reflect great credit upon himself and the United States Air Force.

UNSURE DATE, and first page missing

. . . Thank you for all the typed envelopes. It must take a long time to type that many envelopes! I'll do my best to return them as best I can in due time.

Why weren't MBs asked to the Innocents party? Don't you women party hard enough for them?

You sure do have a case of senioritis! But I guess that is OK.

Hope the weather is good so you can put the top down for the picnics. That is what it is for, so use it.

You ask me to tell you about what I'm doing. Well, I don't know what you want to hear. I've see MIGs. Four at a time as

they rolled in behind me, and I've seen SAM missiles, two at a time and guiding toward me. And I've seen LOTS and LOTS of flak. Big gray, white and black puffs from the bursts. Some of it is barrage (all explodes at the same altitude) and some fused to explode on contact. Some of it tracks you visually and some use radar. I've seen most of the areas on the maps you have. I can tell you what the Red or Black River valleys look like. Or the northeast or northwest rail lines. (I've bombed both). Or the city of Hanoi or the Port of Haiphong.



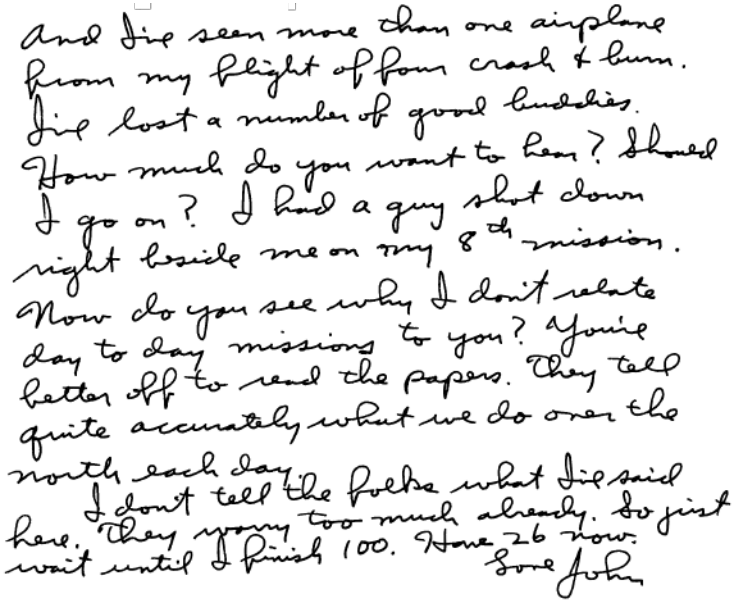
John's picture of the landscape, taken from his F-105

I've twice bombed the huge iron and steel mill at Thai Nguyen (30 miles NNW of Hanoi). I've flown within 2 miles of Phue Yen Airfield (20 miles NW of Hanoi) where most of the MIGs fly from, including MIG-21s. They have a very nice big runway there. I know. And I've seen more than one airplane from my flight of four crash and burn. I've lost a number of good buddies. How much do you want to hear? Should I go on? I had a guy shot down right beside me on my 8th mission.

Now do you see why I don't relate day to day missions to you? You're better off to read the papers. They tell quite accurately what we do over the North each day.

I don't tell the folks what I've just said. They worry too much already. So just wait until I finish 100. Have 26 now.

Love,
John



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Citation with Distinguished Flying Cross
(Second Oak Leaf Cluster)

Capt.  John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by
extraordinary achievement while participating in
aerial flight as an F-105 Thunderchief pilot over
North Vietnam on 28 April, 1967.  On that date,
Capt.  Bischoff while flying as a wingman in a
surface-to-missile suppression flight, sighted
four MIG aircraft about to attack his flight.  He
then directed the successful evasive maneuvers of
the flight while courageously placing himself in a
more dangerous position to more accurately call out
the range of the MIG aircraft.  The professional
competence, aerial skill and devotion to duty
displayed by Capt.  Bischoff reflect great credit
upon himself and the United States Air Force.
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The 357th Tactical Fighter Squadron in Takhli, Thailand. John is standing sixth from the left.

Monday morning
May 1 1967

Dear Carol,

I received yesterday your April 26th letter. Four days' service!

I'm very glad to hear you and Kathy are making progress on your visit. it is perfectly all right with me if the folks are there too. She's quite aware of the situation, how much I've told them, and will handle all of it with much aplomb. She's very perceptive and catches all of the fine points. So whatever you work out is fine with me. Don't worry about her.

You've got to get well! That's an order! You can't waste a beautiful spring coughing instead of partying and really enjoying life. You're a Senior, and it's Spring—Spring—-Spring! So load the red convertible full of beer, drive through the beautiful weather, and laugh! Because that's what you should be doing. So get over all of this allergy and coughing jazz, and enjoy your youth.

I sincerely hope you get well too. Really I do.

And have a ball at the Spook Woodsie.
Love, John

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Citation with Distinguished Flying Cross
(Third Oak Leaf Cluster)

Capt.  John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by
extraordinary achievement while participating in
aerial flight as an F-105 Thunderchief pilot over
North Vietnam on 1 May, 1967.  On that date, Capt.
Bischoff flew through a very heavily defended area
to strike a large iron and steel mill complex.
He disregarded his own personal safety as he flew
through thick bursts of flak and pressed the attack
to place all of his ordnance on the assigned target.
The professional competence, aerial skill and
devotion to duty displayed by Capt.  Bischoff reflect
great credit upon himself and the United States Air
Force.
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Friday
May 5, 1967

Dear Carol,

Today was one of those days where I practiced getting up early again. Got canceled for weather and went back to bed again about 5 AM.

The picture I sent to you was the rear cover of "The Airman Magazine," an official publication of the Air Force. So don't try to obtain more copies.

Yes, I'm a part of the news you hear about things over the North. And yes, I've been in on some of them close to Hanoi. And I've seen MIGs and SAMs and lots of flak, too. And Monday I went back to the Thai Nguyen Iron and Steel Mill again.



John's picture of the airfield at Takhli

Mother mentioned that she may not get any applesauce this year. My, if I only had such problems – instead of worrying whether or not I'll be alive until tonight – or tomorrow night.

But such is the perspective of war, I guess. When each day you hang on a fine line between life and death (and see some of your buddies go both ways), then all other problems seem small in comparison. And you don't have to tell me about loss rates or what the papers say. Because I sit in my airplane right next to them and watch theirs explode and mine fly home. Hell of a deal to experience.

You've got to get well! That's an order! Put off your illness until the weather is bad or something! But don't let your beautiful Spring Semester get loused up by bad health! Seriously, I do hope you get well soon. And without getting too addicted to drugs. My goodness, a real dope addict in the Bischoff family! My goodness, what will people say!

Tonight is Spring Night and tomorrow is Ivy Day. Sure wish I could be there and watch you spook. I appreciate your long, interesting letter and the advance information about Mortar Boards. I hope the day is as wonderful as last years was. In all ways.

Congrats on being nominated for the national sorority awards.

Tell me about the MB-Innocent woodsie. And the Ivy Day Banquet with the folks. And send pictures. I sure wish I could be there. I'll be thinking of you tomorrow.

Good luck on Indiana U. interview.

I'm VERY glad to hear that you're learning to play the guitar. I almost started my sophomore year, but reluctantly concluded that it was futile to learn to play if you couldn't sing – which I can't. So I'm very glad to hear that you're working on it. My, but you must be well organized to find time for that, too.

Are you working in Lincoln this summer? And where will you live?

When are Mother's and Father's Days? And do you have any gift plans for then and/or anniversary? Whatever you do, I want to be in on, since I haven't been R&R to do any shopping. So just go ahead and get it and I'll pay you. Money is no object. Get something nice. I put all of April's pay check ($880) in the 10% interest savings account. It only costs me $100

(approximately) per month to live. So I have to save money, almost. Or until I go R&R. Which I may do soon. But working 7 days a week isn't as bad as I thought it would be. But after so long you need a rest or at least a break in scenery.

I do hope you can get together with Kathy sometime soon. She really is a cool girl and I think we're both quite interested in each other. So go out and have a beer with her, or something. She mentioned that Roger's aunt and uncle are Verle and Mae Hurlbutt and live near Tecumseh. What do you know about them? She doesn't know them well either.

I must close now. I spent a very relaxing day, the first in some time. And I feel a lot better. I hope you can say the same thing.

Love,

John

P.S. Wrote to and heard from Marilyn Peterson. May try to see her sometime.

10 May 1967
Wednesday morning

Dear Carol

This morning on the way to work I got your very nice 3 page typed letter. Mail arrives and is sorted 24 hours a day. It just depends on when the airplane comes in. So I read your letter at breakfast (got one from folks too) and am answering now from mobile control at the end of the runway. All of the airplanes got off and I'm waiting for them to complete their mission and return to land. That explains this stationery.[3]

I can't imagine why anyone would take time to write a letter on Spring Day. That's the best time ever to drink beer! But I do like to read your interesting letters.

It's nice to know you and Kathy are going to get together. Of course I'm very interested in all of the details. Also whether she met the folks. She sounded to me a bit reluctant on that point. But I guess that is understandable.

[3] lined notebook paper

She told me about seeing your picture in the paper when you came to Omaha for the masking.[4] That must have been a very pleasant event. All of the excitement at the airport and all. Plus TV, papers, parents and the rest.



Citation with Silver Star

Capt. John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by gallantry in connection with military operations against an opposing armed force over North Vietnam on 12 May, 1967. On that date, Capt. Bischoff participated in a bombing mission against a military storage area. In spite of encountering heavy flak from anti-aircraft weapons, hostile interceptors and surface-to-air-missiles in the large area, Capt. Bischoff placed his ordnance directly on target. By his gallantry and devotion to duty, Capt. Bischoff has reflected great credit upon himself and the United States Air Force.

[4]the Mortar Board event where new members were surprised and tapped

14 May 1967
Sunday morning

Dear Carol,

I'm told, now that I got to work, that today is Mothers Day. How about that. I didn't even know it was Sunday. I am the early morning duty officer. That means get up at 4 a.m. and open up the squadron, get airplane number assignments, put up the day's schedule, answer the phone—and in general get the day started for the squadron. I'm scheduled to fly this afternoon. If I get off it will be mission number 30.

Yesterday I got your long and very happy letter written on the 9th. I am so very happy for you, and of course proud of you too. But in a way, I'm not so surprised that you do so well in interviews. Dr. Greenleaf sounds very nice. She has good judgment. What exactly will you have to do to earn all of this money that you are going to get?

I can't believe that you will be getting away with spending another summer like the last one. And getting paid money for it too! That's just too much! But enjoy it while it lasts. Some day you will get a job that will require you to work. Unless you continue to be as cagy as you have been.

No ideas at all here for gifts for Mothers and Fathers Days. Or for Wedding Anniversary either. Haven't really given it much thought. I intend to go on R&R soon and may get a chance to think about gifts or see something somewhere to buy. Will have to wait and see. In the meantime, get whatever you think is appropriate and tell me how much my share is—money is no object.

Do a good job of enjoying your last few weeks of your senior year. Have a beer for me. How did you manage to have only ONE final? That's almost too good to be true. That's a lot better than I ever did!

I do hope you and Kathy can get together soon. She wants to too.

Have finally decided that I need a rest. It's been almost two months of working seven days a week, and it's starting to tell. Don't know where I will go or what I will do, but I will just

leave. Go somewhere and buy a big bottle of booze. And then hire some little girlie to screw me three times a day for about a week. And then maybe I will be ready to go fly again. War is hell.

Love, John

[In handwriting at the end] PS Sorry about the typing. I should improve with practice.

24 May 1967

Dear Carol,

Received your letter today. I'm also overdue on a letter to you.

I went R&R to Japan. Had a good time and got a much needed rest. Spent almost $900. That included a Honda 90 that's being sent straight to Nebraska. And it's in five pieces, so you can't ride it yet![5]

Bought an amplifier, tape deck, portable tape recorder, camera, etc. etc. Got VERY drunk ONCE and generally had a wonderful time. Never got around to going to Tokyo. Sorry about that.

Today Senator Peter Dominick of Colorado was here on a visit. Tonight when he came into the Officer's Club he came over to our table and chatted with we pilots for a few minutes. He seemed very nice and quite interested what we're doing.

Today I bombed a railroad siding 20 miles north of Hanoi. Didn't see any SAMs or MIGs. They must still be celebrating Budda's Birthday. We had yesterday off. Big time, you know.

The base had a big banquet the night before. Welcomed Colonel Bob White as Col. Hill's replacement here as Commander for Operations. Col. White flew the X-15 at Edwards AFB to 350,000 ft. altitude and to Mach 6 speed. He holds and wears every day astronaut wings because he's been above 50 miles. He flies with our squadron and seems

[5] John bought a Honda 90, a small motorcycle. It arrived in the summer, and after John's death, we assembled it. Our dad and I rode it once, and we sold it to a neighbor near our home in Tecumseh, Nebraska.

to be a fine man. At the banquet he told about White House presentations from both Presidents Eisenhower and Kennedy. Very interesting.

Read with great interest your letter. I'm a good listener. I think you are handling the situation perfectly. You're doing your usual outstanding job in people relations. And especially in those as delicate as with Tom. And I understand those long talks on those subjects, too. I've been in a few myself, and understand.

Glad you're going to mass and to worship with a Jewish girl. An interesting and informative experience.

Yes, our tour is 100 missions over the North, or one year, whichever ends first, and I hope to have 100 by October. Flew # 31 today.



A ceremony for two pilots who completed their 100th missions. John is in the middle left between the rows, in a bush hat.

Thought you might be interested in the pictures. Not nearly as good as the slides we took. Sorry. Will take some more and

hope they're better. Am sending more to the folks, and you can look at them there. Do I look like a mean fighting pilot?

Keep up the good work!

Love, John



John as a mean fighting pilot



Citation with Air Medal
(Sixth Oak Leaf Cluster)

Capt. John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by meritorious achievement while participating in aerial flight as an F-105 Thunderchief pilot over North Vietnam on 27 May, 1967. On that date, Capt. Bischoff maneuvered his aircraft through adverse weather and highly concentrated anti-aircraft fire to successfully acquire and attach the target. Capt. Bischoff accurately delivered all ordnance on target, resulting in numerous rail cuts to effectively interdict the North Vietnamese transportation system. The professional skill and airmanship displayed by Capt. Bischoff reflect great credit upon himself and the United States Air Force.

30 May 1967
Tuesday night

Dear Carol,

This letter is supposed to be timed to reach you just prior to your graduation. I can only hope it does.

I've spent the entire week and longer planning an appropriate letter for this special occasion. I considered making a nice long tape. I thought of all of the things that I might say to you. All the thoughts I had for an important milestone like graduation from a State University. The wisdom I should pass on. The father–big brother type talk I should give to you. And that you probably won't get from your father.

But you're not going to get a lecture from me. Or lots of eloquent words. Or even a presumption that I could offer any useful sayings. My point is that anything that I could say to you would be inadequate. You and all you have done so well continually prove that you don't need any advice from me. I couldn't tell you anything that you don't already know better. You are already wise well beyond your years. You continually demonstrate a deep understanding of the mysteries of human personalities. And a phenomenal comprehension of the feelings of your contemporaries. These valuable traits have made you so fantastically successful in your every personal contact.

The future would normally be discussed in a discourse of this nature. Your actions and superb planning during the past year have demonstrated the depth of your maturity. Your insight of the future, your very serious approach to it and the intensity of your commitment to it all demonstrate that I can't say anything that you haven't already proved that you can do better.

If I could write poetry, I'd compose some for this occasion. If I could sketch a cartoon, I'd create a series of your college career. If I could write music, I'd do the very best at this time. And you'd deserve all of the very best and more.

But, unfortunately, I'm at war. And I'm very sorry. I feel very, very inadequate at this time. I can't buy you a card. I

can't call you. I can't hug you with pride. I can't even find any kind or size of gift that even approaches adequacy. So you may be disappointed on this, your day of days. But don't for a moment be unhappy. Because you have the world at your feet. The entire human race at your beck and call. Just express your slightest whim and all of mankind will respond. You can do a n y t h i n g !

So as a gift, I promise to honor my long standing pledge to send you to Europe for the summer. Just say when.

And I give you my considered opinion that you are the most phenomenal woman on the face of the earth. Bar none.

For philosophy, refer to my letter written after you election to AWS Board.[6] For an estimation of my pride, refer to my actions on Ivy Day one year ago.

And for confidence, remember that no one anywhere – has done – is – or can do – as much as you can. Anyone, anytime. You are the all time greatest.

Please have a happy graduation day. I wish so very much I could be there in person. But don't let that sadden you. I'm there very much in spirit.

Congratulations!

Love

John

[6] campus-wide governing board

Chapter 10

June 1967

From Wikipedia:

> On 2 June 1967 355th TFW F-105s attacked a AAA site on the coast near Haiphong. During this attack the Soviet ship Turkestan was damaged, and the Soviets protested the attack. The deputy commander of the 355th, TFW Colonel Jacksel M. Broughton, destroyed the F-105 gun-camera film and was court-martialed but ultimately acquitted.

3 June 1967
Saturday morning

Dear Carol,

I hope you got my graduation congrats letter at 540 N 16th. I didn't know where to send this or where you'll be for the summer, so sent it to Tecumseh. Yesterday I got your card announcing break up with Tom.

You sure can handle difficult situations so smoothly! I read closely all of the details of your description. I admire great your tact and finesse. You are so considerate, but still firm enough to be devastatingly effective. You've given a classic example to model all future breakups after. You should join Dear Abby and do advising full time.

Congrats on finishing with a flourish and a high grade average. Very good.

Your attitude is perfect. A bit of Senioritis, a bit conscientious (when necessary), a bit busy (like packing and moving) and a lot of "What the Hell!" I couldn't possibly do as well.

I guess I didn't tell you about my shopping in Japan. Spent $900, only $60 on living expenses, travel and partying. Got very drunk one night, throwing glasses etc. Such is the need to unwind after being to Hanoi and back. It will take 2 months to arrive, but you and Daddy might try to assemble the Honda and ride it before it gets cold in the fall. I have not seen it at all. Ordered from a picture and taken apart to be crated. I haven't seen 5 packages either, so don't know how much work is involved to assemble.

Sounds like a nice contract from Indiana U.

I didn't buy or send graduation announcements. I agree wholeheartedly with your reasoning.

Am enclosing loan application to insurance company. Folks should understand it. Decided to up it to $1000 so don't have to bother in a month or two. Clippings are from Aviation Week. Bede airplane built in Wichita and I told you about it. Thailand operation fairly well explained in other article. Please send it to Kathy next time you write or see her.

I'm now finally receiving LIFE and Aviation Week here. Got ATLAS, NEBR ALUMNUS clipping and first tape recording yesterday. All in good shape and much appreciated. Enjoyed tape very much.

Must close now.

Love

John

Flew #37 yesterday

From Ward Just, "This war may be unwinnable," article in the *Washington Post*, 4 June 1967:

> This war is not being won, and by any reasonable estimate, it is not going to be won in the foreseeable future... It may be unwinnable.

5 June 1967
Monday night

Dear Carol,

The world is coming to an end. Rog is being transferred to Fort Dodge, Iowa in 3 weeks and Kathy told him she won't go with him so all things have been brought to a head. Much ahead of any anticipated schedule. The poor girl is about to lose her mind. She is so completely and totally miserable and unhappy. A failing marriage must be the worse sort of living hell. As she says "the pain of the situation is almost unbearable."

The poor gal really has no one except me to talk to about it. And I'm only 10,000 miles away. I sure wish I could be in Omaha.

And worst of all, I don't know what to say to her. I have no advice to offer (except to get a lawyer early) or can't say anything specific to comfort her. I can only say, everything will work out OK. That sounds weak. Carol, what should I do? Should I stay apart from the situation until the dust settles? Should I offer any advice? Should I only comfort her? Should I tell her I'll marry her when I'm not sure I will? I have no idea what she wants to be told. She only wants to be happy and stop living so miserably And her daily existence is rather unhappy. She says she hasn't loved Rog for about 1 1/2 years. But he begged and pleaded with her to stay with him. She doesn't want to, but feels an obligation to her promise five years ago.

Why does life have to be so damn complicated? As if getting shot at weren't enough of a problem!

Carol, please go to Omaha as soon as you can and talk to Kathy. Comfort her if you can. And tell me immediately how

she is, how things went, how she's reacting to one of life's major crises.

I only wish there were something I could do. Or knew what to do from here. Should I stay out of the whole thing completely?

I don't really know how much of the situation is caused by my existence. Whether she wants to leave him because of me or because she isn't in love with him. I'm sure it's lots of both, but very very complex. And the poor girl is so confused and unhappy. And they haven't even begun to explain things to their relatives. So more is to come I'm sure.

I don't even know what to say to her. How do you write a letter to someone in a situation like she's in? What can I say? And should I say anything? She did get my pictures, and said that lifted her spirits a bit.

It sure is a good thing flying combat isn't this difficult. Over Hanoi I at least can influence some of the variables. Here I feel almost helpless.

Carol, what do you suggest? You're a very good judge of people. What would be the best approach?

I hope that after you've talked to her you can help both of us. It would mean a lot to me if you could.

Nothing else of significance happening here. I'm being checked out as a flight leader. Seems they think I have talent and leadership ability. I'm also in charge of the squadrons Awards and Decorations Program. There went the last bit of my free time

Please answer as soon as you can.

Love, John

P.S. It sure is good to have someone like you to write to about this sort of thing.

12 June 1967
Monday night

Dear Carol,

Flew #43 this morning. Led a two-ship on a relatively undefended target.

Yesterday I was duty officer and wrote an attempt at wit to Kathy. She needs some humor out of life. I hope that you can get to Omaha to see her soon. She tells me that her brother and his wife are attending summer school and living in Sandoz Hall. A bit of concern about your paths crossing and words being exchanged. Her only warning was that he is not nearly so broad-minded as you are.

I don't really know how things are going in Omaha. I'm not sure she does either, since she and Rog hardly ever speak. I'm glad I don't have to go through all that unhappiness.

Got your very interesting, long typed letter yesterday. It's nice to hear you say all those things. Of course I'm very sorry I couldn't attend commencement, but have to admit in all honesty—that if I had my choice of events to attend, and could only attend one, I'd journey to Nebraska last May rather than this June. I agree wholeheartedly – M.B.[1] is a bigger deal than B.S. You have the right attitude and perspective on so many things.

A bit of thought from the enclosed clipping out of Newsweek. Folks sent me it and US News & World Report. Tell them to quit sending me magazines. I get plenty now, and besides, it's very expensive.

A very nice descriptive letter from Missouri. Sounds like a nice trip. They worry about $50 on a vacation! I spent $150 in San Francisco on the weekend before I left the states. One weekend! But they saw something different, and that is very good.

I wish they'd have done it in February when I was there to grind feed, instead of you having to do it now. Lots of hard work for you. But look at it this way: you need some humbling

[1] Mortar Board

experience after such a phenomenally successful college career! I guess grinding feed and running through manure is sufficient humbling to last a while. Maybe quite a while.

I'm not on tomorrows flying schedule. Some damn General is coming to visit the base. While here he wants to present some hero medals, so I've got to be available all day.[2] No one knows what time he'll be here, so I can't fly. I'd much rather fly than go to an award presentation ceremonies.

Just re-read your letter. Don't feel bad about not sending a letter to me on time. Mail is so erratic we go 2 or 3 days without any and then get 4 days worth at one time. Very unpredictable. So don't worry about writing on a regular schedule.

I moved today. Into a 2-man house trailer type building. We share a bathroom. Pretty nice, really.

Will close. Tell me about your job and all about Kathy.

Love, John

16 June 1967
Friday night

Dear Carol,

Can't remember when I last wrote or what I said. Life is so busy and confusing.

I've been reading carefully all of the long and thoughtful letters you've written. And I've been trying to write to Kathy. I guess just waiting is the only thing I can do. I appreciate so much all that you've done and your offer to do more—as far as Kathy is concerned. But now waiting is best. And I do hope you can get to know her soon.

Your letter of June 9 and 10 is a masterpiece. I read and re-read it. You say a lot. Much deep thought is going on in your mind.

Flew #46 today. Led a two-ship that was rather uneventful. Yesterday I led a four ship. We found some trucks and had a

[2] John had recently been put in charge of writing up all the awards for his squadron

field day. Left them burning, also one barge. Didn't leave until every man had fired out every bullet. Great day.

Not much else to tell. Get up early and work late, seven days a week.

Got a nice letter from the folks about their trip. Sounded very nice and I'm sure they needed a rest. Did you give them the money – and if so how much do I owe you? I'm sure they didn't spend enough, but if they're happy, that's the most important thing.

I'll close now and write to the folks.

Love

John

17 June 1967
Saturday night

Dear Carol,

Another Rowdy Sat. night! Got off work at 7 p.m., had one gin and tonic, ate and came home. Up for a 6 AM briefing tomorrow. Such are my weekends. Yesterday your mysterious lines about a cardboard package were received in your letter. Today the package itself arrived. A bit bent but not harmed. And I've been laughing my head off ever since! I think you have what is referred to as a potentially dirty mind. And so very funny. Thanks a lot. It must have taken hours to hunt up all those bits and pieces and put them together. They are very much appreciated.

Flew #47 today. Bombed the rail yard a mile northwest of the big steel mill at Thai Ngygen.

General Ryan was here today. Watched us take off. And talked to us (our flight of four) after we landed-about what we saw etc. You mentioned you know his daughter.

The only magazine I really need is PLAYBOY. The mail clerks here steal all that come to the Post Office. So put one, from the newsstand, in a big envelope and mail it to me. Start with the June issue. I'd appreciate that little favor very much.

Thanks again for the collages. Very interesting, humorous, and appreciated. They will go on my wall.

Must close and say hello to Kathy.

Love

John

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Citation with Air Medal (Seventh Oak Leaf Cluster)

Capt.  John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by
meritorious achievement while participating in aerial
flight as an F-105 pilot in Southeast Asia.  On
23 June, 1967 Capt Bischoff's precise bombing and
accurate rocket deliveries destroyed a large storage
area.  Due to his timely action and expert ordnance
delivery a major hostile offensive was halted.  The
professional skill and airmanship displayed by Capt.
Bischoff reflect great credit upon himself and the
United States Air Force.
```

29 June 1967
Thursday night

Dear Carol,

Got your letter and big envelope yesterday. Thank you very much for PLAYBOY! Much appreciated here. Can you still find a June issue?

The tapes arrived in perfect condition. But my such expensive postage. Believe me, they are appreciated and are being used.

Sounds like an interesting poker game. But until you know more about it, don't be seduced into playing for clothes or money. It could prove to be embarrassing or expensive to learn the game. But it is lots of fun in the meantime.

You seem to be getting home almost every weekend. I'm sure the folks appreciate that.

Yes, I knew Lynn Corcoran quite well. A fine young man. I didn't (or don't) know what he's doing, but knew he was coming to Southeast Asia. I appreciate the bit of news about him.

I'm been getting some very nice letters from Kathy since her trip with her parents. I didn't hear from her for nine days and

thought maybe she'd forgotten about me completely. But no, she tells me she loves me as much as ever, and is more sure of it now.

Today she tells me she went out and bought herself a new Mustang. And she's fairly happy with her life in general. Which is very good and a bit of a change.

I don't know much about her brother. They (he and Kathy) grew up in Page, Nebr. where their parents still live. Her brother and his wife lived and taught school in Valentine (I think) and are going to a town near Grand Island this fall. That's all I know. See her for more information.

Which brings up another subject. When are you going to see her? I sure wish you two could get together soon.

Listen to my tapes for news about flying. Flew # 54 today.

Love

John

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Citation with Distinguished Flying Cross
(Fourth Oak Leaf Cluster)

Capt.  John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by
extraordinary achievement while participating in
aerial flight as an F-105 Thunderchief pilot over
North Vietnam on 1 July, 1967.  On that date, Capt.
Bischoff disregarded the intense anti-aircraft fire
bursting around him, delivered his ordnance with
devastating accuracy and destroyed the center span of
this important bridge.  The professional competence,
aerial skill and devotion to duty displayed by Capt.
Bischoff reflect great credit upon himself and the
United States Air Force.
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Citation to accompany the award of The Air Medal
(posthumous)
(First through Fifth Oak Leaf Clusters)

Capt.  John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by
meritorious achievement while participating in
sustained aerial flight as a combat crew member
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John with his airplane

in Southeast Asia from 15 April 1967 to 26 July 1967. During this period, outstanding airmanship and courage were exhibited in the successful accomplishment of important missions under extremely hazardous conditions including the continuous possibility of hostile ground fire. His highly professional efforts contributed materially to the mission of the United States Air Force in Southeast Asia. The professional ability and outstanding aerial accomplishments of Captain Bischoff reflect great credit upon himself and the United States Air Force.

Citation to accompany the award of The Air Medal
(posthumous)
(Seventh Oak Leaf Cluster)

Capt. John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by meritorious achievement while participating in aerial flight as an F-105 Pilot in Southeast Asia on 23 June 1967. On that date, Captain Bischoff's precise bombing and accurate rocket deliveries destroyed a large storage area. Due to his timely action and expert ordnance delivery a major hostile offensive was halted. The professional skill and airmanship displayed by Captain Bischoff reflect great credit upon himself and the United States Air Force.

Citation with Air Medal
(Eighth Oak Leaf Cluster)

Capt. John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by meritorious achievement while participating in aerial flight as an F-105 pilot over North Vietnam on 6 July 1967. On that date, Capt. Bischoff successfully attacked a vital target while overcoming the obstacles of adverse weather and intense, accurate anti-aircraft fire. Despite last minute changes in his attack parameters, his bombing accuracy completely destroyed the main generator hall of a power plant vital to hostile forces. The professional skill and airmanship displayed by Capt. Bischoff reflect great credit upon himself and the United States Air Force.

Citation with Air Medal
(Ninth Oak Leaf Cluster)

Capt. John W. Bischoff distinguished himself by meritorious achievement while participating in aerial flight as an F-105 Thunderchief pilot near Kep Airfield, North Vietnam on 7 July, 1967. On that date, Capt. Bischoff, hampered by inclement weather, successfully evaded extremely heavy anti-aircraft fire, correctly identified his target and completely

```
destroyed six railroad cars.  The professional skill
and airmanship displayed by Capt.  Bischoff reflect
great credit upon himself and the United States Air
Force.
```

John had several significant relationships while he was in the Air Force. The most meaningful at the end of his life was with Leilani Jones. Leilani was a flight attendant (called stewardess back in 1967), and they met at the Celadon Shop in Bangkok, Thailand when John was on R&R. It was his second R&R, and one that he took soon after one of his best friends was Killed in Action. Celadon is a pottery material unique to Thailand, and they were both perusing the shop. The length of their relationship is unknown, but they kept in touch after he went back to Takhli AFB in northwest Thailand.



Leilani and John on his last R&R, in Bangkok

Friday night
21 July 67

Dear Carol,

Don't know when I last wrote but imagine I'm overdue. Hope you've been home to catch up on my news to there.

Had a great time on R&R in Bangkok. Drank a lot, laid in the sun, spent money, and, most importantly, met a wonderful stewardess. She's cute (looks like Julie Andrews), 27, a graduate of the Univ of Houston, well traveled (five years over Pan American routes) and in general a wonderful gal. Intelligent, interesting and never been married. So we had a GREAT time together.

Spent so much time running around partying that I got way short on sleep. Caught a bad cold that's much worse as a result. So I haven't been able to fly. Still have 59 missions, as before R&R. Should be able to fly in a couple days. Sure hope so. I hate sitting around shuffling papers.

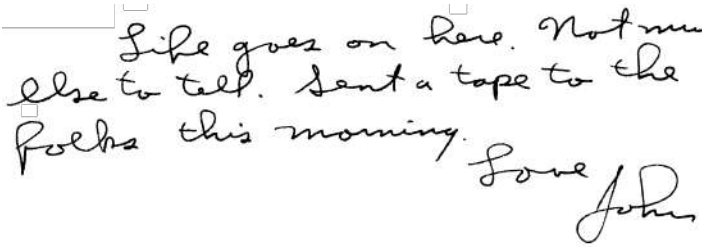
I've read and reread your letter written after your visit with Kathy. I'm glad you like her and that the two of you got along so well. I really appreciate your efforts and the trip to Omaha.

Received your July 14th letter since. Sounds like you're spending an interesting summer.

I have no ideas for gifts for folks. $50 is fine with me.

Life goes on here. Not much else to tell. Sent a tape to the folks this morning.

Love,
John



HIS LAST LETTER TO ME



John on his last R&R, in Bangkok

Chapter 11

The Accident in Laos

Friday, 3 August 1967:
A Day That Changed Our Lives Forever

The day starts earlier in Thailand and as usual the F-105s did early morning sorties. During refueling from a tanker, something John had done hundreds of times, in order to have sufficient fuel to complete their bombing mission, John and another F-105 pilot's wing tips collided. I've always thought it was the other pilot who made a mistake.[1] At 600+ mph a slight miscalculation can be deadly. Both of them had to eject since they were loaded with 750-pound bombs en route to their targets in North Vietnam.

They were over Laos, perhaps halfway to their North Vietnam sites, and had already successfully refueled once before the accident. When the other pilot ejected and landed, he was getting ground fire, so the rescuers went to get him first.

Remember, when those jets are flying over, and then a parachute floats down, the pilot is a relatively easy target for the enemy on the ground, even if it is all jungle. The natives know the terrain and how to get there fast. This is one of

[1]The official accident report (below) claims the opposite: "The primary cause was pilot error on the part of Capt Bischoff."



John's picture, taken from the cockpit of his F-105, of mid-air refueling operations

the reasons why, before John went to Thailand, he had our dad purchase a revolver through our local county sheriff in Tecumseh, Nebraska. John knew what type of weapon was most desirable for this situation from the other pilots (and different from what the Air Force issued, if they issued one at all), and my dad was able to buy it for him. It was not returned with his personal effects.

In the meantime, John had ejected out of his F-105, with tremendous force, probably with as much as 15-16 Gs of force[2] on his body as he was shot out of the cockpit and straight up and away from the plane. Pilots who eject are unconscious with that kind of pressure; the parachute automatically releases and the pilot descends. In John's case, he fell through umbrella-type trees, crashed through the upper foliage, and then fell 50-60 feet

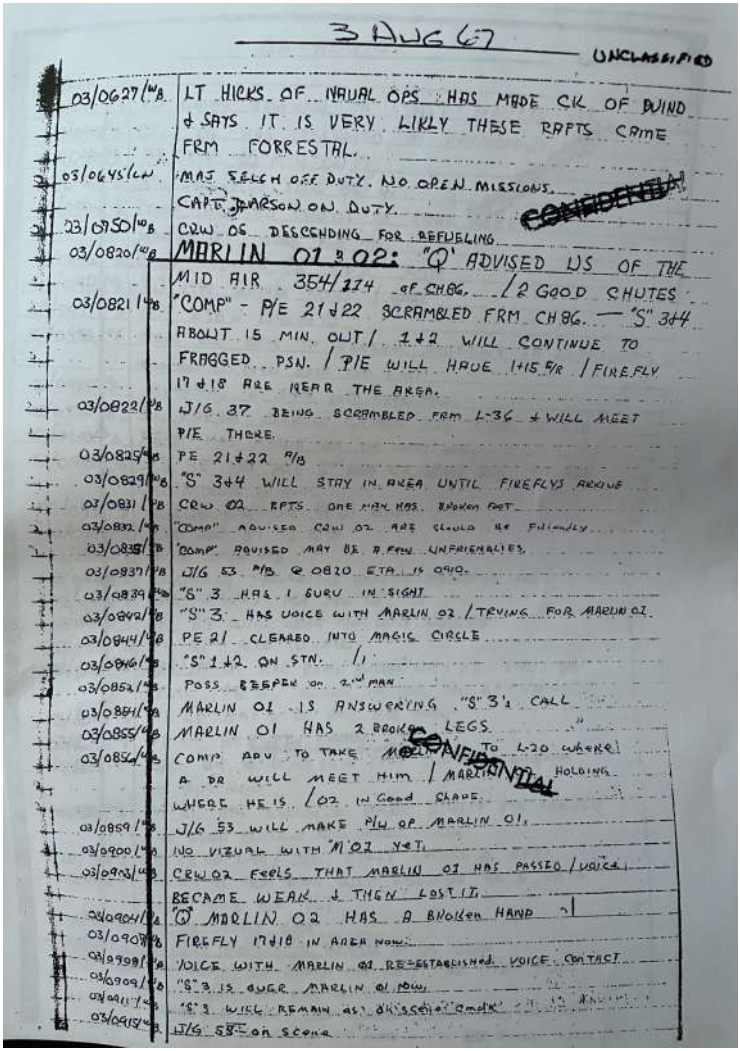
[2]according to a medical doctor and pilot who spoke at Shell Point, Fort Myers, FL on 3/2019

with no branches, directly to the ground. When he came to, he was able to minimally use his emergency radio. Apparently (according to the examining physician) he had broken both legs, which was not unusual for pilots who ejected.

NOTE: Karl Richter, also an F-105 pilot, died on his 198th mission in Vietnam on July 26, 1967, just a week before John. The medical examiner of both Karl and John noted that both of them had broken legs that occurred when being ejected from their planes. Karl, a star graduate of the US Air Force Academy (they later erected a monument in his honor), was the most expert pilot in combat at that time, who had requested a second tour of 100 missions since he felt his expertise should be used to help aid the military cause. The medical examiner was furious that these top pilots had been seriously injured due to defective ejection seats. Later, the design was changed so that these injuries were less likely to occur.

The rescue helicopter crew instructed John to use the provided morphine to minimize the pain he was experiencing.[3] He followed their directions, but the Air Force had apparently not properly instructed pilots that they should be on their side or stomach when getting the morphine, in case they passed out and vomited. The tragedy is that the latter is what apparently happened to John, and this ultimately caused his death. What a waste! And a preventable death! This reportedly was the cause of Karl Richter's death as well, and the doctor was angry at the loss of these two lives, which didn't need to happen. Fortunately, we didn't know this bit of information before my mother died, since **it is so upsetting to know his death was preventable, even though he had broken bones. This procedure was also changed by the Air Force, though too late for John and Karl.**

[3]The official accident report (below) claims the opposite: "Capt Bischoff did not carry any medication in his survival gear to relieve pain."



3 AUG 67

UNCLASSIFIED

03/0627/WB LT HICKS OF NAVAL OPS HAS MADE CK OF WIND & SAYS IT IS VERY LIKLY THESE RAFTS CAME FRM FORRESTAL.

03/0645/LN MAJ SELCH OFF DUTY. NO OPEN MISSIONS. CAPT JAMESON ON DUTY.

03/0750/WB CREW 05 DESCENDING FOR REFUELING

03/0820/WB MARLIN 01 & 02: "O" ADVISED US OF THE MID AIR 354/114 OF CH86. / 2 GOOD CHUTES

03/0821/WB "COMP" - P/E 21 & 22 SCRAMBLED FRM CH 86. — "S" 344 ABOUT 15 MIN OUT / 1 & 2 WILL CONTINUE TO FRAGGED PSN. / P/E WILL HAVE 1415 P/R / FIREFLY 17 & 18 ARE NEAR THE AREA.

03/0822/WB J/G 37 BEING SCRAMBLED FRM L-36 & WILL MEET P/E THERE.

03/0825/WB P/E 21 & 22 P/B

03/0829/WB "S" 344 WILL STAY IN AREA UNTIL FIREFLYS ARRIVE

03/0831/WB CREW 02 RPTS ONE MAN HAS BROKEN FOOT

03/0832/WB "COMP" ADVISED CREW 02 ARE CLOUD OF Friendly

03/0835/WB "COMP" ADVISED MAY BE A FEW UNFRIENDLIES.

03/0837/WB J/G 53 P/B @ 0820 ETA IS 0910.

03/0839/WB "S" 3 HAS 1 GURU IN SIGHT

03/0842/WB "S" 3 HAS VOICE WITH MARLIN 02 / TRYING FOR MARLIN 01

03/0844/WB P/E 21 CLEARED INTO MAGIC CIRCLE

03/0846/WB "S" 1 & 2 ON STN. / /

03/0852/WB POSS BEEPER ON 2ND MAN

03/0854/WB MARLIN 01 IS ANSWERING "S" 3's CALL

03/0855/WB MARLIN 01 HAS 2 BROKEN LEGS

03/0856/WB COMP ADV TO TAKE [redacted] TO L-20 WHERE A DR WILL MEET HIM / MARLIN HOLDING WHERE HE IS / 02 IN Good SHAPE.

03/0859/WB J/G 53 WILL MAKE P/U OF MARLIN 01.

03/0900/WB NO VIZUAL WITH M 02 YET.

03/0903/WB CREW 02 FEELS THAT MARLIN 01 HAS PASSED / VOICE BECAME WEAK & THEN LOST IT.

03/0904/WB "O" MARLIN 02 HAS A BROKEN HAND

03/0908/WB FIREFLY 17 & 18 IN AREA NOW.

03/0909/WB VOICE WITH MARLIN 01 RE-ESTABLISHED. VOICE CONTACT

03/0909/WB "S" 3 IS OVER MARLIN 01 NOW.

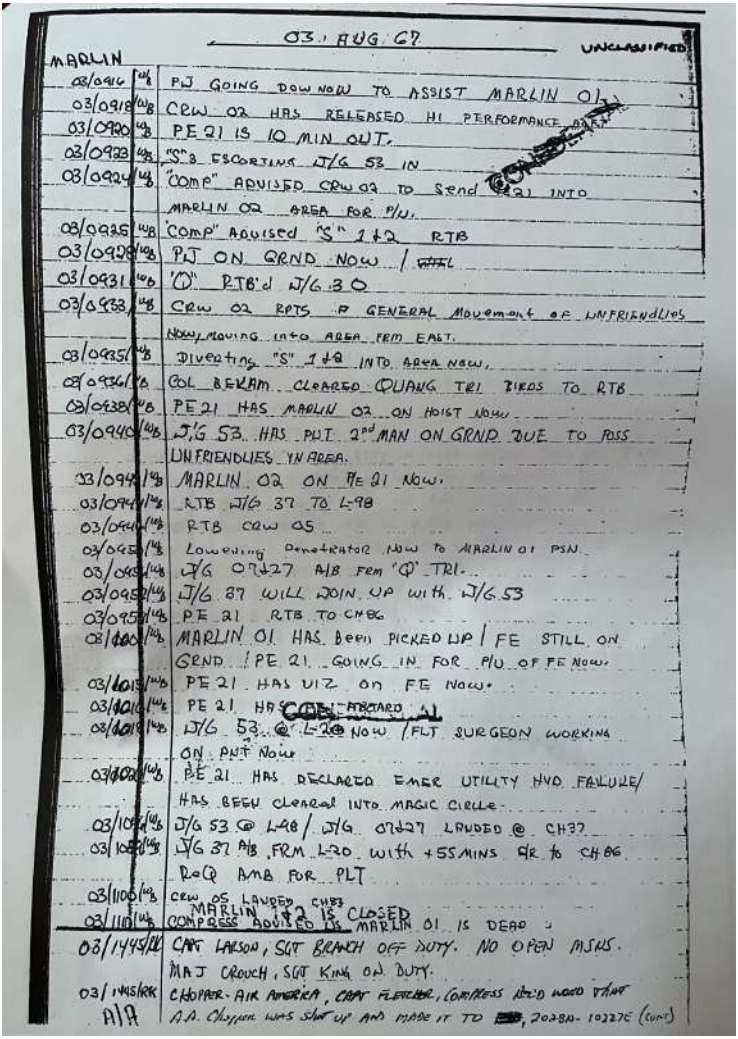
03/0911/WB "S" 3 WILL REMAIN AS [illegible]

03/0915/WB J/G 58 ON SCENE

CONFIDENTIAL

CONFIDENTIAL

The radio log from the morning of the accident (page 1). John is MARLIN 01 and the other pilot is MARLIN 02.



03 AUG 67 UNCLASSIFIED

MARLIN

03/0916	UHF	PJ GOING DOWN NOW TO ASSIST MARLIN 01
03/0918	UHF	CREW 02 HAS RELEASED HI PERFORMANCE ACFT
03/0920	UHF	PE 21 IS 10 MIN OUT.
03/0923	UHF	"S" 3 ESCORTING J/G 53 IN
03/0924	UHF	"COMP" ADVISED CREW 02 TO SEND PE 21 INTO MARLIN 02 AREA FOR P/U.
03/0925	UHF	"COMP" ADVISED "S" 1 & 2 RTB
03/0928	UHF	PJ ON GRND NOW / [illegible]
03/0931	UHF	"O" RTB'd J/G 30
03/0933	UHF	CREW 02 RPTS A GENERAL MOVEMENT OF UNFRIENDLIES NOW, MOVING INTO AREA FRM EAST.
03/0935	UHF	Diverting "S" 1 & 2 INTO AREA NOW.
03/0936	UHF	COL BEKAM CLEARED QUANG TRI BIRDS TO RTB
03/0938	UHF	PE 21 HAS MARLIN 02 ON HOIST NOW.
03/0940	UHF	J/G 53 HAS PUT 2nd MAN ON GRND DUE TO POSS UNFRIENDLIES IN AREA.
03/0941	UHF	MARLIN 02 ON PE 21 NOW.
03/0944	UHF	RTB J/G 37 TO L-98
03/0944	UHF	RTB CREW 05
03/0945	UHF	Lowering Penetrator Now to MARLIN 01 PSN
03/0948	UHF	J/G 07427 A/B Frm "O" TRI.
03/0952	UHF	J/G 37 WILL JOIN UP with J/G 53
03/0955	UHF	PE 21 RTB TO CH86
03/1000	UHF	MARLIN 01 HAS Been PICKED UP / FE STILL ON GRND / PE 21 GOING IN FOR P/U OF FE NOW.
03/1013	UHF	PE 21 HAS VIZ on FE Now.
03/1014	UHF	PE 21 HAS CODEL ABOARD
03/1019	UHF	J/G 53 @ L-20 NOW / FLT SURGEON WORKING ON PAT Now
03/1022	UHF	PE 21 HAS DECLARED EMER UTILITY HYD FAILURE/ HAS BEEN CLEARED INTO MAGIC CIRCLE.
03/1054	UHF	J/G 53 @ L-98 / J/G 07427 LANDED @ CH37
03/1058	UHF	J/G 37 A/B FRM L-20 with +55 MINS QR to CH86 RoQ AMB FOR PLT
03/1100	UHF	CREW 05 LANDED CH83
03/1101	UHF	COMPRESS ADVISED MARLIN 1 & 2 IS CLOSED MARLIN 01 IS DEAD
03/1445	UHF	CAPT LARSON, SGT BRANCH OFF DUTY. NO OPEN MSNS. MAJ CROUCH, SGT KING ON DUTY.
03/1445	RR	CHOPPER - AIR AMERICA, CAPT FLETCHER, COMPRESS HOLD MOOD PLANT
A/A		A.A. Clayton WAS SHOT UP AND MADE IT TO [redacted], 20280-10227E (cont)

The radio log from the morning of the accident (page 2)

The rescue helicopter got to John after retrieving the other pilot, perhaps 45-60 minutes later, but it might have been two hours.[4] Reports indicate John was still alive when they got to him, but he died in the rescue helicopter en route to the field medical hospital.

NOTE: A high school classmate of Karl Richter did extensive research on both Karl and John. About twenty years after the accidents, I got a call in Deer Isle, Maine, our summer home, and after verifying that I was John's sister, the caller, David F McNeil, 4811 Kennedy St, Hickory, NC, quickly asked me not to hang up because he had been trying to locate me for years!

He had lots of detailed information about John's situation, including the precise location in the mountainous terrain in Laos where John had landed. In fact, he sent me a Google map with the precise longitude and latitude marked on the topographical map! He also had the recordings between the rescuing helicopter and the headquarters that had received the initial request for rescue being needed. He shared information with me for several years, sent me information our family hadn't known, and I was very appreciate of all he did to compile facts and figures from John's final moments on this earth. And most especially, all the efforts that were coordinated to have the best chance of rescuing these amazingly skilled pilots. John had said that any pilot who completed more than ten missions had to be really good. And he had completed 64. He was not just good, but very skilled, sharp, fast, and had good judgment. But this time it wasn't enough.

This helpful researcher had also located some of the rescuing crew, and one lived near our winter home in Florida. However, he had told the researcher that though he actually remembered retrieving John, he didn't want to discuss it. Those rescuers had very tough jobs, and lost lots of their guys. They risked their lives, going down into enemy territory in the midst of ground fire, hanging on suspended baskets while being pulled back into

[4] According to the accident report, "Two hours elapsed from ejection to pickup of Capt Bischoff." According to the radio log on the previous pages, the collision occurred at 8:20am and John was picked up at 10:01am.

the helicopter, and risking life and limb every time they did these missions, numerous times a day! Though I would like to have known any tidbits of personal information about John and his last words and moments of life, I can see why he might not want to relive these memories since many ended with loss of life.

I have the extensive packet of information that David McNeil compiled in 2004, including the transcription of John's rescue (SAR, Search and Rescue log), other pilots that were at Takhli at the same time, and more.

He also included a photo copy of the book *Thud Ridge* by Col. Jack Broughton... In the section on pages 246–247, he describes "the number 4 man," on his first combat mission, and says of him, "he later turned out to be one of our shiny lads." This person is my brother, John. Jack uses only first names or nicknames of pilots in this book, and I can see why: Jack retired from the Air Force in 1968 and this book was published in 1969. Most of the fellows who were lost; their fate was not yet known; and they could have been POWs. No point giving the North Vietnamese complete information about one or more of their prisoners. (The "John" who was shot down, in events described on page 246, was Major John F. O'Grady USNA '57.)

He also included relevant emails from other pilots: Gary Baker, Hank Brandli, and some of Karl Rickter's info. Also an article, "What Really Happened to Karl Richter?" He also recommended *When Thunder Rolled* by Ed Rasimus. It's about the F-105 pilots and F-105 operations, and was available from Amazon back then. Ed was with the 421st in 1966, and is on the tape "There is a Way." It was first published in 2003.

The Very Best

From Thailand John told us that any fighter pilot who had survived ten missions had to be really good. Anything more than that was not just a matter of superb skill, which obviously the pilot had or he wouldn't have made it that far, and luck. As of August 3, 1967 John had flown 64 missions. He was highly skilled, and his numerous awards to date verified that. He had

earned the Silver Star, nine Oak Leaf clusters, the Distinguished Flying Cross, and numerous other awards for precision firing as well as doggedly fighting the MiGs en route and returning from North Vietnam bombing missions. John and his crew mates were named by the Air Force "the Hallmark pilots: when you care enough to send the very best." And he was.



John's bush hat, recording his missions. Black marks indicate missions over North Vietnam; red marks indicate missions into the Hanoi area. John's service requirement was 100 missions, of which he completed 64.

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Accident Report -- History of Flight

On August 3, 1967, Marlin, a flight of 4 F-105's was
fragged against a target in North Vietnam.  Marlin
1 aborted on the take off roll.  Marlin 2, 3 and 4
became airborne at 1401L. Marlin, Capt Bischoff, the
assigned deputy flight leader, then assumed command
of the flight and became Marlin 1.  Marlin, now a
flight of 3 aircraft, proceeded to the tanker, Green
Anchor 44, and completed one air refueling sequence
in a normal manner.  Capt X, Marlin spare, acquired
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an aircraft, departed Takhli at 1424L, proceeded to Green Anchor 44, joined the flight as Marlin 4, and refueled immediately upon rendezvous. He then returned to his proper position on the right wing of Marlin 3, who was on the tanker's right wing. Marlin flight refueled on Green Anchor 44 two times. During one recycle it was noted that Marlin 3's QRC-160 pod was damaged. After an inspection of this pod by Marlin 2, and during maneuvering to return to position on the tanker, an explosion caused Capt Bischoff and Lt X Marlin 2, to eject from their aircraft. Both pilots ejected successfully at 1501L, approximately 113 NM North of Udorn, Thailand. Capt Bischoff sustained injuries on landing which were later fatal. Lt X survived XX. Both pilots were recovered approximately two hours after the ejection. The two aircraft crashed and were destroyed.

[Long paragraph (full page) redacted by the Air Force.]

III. Findings and Recommendations

Findings:

1. It is the conclusion of the Board that this accident was a mid-air collision. The primary cause was pilot error on the part of Capt Bischoff.
2. Contributing causes of the accident were:
    a) Lack of flight leadership on the part of Marlin flight lead, Capt Bischoff
    b) An unsafe condition necessitated by a combat environment which required that Capt Bischoff be prepared to perform crew duty over a 14 to 15 hour day.
    c) The materiel failure of the QRC-160 pod which began a series of events requiring actions on the part of Marlin flight out of the ordinary.

3. Additional Findings

a) Two hours elapsed from ejection to pickup of Capt Bischoff

b) Capt Bischoff did not carry any medication in his survival gear to relieve pain.

c) The emergency treatment rendered Capt Bischoff did not insure a clear airway.

[Long (half page) redacted by the Air Force.]



John's Air Force photo and Vietnam Memorial rubbing, displayed in our Maine home.

5 August 67

1. Special Order pertaining to the members of an Aircraft Investigation Team to investigate a Major Aircraft Accident, F-105D, SN61-136, 6 July 67 as reads Major X, 41st TEWS PACAF, this

sun, Position: "Safety Advisor" is amended to read "Investigating Officer" Investigative duties will take precedence over all other duties at the discretion of the Commander, 355 Tac TFtr Wg. The investigation will be conducted IAW AFR 127-4 as supplemented Auth: AFR 127-4

2. The following named personnel, organizations indicated, PACAF, with concurrence of appropriate Commander, are appointed as members of an Aircraft Accident Investigating Team to investigate a Major Aircraft Accident involving F-105D SN61-139 and F 105D SN 61-4240, which occurred 3 August 1967.

STATEMENT OF DAMAGE

Aircraft	Loss
F-105D, 61-139 (Destroyed)	$2,136,668
F-105D, 62-4240 (Destroyed)	$2,136,668
Total Loss	$4,273,336

Major, USAF
Maintenance Control Officer

Notification

My college friends and I were off for a fun long weekend from the University in Lincoln, Nebraska to Estes State Park in northwest Colorado, a ten-hour drive via Scottsbluff, Nebraska, where we were crashing for the night at the home of Ann Blackstone, one of the staff who happened to be my roommate for the previous eight weeks. Most of the staff of Freshman Summer Orientation Leaders joined in on this final hurrah of the summer. We were all campus leaders and had really bonded as a staff; this was the perfect ending to a college career and great summer job. Ann's father was a doctor, and they had a nice big house where the ten of us were happy to have a horizontal place to sleep after our last full day of work, and the the ten of cramming in two cars driving the seven hours to the Blackstones.

The next morning Dr. and Mrs. Blackstone and Ann woke me up and we were chatting in the kitchen. Soon it became apparent there was a more serious reason for getting me up than just getting to know me better. Dr. Blackstone started by saying, "Your dad called last night." I immediately said "Is he missing?" I knew it had to be about John, and the best case scenario of anything serious was that he was Missing in Action. I don't remember his exact words, but he told me that John had been Killed in Action. It was my worst nightmare, and totally unexpected. I knew John was a skillful pilot who had made many successful safe missions to North Vietnam. He had told us early in his time flying out of Thailand that anybody who had ten or more missions was really good or they wouldn't have survived. And now he was one of those who wasn't coming home.

I was overwhelmed and crying. At some point Dr. Blackstone gave me a pill to help calm me. I gathered my belongings and they took me to the Scottsbluff airport, where they had already made a plane reservation for me to fly back to Lincoln. I have few memories of that trip, but I do remember handing my boarding pass to the attendant and she told me I was at the wrong gate for Lincoln. That pill had fuzzied my brain. I finally did get on the right plane.

I don't remember, but I must have gotten a cab back to the University parking lot to get my car. I drove the fifty miles southeast to my parents' home, but not before I found myself driving at full speed on the highway on the LEFT side of the road. Clearly I was in no shape to be driving, but driving I had to do. Then I was scared. I realized it was a dangerous situation, and told myself out loud that I couldn't have an accident and die, since my parents had just lost their only other child. Mind over matter, I made it home safely.

Much of the rest of the next few days is a blur. I remember many family and friends coming by. My father shared a single sheet of paper that the air force officers had given him that briefly described the situation in which John was killed. Depressing to think that an entire life ended up summarized



DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE
HEADQUARTERS PACIFIC AIR FORCES
APO SAN FRANCISCO 96553

OFFICE OF THE COMMANDER IN CHIEF

2 8 AUG 1967

Mr. & Mrs. Arnold F. Bischoff
Tecumseh, Nebraska

Dear Mr. & Mrs. Bischoff

The officers and men of the Pacific Air Forces join me in extending to you our deepest sympathy on the death of your son, Captain John W. Bischoff.

I realize that words of condolence cannot alleviate the grief you and your family feel in this time of sorrow. I hope you will derive some measure of comfort from the knowledge that your son gave his life in the service of his country. As a member of the United States Air Force, he has contributed to the all-important mission of preserving our heritage with honor, and you may be justly proud of his part in this national endeavor. His loss will be keenly felt by all of us, for the real strength of the Air Force lies in men such as your son.

If in the difficult days that lie ahead I can be of any assistance to you, do not hesitate to write me.

Sincerely

JOHN D. RYAN, General, USAF
Commander in Chief

The official letter from the Air Force

on one single piece of paper. Twenty-five years of raising an outstanding young man. THE END.

The day starts early in Thailand, so it was still the afternoon

of August 3rd in Nebraska when the air force officers came from Omaha to tell my parents the terrible news that John had been killed. Of course I was off on my big carefree weekend to Colorado, so I wasn't there, and got some of the story; through the years, I only asked for some of the details, and now there are so many more questions I wish I had asked.

My parents were grinding feed in the corn crib south of our beautifully kept big two-story white frame house, six miles south of Tecumseh, Nebraska. We later learned the air force had contacted the local sheriff to find out where we lived. It so happens the sheriff used to haul cattle to market, and he had often been on our place to get cattle, so he knew the area well.

When my dad saw the black car in our yard, he told my mother, "Something happened to John." Thoughts of John were never far from any of us, even though he was half way around the world.

Just good backbone-of-the-country, hard-working farmers who had done a fine job raising a skilled and brilliant son, and now that life with so much potential was over. Just like that.

I never asked for details of how they were notified. After introductions, did they share the bad news right there in the middle of the yard? Did they come in the house first? Do you do small talk before sharing the traumatic news? These two men had done this delivery of horrible news often, but I didn't ask how it transpired with my parents. Knowing my parents, they probably were a bit embarrassed that they were dressed in their everyday "farmer" clothes, but they were working. I'm sure my dad had on his blue bib overalls and lighter blue long sleeve work shirt. Mother usually had on a dress, but depending on her job that day she might have had on jeans. Most likely they were both scooping ear corn into the grinder-mixer for the twice-daily feeding of the 200 cattle my dad raised to sell when they were at the best weight, probably 700-800 pounds.

Funeral

The Air Force couldn't tell us when John's body would be returned to us so we couldn't plan the funeral, or even put out notices. All the local businesses always had a card for the just deceased on their counters. (Wherry Mortuary took care of these manually distributed notices, a labor-intensive but necessary form of communication back then.)

Nearly a week later, we got a notice that we could plan the funeral for Monday, August 13. I know my Grandma Bischoff (Mary Baum Bischoff, my Dad's mother) was relieved we were getting his body back. However, we did NOT get to see him again. I never asked, but I assumed that the air force embalmed him. We were told it was best if we didn't see him. Yes, it was a total of ten days since he had been killed, and it was summer, but I did periodically wonder if they had the right guy. And for years I thought about asking Tom A. Wherry,[5] the mortician, if it had been him – to positively identify John, since Tom had known him – and how he looked. But I never did. Even a few years ago, after nearly 50 years, I was going to ask Tom, since I knew he would remember. But I didn't, and now it's too late. Tom developed Alzheimers and passed away, so now I'll never know. I wish I'd had the courage to ask, but I didn't. Maybe it's best this way.

In the ten days of waiting for the funeral, my parents were busy contacting John's friends and family to be honorary pallbearers. The Air Force provided the casket bearers, and there was also a special escort who had accompanied John's body back, and he was helpful in answering my parents' questions.

We were able to get in touch with Leilani Jones, the stewardess that John met on his last R&R in Bangkok, and she came back to Tecumseh for his funeral and stayed at our house for several days.

Rev. Don McCall had been minister of the Presbyterian

[5] we had dated off and on for a few years, a good guy but we had no chemistry

church where John was a member, and was a good friend of John and his high school friends, so my parents hoped he would be available to do his funeral. But he had moved on, so we had the current minister do the service. The church was packed. Not only was John a star student in high school, but he was also well known in the community. (We were the only Bischoffs in the county.) And he was the first casualty of the Vietnam War in Johnson County, an area of 20 miles by 20 miles, in southeast Nebraska. We were overwhelmed with all who came to pay their respects. A tiny detail that I remember for some reason is that from where I sat in church, there were lots of visible fingerprints on John's nice picture on top of his casket. What a thing to notice! If I had seen it earlier, I should have told Wherry's to wipe them off!

What I remember most vividly is the flyover at the cemetery. It was timed perfectly, and I now realize this was no small feat since the four jet fighters out of Omaha (Offut Air Base) had to be timed for the church service, getting the funeral procession to the cemetery eight blocks away, the graveside committal service and then, just after the final words of that service, their fly-over with the one plane flying off by itself. Since John loved to fly, it was THE fitting send-off.

Aftermath

Less than three weeks later, I left home to go to Indiana University in Bloomington for my first year of graduate school. My world was full of new people and opportunities. I was driving John's car, a red Ford convertible, a perfect car for a young bachelor, 600 miles east to a college I'd never seen, and where I knew no one. I was partly in my new world – excited and anxious – and also I deeply felt that I was leaving home and was on my own. I can only imagine how my parents felt, having lost their first born a month before, and now I was leaving. We weren't a family to show much affection, and this was the first and only time that when my Dad gave me a good-bye hug, he told me he loved me.

One of the best things that happened on the first day of residential staff orientation in Bloomington was meeting Beth Benson (now Schwarzmueller). We've been friends for 50+ years, and we both remember that September. As I shared my new experiences with my mother, she kept clarifying my new friend's name. And on my 22nd birthday, September 21, Beth had a surprise party with cake and ice cream and all, thanks to my thoughtful mother. Yes, my world felt a little better.

I had a hard time with losing John, so I saw a counselor who came to the residence halls at Indiana. (He was a doctoral student, and this was part of his internship.) He was there especially for the students, but though I was on staff, I could see him too at no cost. I'd never seen a counselor for anything, but I was working through the trauma of suddenly becoming an only child. Since John was so outstanding, I had been competitive with him in a pretty positive way. He was a motivator for me, and had helped me decide to strive to make Mortar Board at the University, and I knew he was so proud of me for that. But with him gone, I felt I had to make up for all the great things he might have done. It took a while, and the talking about my situation was helpful.

Posthumous Medals



John's posthumous medals: the Air Force Commendation Medal, Air Medal, Distinguished Flying Cross and Silver Star



Receiving John's posthumous medals in April 1968

From the *Tecumseh Chieftain*:

> In ceremonies Wednesday, April 2 [1968], at Offutt Air Force Base, Captain John W. Bischoff was posthumously awarded the Air Force Commendation Medal, Air Medal (first through ninth Oak Leaf Clusters), the Distinguished Flying Cross (first through fourth Clusters) and the Silver Star. Col. Edward Crouchley, base commander, presented the awards. They were accepted by Capt. Bischoff's parents, Mr. and Mrs. Arnold F. Bischoff of Tecumseh, in the office of the base commander.

WHAT IF?

Following the "black box" experience while in Survival School in Nevada in the spring of 1964, during which John had a traumatic reaction, the doctor had expected to see him again before he was passed on to the next stage. But instead, there was a bureaucratic paperwork screw-up and John was sent on to the next base. *What if* he had been called back, and through the discussions with the doctor it was decided that he should cease the training?

The doctor made a note that he had thought he would see John again before he was transferred, because he had concerns and wanted to follow up. A red flag. And it was an important red flag that could have changed the course of his career and ultimately his life, and all of us as family and friends.

On a personal note, it would have dramatically changed my life and many decisions I made as I was becoming an adult. With his death, I suddenly became an only child. I no longer had a sibling with whom to discuss many of life's major issues. Fifty years later, I still miss him.

It would have lessened the trauma for my parents of losing their first born son, a loss they never got over. My father only lived ten years after John was killed, and the stress of the loss was always with him. My mother lived for forty years after John's death, and it was a loss that she often mentioned. She wondered what he might have been able to do in his life. We all did.

WHAT IF?

...the doctor had been able to follow up, and had determined that the stress was too much for John and that he should pursue different Air Force directions? He never would have been a fighter pilot and he wouldn't have died when he was only twenty-five.

WHAT IF?

. . . he had continued in an air force career with or without the flying? There are many non-flying positions, and he could have had a twenty-year career and then entered politics as one of his lifetime goals. He could have gone to graduate school while in the Air Force, met more important people who might have helped him in his career aspirations, and found a new home with more of the diversity and cultural stimulation that he loved. We knew he was never coming back to Nebraska, to be a farmer or otherwise. He had seen the world and wanted to enjoy other parts of it.

If he hadn't been flying to a combat zone, he would have been able to form and nourish relationships that led to marriage. He was interested in marriage, but down the line, after he had seen some of the world and lived a good single bachelor's life. He did that for several years, most happily when he was on the East Coast for a couple years. He thrived there and met women he found intellectually interesting and fun to be with.

John had women friends in San Francisco, one from Denmark, and one in Omaha. He was a good correspondent and would write them letters, but we have none of them, nor do we have any of the letters they wrote to him. When the personal effects of someone who is Killed in Action are returned via the military, apparently they don't include personal letters.

And so, more than fifty years after John was killed, there are still questions about not only details about the accident (parts are redacted), what really happened, what he did or didn't do, and what the other pilot did or didn't do. But also questions about what might have been. These are the What Ifs that will never be answered.

To close on a positive note:

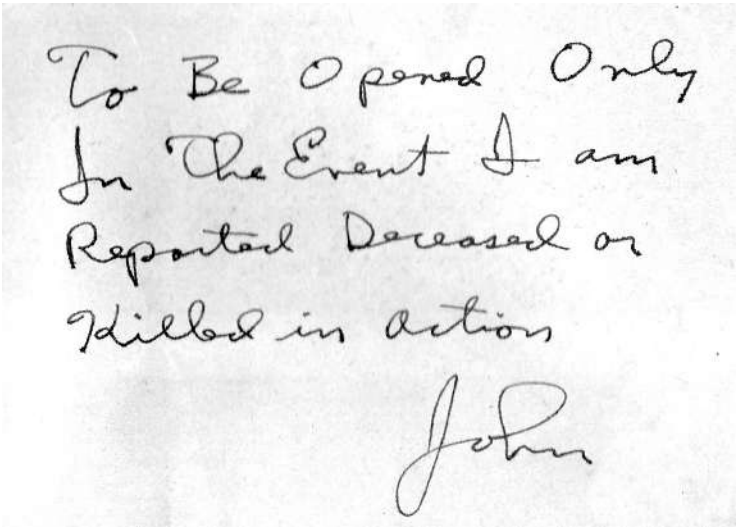
I can imagine John completing a career in the Air Force, transitioning to a career he found personally challenging and fulfilling, finding a wonderful woman with whom to share his life, raising a couple of children he adored, and enjoying a good life with all the benefits he had dreamed of. My family and I would have a close relationship with him and his family and we would all live happily ever after.

I am grateful that I had an incredible brother for twenty plus years, that he was such a positive role model for me, that he had a wonderful personality and had many good friends in high school, college, and while flying for the Air Force. He was fun to be around, and we all have warm memories of him and the good things he added to our lives. I am grateful that he loved flying and was good at it, and that his career enabled him to see much of the world. He was grateful to be traveling to exotic parts of the world that we couldn't even imagine when we were growing up on the farm. Yes, his life was much too short, but it was a life rich with experiences and relationships with his family and many friends. I am grateful.

6/16/2020

John's Final Tape

He made this tape before he left in March 1967, and left these instructions:


To Be Opened Only
In The Event I am
Reported Deceased or
Killed in Action
John

He was reported Killed in Action on Friday, August 3, 1967.

Hello
This is John.
Well I'm gone now, but it's been a good life, very good, a bit short, but very good. So I'll give a brief review as I see it in retrospective.

Childhood,
Very good, A lot of love
I was taught the virtues of hard work, thrift and very good traditional solid values of life

Lots of healthy outdoor exercise and lots of love from very appreciative parents.
There's always something special about the first-born and I would imagine I was so and it was reflected in my care, upbringing and so on.
Very good.

Grade School,
very different from many grade schools in the country but a lot paid off, got good values, virtues that will show up later in life
And a lot of the basics that are very important for which all the rest of the things are based upon, it was a very good experience in many, many respects.

High school – rather pleasant, developed really good friends, new friends and major personal growth in life took place at that time. Formative years were really very good years.

And then probably the most phenomenal change of all, the most significant, influential of all was college, especially that first year.

I joined the fraternity, probably the single most momentous decision that I ever made. Was very, very good for me.
I grew up an awful lot. Changed somewhat
I think probably in all respects for the best, it warranted a lot

of things that I hadn't thought about before. A lot of things changed.

Had a difficult first year. And did a lot of thinking about things I that hadn't thought about before, worked hard to get through all the things that were so different
And I had a lot of support from home and which was never forgotten. I was always conscious that it was there. That was probably the biggest single reason that I made it through and made it through as well as I did. Later years of college were part of orientation and development, and establishing goals and ideas thinking through a lot of things that hadn't been thought about before.

A lot of ways in life and what it is to be, was formed by that debate during this time.

And all the while there was, there was a background, a solid background that I had the continued knowledge of the support from home that meant a lot during this period.

I got involved with activities which was also very good for me. Developed my personality, meeting people
general development which hadn't been possible in a small town and small school and so on and did an awful lot for the overall personality that was to evolve.
as a result of all this college experience, and as a result of these activities, I am very thankful that the end result was a combination of my father's good looks and his charming personality and my mother's intelligence and common sense and out of all this came a
student leader and which sort of culminated in being elected president of the [fraternity] house, a very, very meaningful position, an honor and responsibility which I really enjoyed.

After that I went on to become involved in the air force
ROTC training and looked forward to an air force career

And started flying my senior year which was a wonderful experience.

And of course after graduation, there was the trip to Nantucket, which I'll never forget, I've always been grateful for.
Because I know it was a sacrifice in the time period here, so I really appreciate all that.

Went to Texas, learned to fly, a wonderful year, the second 6 months down there, probably the most fun 6 months in my entire life
and learned an awful lot and it was very, very meaningful.
But I had the headaches and I appreciated your help and support during all those things, all the problems and trials and tribulations I had as a result of that.
But as things got straightened out, solved the headaches, I felt a lot better.
It was all the result of ambition, I guess, tension
but I've been all right since.

Then I picked up the idea that I wanted to be a jet fighter pilot and really never forgot it.
I went to New Jersey, flew the C-135,
traveled, saw the world, which I'd always wanted to do.
I really lived the good life for almost 2 years, partied, had lots of fun, I spent money, shopped, bought things and I really enjoyed life which in perspective is probably the best alternative at that particular time.

And then came the 105, and the assignment and the training and going off to combat and the war.
And that's all as it should be; someone has to do it and I was glad to do my part.

I was very much interested in the airplane and all the things associated with it.
I didn't go reluctantly, I did not go reluctantly, even though I

didn't volunteer; after I got involved I really liked the airplane and I'm very very happy with what I've been doing.

So in perspective, it's been a short but very good life and I was very well brought up, and very much in appreciation of all the things that have always been done for me from home.

I have probably the most wonderful sister in the whole world. A fine charming fabulous young lady, there is no limit to what she can accomplish no matter what the field may be. And I've always appreciated very much having her to talk to. And knowing her and that's a very rewarding experience, too.

I have many friends spread all over the world. That's very good, a great deal of compensation.

But I think that all in all you should be proud of your accomplishments that you made in life and in terms of money. But probably the greatest contribution that parents can make to society and to life as they look back and review for success in their children and I think that you've done that more successfully than anybody in similar circumstances anyone could have in the world at any time.

So I'll close by saying
I've been happy
It was very good and I really enjoyed it.
I've been satisfied with life, life's been fulfilled, and I have been appreciative of my parents, of you, Carol, and of everyone who's done so much for me.

It's been a very good life,
A bit short but very good and very rewarding and that's all anyone could ask for, really.
So thank you very much for everything.

Goodbye and God Bless you.